ΕΛΛΗΝΙΚΆ · COMPANION VOLUME

Διάλεκτοι

Dialects of Modern Greek

Where the dialects came from and how to recognise them: history, classification and 11 dialect areas, with maps, feature tables, sample texts, archive recordings with transcripts, and 59 questions with answers.

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OVERVIEW

The dialect map

Ο χάρτης των διαλέκτων

Every Greek you will meet speaks Standard Modern Greek (**κοινή νεοελληνική**), but almost every region once had, and many still have, its own way of speaking. These pages take each dialect in turn: where it is spoken, how it sounds, how its grammar and words differ from the standard, and which events in Greek history (the Hellenistic **Κοινή**, Byzantine frontiers, Venetian and Ottoman rule, the population exchange of 1923) explain the differences. Start with the two overview pages, then read the dialects in any order.



Traditional dialect areas around 1900, before the population movements of the early 20th century. Dots mark representative places, not borders. Coastlines from Natural Earth (public domain).

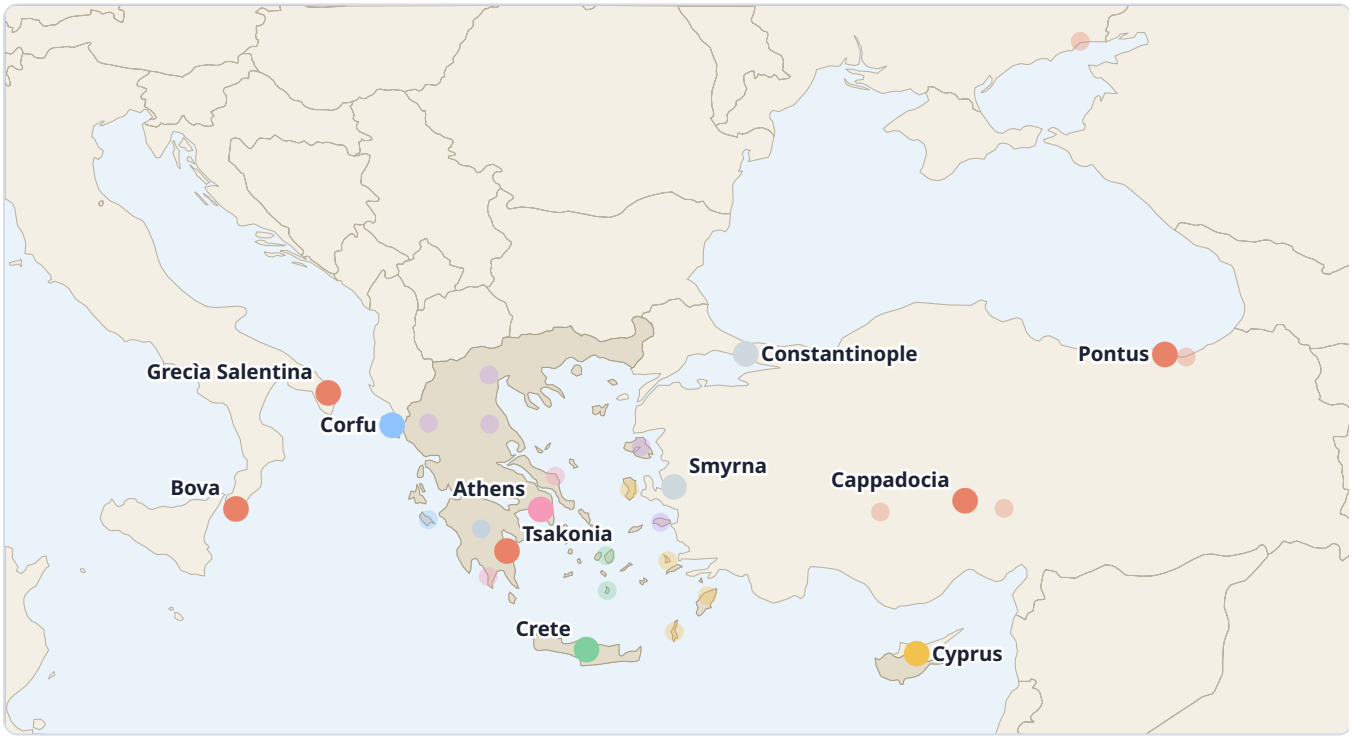
- Start here: history and classification
- Outlying dialects, hard for other Greeks to follow
- South-eastern dialects: Cyprus, Dodecanese, Chios
- Southern dialects: Crete and the Cyclades
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Από την Κοινή στις διαλέκτους

History: how one ancient Koine became many modern dialects

Greek has been written for about 3,500 years, and it has always had dialects. But the modern dialects are, with one or two exceptions, **not** the descendants of the ancient ones. Ancient Attic, Ionic, Doric and Aeolic were almost entirely replaced by a single common language, the Hellenistic **Κοινή**. The dialects you can hear today grew out of that Koine again, mostly between the 7th and 15th centuries AD, when wars, conquests and frontiers cut Greek-speaking regions off from one another. This page tells that story; the other pages show its results region by region.

KEY IDEA	Modern dialects = Koine + about 1,000 years of separate development. Exceptions: **Tsakonian** (from Laconian Doric) and possibly the Greek of **southern Italy**.
WHEN THEY FORMED	Local varieties probably took shape between the 10th and 12th centuries, after earlier isolation in the 7th–10th (Arab raids). The first texts written in dialect come from Cyprus and Crete in the 14th century.
GREEK TERMS	**διάλεκτος** = a strongly marked variety (Pontic, Tsakonian, Cappadocian, Italiot); **ιδίωμα** = a local variety close to the standard (most regional speech in Greece).
STANDARD	**Κοινή νεοελληνική** (Standard Modern Greek): spoken Demotic plus a large learned layer from Katharevousa; official in all schools since 1976.



1. Ancient dialects and their disappearance · Οι αρχαίες διάλεκτοι

The oldest Greek, the Mycenaean of the Linear B tablets (from about the 14th century BC), already shows dialect differences. After the Mycenaean palaces fell, Greek split freely into the dialects we know from inscriptions and literature: **Attic** (Athens), **Ionic** (the Aegean islands and the coast of Asia Minor), **Doric** (Sparta and Laconia, Argos, Corinth, Crete, Rhodes, and colonies such as Syracuse and Taranto), **Aeolic**

(Sparta and Laconia, Argos, Corinth, Crete, Rhodes, and colonies such as Syracuse and Taranto), **Aeolic** (Lesbos, Thessaly, Boeotia), **Arcado-Cypriot** and **North-West Greek**. Colonists carried these dialects across the Mediterranean and the Black Sea, to southern Italy (**Μεγάλη Ελλάς**, Magna Graecia) and to towns such as Trapezous, today's Trabzon.

From the 5th century BC a levelling process began. The dialects of the city-states lost ground to an **Attic-Ionic Κοινή**, and Alexander's conquests and the Hellenistic kingdoms spread that Koine from Egypt to Afghanistan. Under Roman rule it became the common language of the whole eastern Mediterranean, the language of the New Testament. By late antiquity the old dialects had died out almost everywhere. The one clear survivor is the speech of Laconia, which lives on as **Tsakonian**.

> αρχ. ἡμέρα (Αττική) ~ ἀμέρα (Δωρική)
> **STANDARD:** μέρα
> 'day': Attic and Koine have η where Doric kept the old long ā. The modern standard continues the Koine form; Tsakonian keeps the Doric α in many words (α μάτη 'the mother', from Doric μάτηρ).

> αρχ. θυγάτηρ
> **STANDARD:** κόρη
> 'daughter': lost in the standard, but alive in Tsakonian as α σάτη (θ > σ, a Laconian trait).

2. Koine Greek and the birth of diglossia · Η ελληνιστική Κοινή

The Koine kept changing in speech. Vowel length was lost, the pitch accent became a stress accent, ancient **υ, οι, η, ει** gradually merged with **ι** (the change called iotacism, **ιωτακισμός**), **β, γ, δ** became fricatives, and the dative case began to retreat. Many grammar points you learn today (the stress accent, **θα** futures, **να** in place of the infinitive) are the end result of these Koine and Byzantine changes.

From the 1st century BC writers who admired classical Athens (the **Atticists**) refused to write the Koine as it was spoken and imitated 5th-century Attic instead. From then on, Greek had two layers: a natural spoken language and an archaising written one. Linguists call this **διγλωσσία** (diglossia). It lasted, in one form or another, until 1976.

3. Byzantium: frontiers, raids and the first splits · Βυζάντιο: η πρώτη διαφοροποίηση

The modern dialect map started to form when parts of the Greek-speaking world were cut off from Constantinople. Scholars cannot follow the process in detail, because people wrote in learned Greek, not in their local speech. What is known points to long periods of isolation.

6th–8th c.
Slavic groups settle across much of the Balkans and the Peloponnese. Greek is later restored there, but the old local continuity is broken in many places.

7th–10th c.
Arab raids. **Cyprus** is shared between Byzantium and the Caliphate from the late 7th century until 965. The **Pontus** is a frontier zone. The **Dodecanese** are long a no man's land between Byzantium and the Arabs. These isolated centuries are where scholars place the start of Cypriot, Pontic and Dodecanesian distinctiveness.

c. 824–961
Crete is an Arab emirate, out of contact with the rest of the Greek world, until Nikephoros Phokas retakes it.

1071
Byzantine defeat at Manzikert. Seljuk Turks take central Anatolia, and **Cappadocia** is cut off from the Greek world. Cappadocian develops under Turkish influence from here on.

10th–12th c.
The period when, many scholars think, the main local varieties were formed out of Medieval Greek.

4. Latin rule: Venetians, Franks and Lusignans · Φραγκοκρατία και Βενετοκρατία

After the Fourth Crusade took Constantinople in **1204**, much of the Greek world passed to Latin rulers. Where Greek was no longer the language of a Byzantine court and church administration, people began to **write their own dialect**: the first dialect texts come from these Latin-ruled areas. Italian (above all Venetian) and Old French words entered the local speech, which is why island dialects are full of Romance loans that the mainland lacks.

1192–1489
Cyprus under the Lusignan kings. Legal texts (the Assizes, 14th c.) and the chronicle of Leontios Machairas (15th c.) are written in Cypriot. Old French loanwords enter the dialect.

1204–1461
The **Empire of Trebizond** rules the Pontic coast, independent of Constantinople, until the Ottomans take it in 1461.

1211–1669
Crete under Venice. The Cretan Renaissance (16th–17th c.) produces drama and poetry in Cretan dialect, above all Kornaros's **Ερωτόκριτος** (c. 1600).

13th–17th c.
Venetian and other Latin lords in the **Cyclades** (the Duchy of the Archipelago at Naxos). Catholic communities on Syros, Tinos and Naxos; Italian loans in the island dialects.

1386–1797
Corfu under Venice (the other Ionian Islands from the 15th–16th c.). The Ionian Islands largely escape Ottoman rule; Italian is the language of the elite.

14th–15th c.
Albanian-speaking (Arvanite) settlers fill much of Attica, Boeotia, southern Euboea and the Peloponnese. Greek survives in pockets such as Athens, Megara, Aegina and Kymi, the later **Old Athenian** group.

5. The Ottoman centuries · Τουρκοκρατία

Constantinople fell in **1453**; Trebizond in 1461; Rhodes in 1522; Cyprus in 1571; Crete in 1669. For three to four centuries most Greek speakers lived in the Ottoman Empire, where the Orthodox Church, not the language, defined who was 'Greek' (**Ρωμιός**, from Byzantine 'Roman'). That is why speakers of Pontic call their language **Ρωμαίικα** and why many Orthodox Christians in central Anatolia spoke Turkish (Karamanli Turkish, written in Greek letters).

Turkish loanwords entered every dialect, especially in vocabulary for food, crafts, clothes and administration (**καφές, τζάμι, μπογιά, κιόσκι, χαλάλι**). In the interior of Asia Minor the influence went much further, into sounds and grammar, as Cappadocian shows. The written language stayed archaising: the Church and the educated Phanariot families of Constantinople used a learned Greek with essentially modern syntax.

6. The new state and the Language Question · Το γλωσσικό ζήτημα

When the Greek state was founded (independence won 1821–1830, Athens capital from 1834), it needed a national language. Two answers competed. **Καθαρεύουσα** ('the purifying one'), shaped by Adamantios Korais's 'middle way', kept modern syntax but restored ancient words and endings; it became the language of the state, schools, church and press. **Δημοτική** ('the people's language') was the spoken

language; poets such as Dionysios Solomos (from Zakynthos) wrote in it, and Yannis Psycharis's book **Το ταξίδι μου** (1888) made its use a cause.

The spoken standard itself formed in Athens, where people from every region met. Since the old local Athenian dialect was already giving way, the new urban speech levelled the regional differences. Its base is southern: it has southern vowels, the genitive (not accusative) for indirect objects, and grammar close to that of the Peloponnese and the Ionian Islands, though recent research argues that the Peloponnesian dialects may look standard partly because they converged early on Athenian speech, rather than the other way round. The fight over the two forms lasted through the 20th century and was settled after the fall of the junta: **Law 309/1976** made Demotic the language of education and of the state, and the **monotonic** accent system followed in **1982**. Today's standard is Demotic with a large learned layer taken from Katharevousa (words such as **επιπλέον, εντούτοις, υπό, εν τω μεταξύ**).

> Καθαρεύουσα: Ο οίκος ούτος ανήκει εις τον πατέρα μου.
> **STANDARD:** Αυτό το σπίτι ανήκει στον πατέρα μου.
> This house belongs to my father: the same sentence in purist and standard form.

7. 1923: the population exchange and the end of the old map · Η ανταλλαγή των πληθυσμών

The Balkan Wars (1912–13) added Macedonia, Epirus, Crete and the North Aegean islands to Greece. Then came the Greco-Turkish war and the Asia Minor Catastrophe of 1922. The **Convention of Lausanne** (30 January 1923) ordered a compulsory exchange: about 1.2 million Orthodox Christians left Anatolia and Eastern Thrace for Greece, and about 400,000 Muslims left Greece for Turkey. Religion, not language, decided who moved: Turkish-speaking Christians came to Greece, and Greek-speaking Muslims (Cretan Muslims, some Pontic speakers) went to Turkey or stayed there.

For the dialects this was decisive. Pontic, Cappadocian, Pharasiot, Silliot, Smyrniot and the Greek of Constantinople's hinterland lost their homelands. Refugees were settled in Macedonia, Thrace and around Athens, where the next generations shifted to the standard. Only Pontic still has large numbers of speakers. The Greek of Istanbul survived among the community exempted from the exchange, now very small.

- **Smyrna** (İzmir) had an urban Greek with French and Italian loans and some local forms of the article; it is not one of Trudgill's dialects with the six key features (see the classification page).
- **Constantinopolitan Greek** (**Πολίτικα**) is close to the standard but has its own loans (Turkish, French, Italian), a dark **λ**, and semi-northern vowel loss.
- **Dodecanese**: Italian rule 1912–1943; joined to Greece by the 1947 Treaty of Paris (formally 1948).
- **Cyprus**: British 1878–1960, independent since 1960; Cypriot Greek coexists with Standard Greek and English.

8. Dialects today · Οι διάλεκτοι σήμερα

Radio, television, schooling and migration to the cities have shrunk most dialects to an accent, a few words and some grammar habits. Cypriot is the exception: it is everyone's everyday language on the island. Cretan is vigorous in speech and song. Pontic lives on in families, associations and music, and as Romeyka in a few valleys of north-east Turkey. Tsakonian, Griko and Greko, and Cappadocian are severely endangered, with revival efforts in schools and online. When a Greek friend says **«Ίντα κάνεις;»**, **«Είντα λες;»** or **«Σε είπα!»**, you are hearing the history told on these pages.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

1. Most modern Greek dialects descend from…
   (a) the ancient dialects of each region (b) the Hellenistic Koine (c) Katharevousa

2. Which modern variety continues ancient Laconian Doric?
   (a) Pontic (b) Tsakonian (c) Cretan
3. Why did the first texts written in dialect appear in Cyprus and Crete?
   (a) They were ruled by Latin powers, outside Byzantine learned culture (b) They had no Greek schools at all (c) The Ottomans required local languages
4. What decided who moved in the 1923 population exchange?
   (a) Language (b) Religion (c) Place of birth in Greece
5. When did Demotic become the language of Greek schools and the state?
   (a) 1888 (b) 1923 (c) 1976

Glossary

Ίντα ίντα (dialect) — what? = τι (Crete, Cyprus, Aegean)

Δημοτική δημοτική — the spoken, popular language (Demotic)

διάλεκτος διάλεκτος (η) — dialect (feminine despite -ος)

διγλωσσία διγλωσσία — diglossia: a high written and a low spoken variety side by side

Είντα είντα (dialect) — what? = τι

εις εις — to, in (Katharevousa form of σε)

Ελλάς Ελλάς — learned form of Ελλάδα

θυγάτηρ θυγάτηρ — ancient 'daughter'

ιδίωμα ιδίωμα — local variety, idiom (less divergent than a διάλεκτος)

ιωτακισμός ιωτακισμός — iotacism: η, ι, υ, ει, οι all pronounced [i]

Καθαρεύουσα καθαρεύουσα — 'the purifying one': the learned written Greek of 1830–1976

Κοινή Κοινή — the Hellenistic 'common' Greek (4th c. BC – 6th c. AD)

κοινή κοινή — common; η κοινή νεοελληνική = Standard Modern Greek

μάτη μάτη (Tsakonian) — mother, from Doric μάτηρ

Μεγάλη μεγάλος — great; Μεγάλη Ελλάς = Magna Graecia, the Greek colonies of southern Italy

νεοελληνική νεοελληνικός — Modern Greek (adj.)

οίκος οίκος — house (learned)

ούτος ούτος — this (Katharevousa)

Ρωμαίικα ρωμαίικα — Greek, lit. 'Roman (language)'; Pontic speakers' name for their dialect

Ρωμιός Ρωμιός — Greek (Orthodox), lit. 'Roman', the Byzantine self-name

σάτη σάτη (Tsakonian) — daughter, from θυγάτηρ

Σε σε — you (acc.); northern «σε είπα» = standard «σου είπα» 'I told you'

ἀμέρα ἀμέρα — ancient Doric 'day'

ἡμέρα ἡμέρα — ancient Attic 'day'

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Ο χάρτης των διαλέκτων

Classification: the six features that divide the dialect map

There is no single official map of Greek dialects, and Greek dialectology has never had a national atlas. The most widely used classification today is Peter Trudgill's (2003), built on the work of Nikolaos Kontosopoulos and Brian Newton. It sorts the traditional dialects of about 1820–1920, the period before the population movements, by six features you can actually hear. Learn these six and you can place most Greek accents on the map.

MAIN SPLIT	**North vs south**, first noticed by Georgios Hatzidakis in the 1890s: the north drops unstressed **ι, ου** and raises unstressed **ε, ο**; the south keeps all five vowels.
A SECOND SPLIT	**«τι» Greece vs «είντα» Greece** (Kontosopoulos): most Aegean islands, Crete and Cyprus say **ίντα/είντα** for 'what?'.
OUTSIDE THE MAP	Pontic, Cappadocian, Tsakonian and Italiot Greek are so different that they are treated separately, as **διάλεκτοι** in the strict sense.
NO LOCAL DIALECT	Attica, Boeotia and much of the north-east Peloponnese were largely Arvanite (Albanian-speaking) until the 19th–20th c.; their Greek today is near-standard.



Feature 1: northern vocalism (high vowel loss) · Βόρειος φωνηεντισμός

In the north, unstressed **ι** and **ου** disappear and unstressed **ε** and **ο** are raised to **ι** and **ου**. A standard word like **παιδί** becomes **πιδί**, **χωράφι** becomes **χουράφ'**, and Thessaloniki sounds like *Θισαλουνίκ'*. Kontosopoulos distinguishes three degrees: **extreme northern** (both changes everywhere), **northern** (raising everywhere, deletion only at the end of words) and **semi-northern** (only final **ι, ου** deleted, no raising: Lefkada, Mykonos, Skyros, Kastoria, Constantinople).

> σκλι
> **STANDARD:** σκυλί
> dog: unstressed υ [i] deleted

> πιδί
> **STANDARD:** παιδί
> child: unstressed αι [e] raised to [i]

> χουράφ'
> **STANDARD:** χωράφι
> field: ω [o] raised to [u], final ι lost

Feature 2: ancient υ pronounced [u] · Το υ ως ου

Everywhere else ancient **υ** and **οι** became [i]. A few areas have [u] instead, as in **ξούλο** for **ξύλο**, **γουναίκα** for **γυναίκα**. They are Tsakonian, Mani, and four extinct 'oasis' dialects inside the old Arvanite area: Old Athenian, Megara, Aegina and Kymi. Trudgill's conclusion: these four are the last fragments of one large dialect area that was split apart when Albanian-speaking settlers moved in.

Feature 3: palatalisation of velars · Ουράνωση των υπερωικών

All Greek fronts **κ, γ, χ** before **ε, ι** (standard **και** is [ce], not [ke]). In the south this goes much further, to *ch*- and *sh*-like sounds: **και** [tʃe] or [tɕe], **χέρι** [ʃeri]. Cyprus has the palato-alveolar [tʃ, ʃ]; Crete has the softer alveolo-palatal [tɕ, ɕ]. The area: Crete, Mani, Kythera, Santorini, Milos and other southern islands, much of the Dodecanese, Cyprus, and Kymi in Euboea.

Feature 4: tsitakismos · Τσιτακισμός

Just north of the palatalisation zone, **κ** before **ε, ι** went all the way to **τσ** [ts], so that it merged with the old τσ: **τσαι** for **και**, **τσεφάλι** for **κεφάλι**. This is the classic sound of most of the **Cyclades**, and it was shared by Old Athenian, Megara and Aegina.

> αυλάτσι, τσέρατο
> **STANDARD:** αυλάκι, κέρατο
> furrow, horn (Cyclades)

Feature 5: double consonants · Τα διπλά σύμφωνα

Standard Greek writes **λλ, μμ, ττ** but pronounces them single. The south-east keeps them long, as in Ancient Greek, and even creates new ones, including at the start of words. In Cypriot **φύλλα** 'leaves' and **φίλα** 'kiss!' differ only in the length of λ; **ναι** 'yes' is said [nːe]. Long **ππ, ττ, κκ** are heard as aspirated: **κόκκαλον** [kókʰalon].

Feature 6: final -ν kept · Το τελικό -ν

The standard has lost the final **-ν** of many ancient endings (**είπε, τυρί**). The south-east keeps it, and adds it by analogy: **είπεν, τυρίν, χαρτίν, βουνόν**. Before another consonant it often assimilates and produces a new double consonant: **τον λαό** → [tolːaón].

Fourteen areas · Δεκατέσσερις περιοχές

Combining the six features, Trudgill divides the dialect-speaking area of about 1900 into fourteen areas. A ✓ means the feature is typical of the area.

Area	Northern vowels	υ as [u]	Velar palatalisation	Tsitakismos	Double consonants	Final -ν
1 Central: Peloponnese, W Epirus, Corfu, Kefalonia, Zakynthos	–	–	–	–	–	–
2 Northern: mainland north, Lefkada, N Euboea, Lesbos, Lemnos, Thasos, Sporades…	✓	–	–	–	–	–
2a Samos	✓	–	–	–	–	–
3 Mani	–	✓	✓	–	–	–
4 Tsakonian	–	✓	(own system)	(own system)	–	–
5 Old Athenian: Athens, Megara, Aegina	–	✓	–	✓	–	–
6 Kymi	–	✓	✓	–	–	–
7 Southern: Crete, Kythera, Santorini, probably Milos, Anafi	–	–	✓	–	–	–
8 South-eastern: Cyprus, Rhodes, Karpathos, Kasos, Kastellorizo, Kos, Leros, Patmos	–	–	✓	–	✓	✓
9 Eastern: Symi, Tilos, Nisyros, Kalymnos, Astypalaia, Ikaria, Chios	–	–	–	–	✓	✓
10 Smyrna	–	–	–	–	–	–
11 Central Cyclades: Amorgos, Irakleia, Schinoussa, Koufonisia, Donoussa	–	–	–	✓	✓	✓
12 Western Cyclades: Sifnos, Kimolos, Serifos	–	–	✓	–	✓	–
13 Mykonos	✓ (semi)	–	–	✓	–	–
14 Northern Cyclades: Andros, Tinos, Kea, Kythnos, Syros, Naxos, Paros, Ios, Folegandros…	–	–	–	✓	–	–

Area 1, with none of the six features, is where the base of the standard language lies (see the Peloponnese–Ionian page). Smyrna (area 10) had its own peculiarities, but none of these six.

Other features worth knowing · Άλλα γνωρίσματα

- **«ίντα» for «τι»** in most Aegean islands (not Rhodes, Lemnos, Thasos, the Sporades or Andros), Crete and Cyprus; Pontic has **ντο**.

- **Indirect objects in the accusative** in the north (and in Constantinople, Smyrna, Rhodes and Inner Mani): **σε λέω** for **σου λέω**, **τον έδωσα** for **του έδωσα**. The south uses the genitive, like the standard.
- **Dark λ** [ɬ] before **α, ο, ου** in Macedonia, Epirus and other northern areas.
- **Loss of γ, δ, β between vowels** in many Aegean islands, especially the Dodecanese and Cyclades: **μεάλο** for **μεγάλο**, **πρόατο** for **πρόβατο**.
- **No synizesis**: in Pontic, Griko, Old Athenian and some southern areas, **-ία, -έα** stay two syllables: **παιδία, φωλέα** for **παιδιά, φωλιά**.
- **Clitics after the verb** (**θωρώ σε, είπα σου**) in Crete, Cyprus, the Cyclades, Pontic and Cappadocian, where the standard puts them before (**σε βλέπω, σου είπα**).

Greek outside the map · Ελληνικά εκτός χάρτη

Besides the four outlying dialects with their own pages, Greek has been spoken in many smaller enclaves: **Cargèse** in Corsica (descendants of settlers from Mani who reached Corsica in 1676; the dialect died out in the 20th century), Greek-speaking Muslims of Cretan origin in **al-Hamidiyah** (Syria) and Lebanon, the Romaniote Jews' **Yevanic** (Judeo-Greek), and the Greek of the diaspora in Australia, the United States and Germany, now with its own loanwords (in Australia **το κάρο, το φλόρι, η μπάνκα, το μπούκο** for car, floor, bank, book).

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

6. A speaker says **πιδί** and **χουράφ'**. Which area are they most likely from?
   (a) Crete (b) Macedonia or Thessaly (c) Cyprus
7. Which feature unites Old Athenian, Mani and Tsakonian?
   (a) Final -ν (b) υ pronounced [u] (c) Northern vowels
8. **τσαι** for **και** with a plain [ts] sound is called…
   (a) tsitakismos (b) gemination (c) synizesis
9. Which area has double consonants **and** final -ν **and** velar palatalisation?
   (a) South-eastern (Cyprus, Rhodes, Karpathos…) (b) Central (Peloponnese) (c) Northern Cyclades

Glossary

ίντα ίντα (Aegean, Crete, Cyprus) — what? = τι

αυλάτσι αυλάτσι (Cyclades) — furrow = αυλάκι

βουνόν βουνόν (Cypriot) — mountain = βουνό

γουναίκα γουναίκα (Mani, Old Athenian, Tsakonian) — woman = γυναίκα

είπεν είπεν (south-east) — he/she said = είπε

θωρώ θωρώ (Crete, Cyprus) — I see = βλέπω

κάρο κάρο — cart (standard); car (Greek-Australian)

κόκκαλον κόκκαλον (Cypriot) — bone = κόκαλο

μεάλο μεάλο (Aegean islands) — big = μεγάλο

μπάνκα μπάνκα (Greek-Australian) — bank = τράπεζα

μπούκο μπούκο (Greek-Australian) — book = βιβλίο

ντο ντο (Pontic) — what? = τι

ξούλο ξούλο (Mani, Old Athenian) — wood = ξύλο

παιδία παιδία (dialects without synizesis) — children = παιδιά

πιδί πιδί (northern) — child = παιδί

πρόατο πρόατο (Dodecanese) — sheep = πρόβατο

σκλι σκλι (northern) — dog = σκυλί

τσέρατο τσέρατο (Cyclades) — horn = κέρατο

τσαι τσαι (Cyclades, Crete) — and = και

τσεφάλι τσεφάλι (Cyclades) — head = κεφάλι

τυρίν τυρίν (south-east) — cheese = τυρί

φλόρι φλόρι (Greek-Australian) — floor = πάτωμα

φωλέα φωλέα (dialects without synizesis) — nest = φωλιά

χαρτίν χαρτίν (south-east) — paper = χαρτί

χουράφ' χουράφ' (northern) — field = χωράφι

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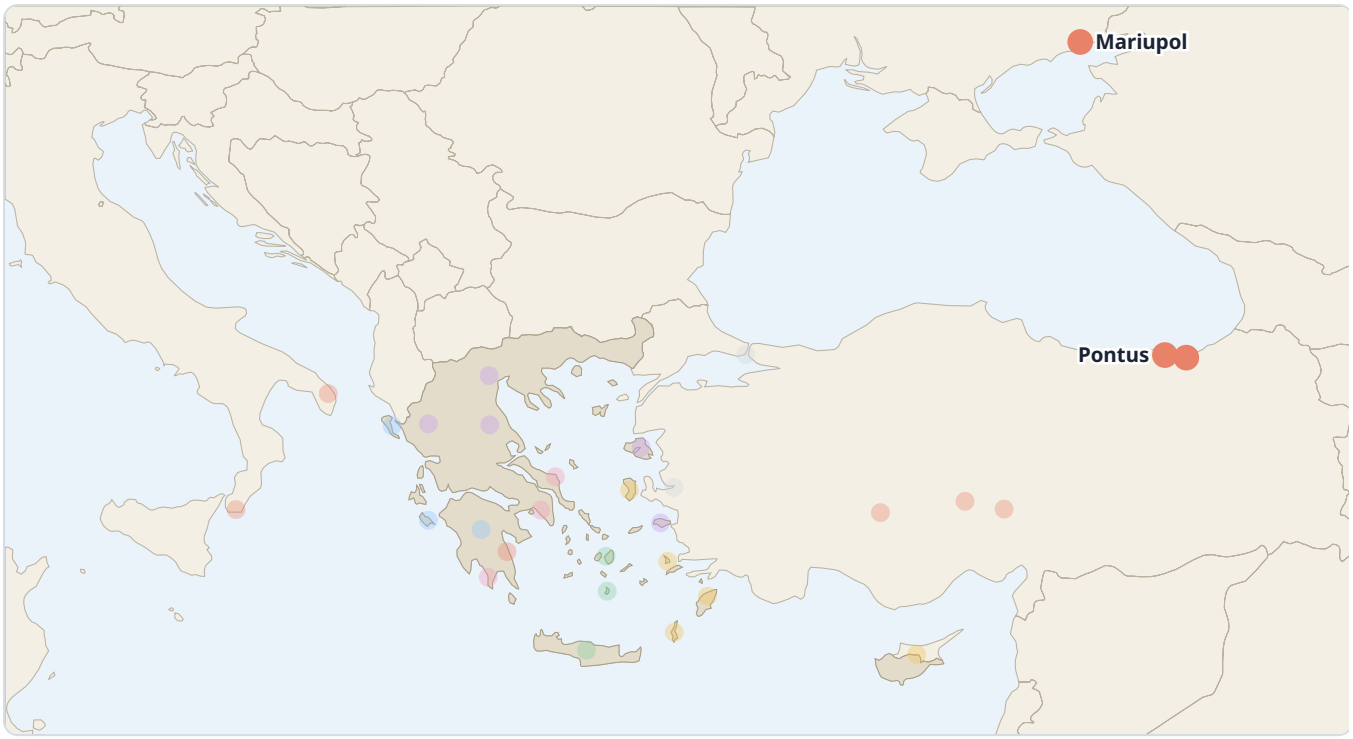
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Ποντιακά

Pontic Greek (Romeyka): the Black Sea dialect

Pontic Greek was spoken along the south-eastern coast of the Black Sea, the ancient **Πόντος**, in some 800 towns and villages stretching about 400 km from İnebolu in the west to the edge of Georgia in the east, and up to 100 km inland. Its speakers called it **Ρωμαίικα** ('Roman', i.e. Byzantine Greek), sometimes **Λαζικά**; Greeks today call it **Ποντιακά**. After 1923 almost all its Christian speakers came to Greece, where Pontic is still the most widely spoken of the strongly divergent dialects, kept alive in families, music and dance. A Muslim variety, Romeyka, survives in the valleys east of Trabzon.

WHERE	Historically the Pontus (Trabzon, Of, Sürmene, Giresun, Samsun, the mining district of Gümüşhane/Argyroupolis); after 1923 mainly Macedonia, Thrace and Attica. Earlier migrations to Georgia, southern Russia (Stavropol, Krasnodar) and Ukraine.
SPEAKERS	Estimates for Greece range from about 200,000 to 400,000 people with some knowledge, most of them bilingual and many second-generation; a few thousand Romeyka speakers in Turkey (estimates vary widely).
STATUS	No official status in Greece. UNESCO: 'definitely endangered'.
ANCESTOR	Hellenistic Koine of Asia Minor, isolated from the 7th–8th c. on; independent Empire of Trebizond 1204–1461.
MAIN GROUPS	**Τραπεζουντιακά** (Trebizond, Matsouka, Santa, Chaldia, Of), **Οινουντιακά** (Oinoe/Ünye, closer to the standard), **Χαλδιώτικα** (inland, more Turkish influence). Mariupolitan (**Ρουμέικα**) in Ukraine descends from the related Crimean Greek.
WRITING	Greek alphabet with extra marks: **ǒ, ζ, ξ, ψ** for [ʃ ʒ kʃ pʃ] and **ä, ö** for [æ ø]; Latin letters in Turkey, Cyrillic in the former USSR.



Where Pontic comes from · Ιστορία

8th–6th c. BC
Ionian Greeks from Miletus and its colony Sinope found trading towns on the southern Black Sea coast, among them **Τραπεζούς** (Trabzon).

Hellenistic & Roman
The Koine spreads inland. Pontic, like other Asia Minor varieties, grows out of the local Koine, not out of ancient Ionic.

7th–8th c.
Arab invasions and a frontier way of life cut the Pontus off from the Greek west. Scholars place the start of Pontic's divergence here.

1204–1461
The **Empire of Trebizond** under the Grand Komnenoi, independent of Constantinople. No Pontic texts survive; the dialect was oral.

1461–1923
Ottoman rule. In the 17th–19th c. many villages of the **Of** valley convert to Islam but keep their Greek. From the 18th c. many Christians move to the Russian Empire (Georgia, the Caucasus, southern Russia).

1916–1923
Deportations and massacres of the Pontic Greeks during the First World War and the Turkish national war; Greece commemorates them on **19 May**. The 1923 exchange brings the survivors to Greece.

1928 →
The **Επιτροπή Ποντιακών Μελετών** and its journal **Αρχείον Πόντου** start the systematic recording of the dialect. A second wave of Pontic speakers arrives from the former Soviet Union in the 1990s.

Sounds · Φωνολογία

Feature	Pontic	Standard
Ancient η often kept as [e], not [i]	**νύφε, κλέφτες, Γιάννες**	νύφη, κλέφτης, Γιάννης

ω kept as [o] where Koine had ου	**ζωμίν**	ζουμί
Ionic σπ for Koine σφ	**σποντύλιν**	σφόνδυλος (vertebra)
No synizesis: ια, ιο → [æ], [ø]; or two syllables	**βασιλάδες** [vasi'læðes], **τελöνω**; **φωλέα, παιδία**	βασιλιάδες, τελειώνω; φωλιά, παιδιά
Unstressed ι, ου dropped (like the semi-northern dialects)	**πεγάδ', κόρ'**	πηγάδι, κόρη
Final -ν kept, and added by analogy	**πόρταν, τραπέζιν, χώμαν**	πόρτα, τραπέζι, χώμα
Stress can fall 4–5 syllables from the end, with a second stress	long verb forms such as 'we sleep'	three-syllable rule

Nouns and pronouns · Ονοματικό σύστημα

Feature	Pontic	Standard
Masculine -ος nouns end in -ον, with genitive -ονος	**ο λύκον, τη λύκονος; ο πάππον; ο Τούρκον, τη Τούρκονος**	ο λύκος, του λύκου; ο παππούς; ο Τούρκος
One genitive article **τη** for all genders	**τη Τούρκονος, τη γαρής, τη χωραφί**	του Τούρκου, της γυναίκας, του χωραφιού
Neuter diminutives in -ιν (ancient -ιον)	**παιδίν, χωρίν**	παιδί, χωριό
Productive feminine suffix -έσσα	**ορφανέσσα**	ορφανή
Diminutive suffix -όπον	**κορτσόπον, πουλόπον**	κοριτσάκι, πουλάκι
Feminine adjectives in -ος (ancient compounds)	**η έμορφος, η άλαλος**	η όμορφη, η άλαλη
Comparison with άλλο / πολλά	**(κι) άλλο έμορφος; πολλά έμορφος**	ομορφότερος; πάρα πολύ όμορφος
Demonstrative	**αούτος / αβούτος**	αυτός

Verbs · Ρηματικό σύστημα

Feature	Pontic	Standard
'is'	**εν** (from Koine ἔνι)	είναι
Passive aorist in -θα (ancient -θην)	**εκοιμέθα, εγαπέθα, εστάθα**	κοιμήθηκα, αγαπήθηκα, στάθηκα
Imperfect of -ώ verbs in -να	**επαρακάλνα**	παρακαλούσα
Middle verbs in -ούμαι	**σκοτούμαι, στεφανούμαι**	σκοτώνομαι, στεφανώνομαι
Future without an aspect contrast (most areas)	**θα λέγω** = 'I will say' and 'I will be saying'	θα πω / θα λέω
Negation	**κι** (from ancient οὐκί)	δεν

The infinitive: alive in Romeyka · Το απαρέμφατο

Standard Greek lost the infinitive centuries ago and uses **να** + subjunctive instead (**θέλω να πάω**). The Romeyka of the Trabzon valleys still has an aorist infinitive in **-ίν(ι)** / **-είν(ι)**: **φαγείν** 'to eat', **πιείν** 'to

Romeyka of the Trabzon valleys still has an aorist infinitive in **-ιν(ι)** / **-ειν(ι)**: **φαγίνι** 'to eat', **πιείνι** 'to drink', **κόψινι** 'to cut'. Research by Ioanna Sitaridou (Cambridge) shows that it is no longer used freely: it appears only where the event does not happen, after negated past modals, after **πριν** 'before', and in some counterfactuals. Some villages of Sürmene even add person endings to it, an 'inflected infinitive' like the Portuguese one.

> ούτσ' επορέσα τρέξινι
> **STANDARD:** δεν μπόρεσα να τρέξω
> I couldn't run

> πριν δοσίνι τα παράν ο Αϊσέ
> **STANDARD:** πριν δώσει ο Αϊσέ τα λεφτά
> before Aise gives the money

> είχε ειπίνα
> **STANDARD:** αν είχα πει
> if I had said (Sürmene, inflected infinitive)

Sentences · Σύνταξη

Pontic puts weak pronouns **after** the verb, and uses the **accusative** for every object, direct or indirect (as the northern dialects do). An enclitic **-πα** marks a strongly highlighted topic; Georges Drettas, its main modern describer, links several such word-order features to contact with Turkish.

> Ντο εν αούτο;
> **STANDARD:** Τι είναι αυτό;
> What is this?

> Ντο λες με;
> **STANDARD:** Τι μου λες;
> What are you telling me?

> Έγκα σε.
> **STANDARD:** Σου έφερα.
> I brought (it to) you.

> Έδειξα 'τον το χωράφι μ'.
> **STANDARD:** Του έδειξα το χωράφι μου.
> I showed him my field.

> Είπα τον κύρη.
> **STANDARD:** Είπα στον πατέρα.
> I told father.

Words · Λεξιλόγιο

Pontic keeps many Byzantine and older words, and has borrowed from Turkish above all, but also from Armenian, Georgian, Laz and Kurdish. Some words you will hear at a Pontic **γλέντι**:

Pontic	Meaning	Note
κορτσή / πατσή	girl	standard κορίτσι
παρχάρι(α)	high summer pasture(s)	the mountain meadows where families took their flocks; a key word of Pontic song
ντο	what?	standard τι
κι	not	standard δεν
κύρης	father	Byzantine κύρης 'lord, father'
κεμεντζές	the Pontic lyra	three-stringed, played upright on the knee

Romeyka in Turkey and Mariupolitan in Ukraine · Ρωμαίικα του Όφη, Ρουμέικα της Μαριούπολης

Muslim villages of the **Of** valley and nearby (Çaykara, Dernekpazarı, Sürmene, Köprübaşı, Tonya) still speak Romeyka, mostly older people. Its speakers are Turkish citizens with Turkish national identity; the dialect keeps archaisms (the infinitive above) alongside many Turkish and Arabic loans. A closely related variety is spoken in **Νέα Τραπεζούντα** in Pieria by descendants of Christians from the same valley.

Mariupolitan Greek (**Ρουμέικα**) is spoken in villages north of the Sea of Azov. It continues the Greek of Crimea, once part of the Trebizond world; the Crimean Greeks were resettled around Mariupol by Catherine the Great after 1778. It shares Pontic's lack of synizesis but has northern-type vowel loss. (The Turkic-speaking Greeks of the same area, the **Ουρούμ**, are a different group.)

Listen: Pontic today

Recordings from the **Vanishing Languages and Cultural Heritage** (VLACH) archive of the Austrian Academy of Sciences, played from its YouTube channel and not stored in the app.

In the app these recordings play inside the page, with subtitles you can tap. Here each one is listed with its link.

Μάισσες · The witches

Ioannis Amarantidis, Oinoi (Kastoria). His grandparents came from Matsuka (Maçka) in the hills behind Trabzon. VLACH notes that his Pontic shows influence from written Modern Greek.

Watch: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EXBGL8rICIg

Listen for: κ' for 'and' but κι for 'not'; σο for 'in the'; τηρώ 'I look'; ντο 'what'; εν 'is'; the dropped final vowel in καλύβ', βράδ'.

0:12	Εν σον παρχάρ ο πάπον, λίγο τρανίτερος, En som-barχár o pápon, lígo traníteros	*My grandpa was young when he was at the summer pastures,*
0:16	κανά δεκαεφτά δεκαοχτώ χρονών, νέικον παιδί. kana ðekaeftá ðekaoχtó χronón, néïkom-beðí.	*seventeen-eighteen years, a young boy.*
0:21	Έτον σο καλύβ' το βράδ'. Éton so kalív to vrað.	*He was in the hut at night.*
0:24	Αυτά που λέω όλοι τα πιστεύαν. Aftá pu léo óli ta pistévan.	*Everybody believed these stories.*
0:28	Δηλαδή μπαίνανε στο θυμικό του ανθρώπου Ðilaðí bénane sto θimikó tu anθrópu	*They came into the human mind*

0:31	κ' τα βλέπαν κ' τα πιστεύαν. k'e ta vlépan k'e ta pistévan.	*and they saw them and they believed them.*
0:35	Απού κάποτε εξέβεν οξωκά α σο καλύβ', Apu kápote ekséven okʃoká a so kalív,	*After some time, he went out of the hut,*
0:38	με συχωρείς, να κατουρεί. me siχorís, na katurí.	*you will excuse me, to pee.*
0:40	Καπινέδες τέτοια δεν είχανε. Kapinéðes tétĭa ðen íχane.	*They did not have toilets and things like that.*
0:41	Στα καλύβια όλο το δάσος ελεύθερο. Sta kalívia ólo to ðásos eléfθero.	*Next to the huts all the forest was free.*
0:46	Μόλις εξέβεν οξωκά σο καλύβ' Mólis ekséven okʃoká so kalív	*He went just out of the hut*
0:48	ακούει απέναντι σο ορμίεν [...] akúi apénandi so ormién [...]	*and there was across the forest*
0:54	στέκ' ένα φως, ένα φωσόπολι stek éna fos, éna fosópoli	*a small light,*
0:59	κ' ακούει κ' κεμεντζέν, μουσική δηλαδή. k'e akúi k'e k'emendʒén, musik'í ðilaðí.	*and he heard a pontic lyra – music!*
1:04	«Εγώ πα», λέει, λέει, «ας πάω», λέει, «τηρώ ντο εν εκεκά». Eɣó pa, leĭ, ʎeĭ, as páo, leĭ, tiró do en ek'eká.	*Let's go to see what is down there.*
1:09	Επήα ως εκεκά. Μόλις α... Λαγγεύ', λέει, το φως, Epía os ek'eká. Mólis a. Lang'év leĭ to fos,	*I went there. The light jumped,*
1:15	πάει απέναντι, κ' ένι μουσική πάλι. paĭ apénandi k'-éni musik'í páli.	*it went across and there again I heard music.*
1:18	Τηρώ σο απέναντι πεζ, τραγωδί, λαλία ήτε γυναικείο ήτανε. Teró so apénandi pez, trayoðí lalía íte jinek'ío ítane.	*I saw it across from there. There was a song, a woman's voice.*
1:27	Λέω, θα πάω κ' εκεί. Léo, θa páo k'e ek'í.	*I said I will go there.*
1:30	Από κάποτε έρθε σο νου μ' ντο ελέν' ατον η καλομάνα. Apo kápote érθe so nu m do elén-aton i kalomána.	*Sometime it came into my mind what my grandmother said.*
1:35	Επήα εκεί, λέει, τηρώ, πάλι το ίδιο. Epía ek'i, leĭ, teró, páli to íðjo.	*I went there, I saw it, again the same.*
1:39	Κ' το φως λαγγεύ' πιο πέρα K'e to fos lang'év pço péra	*The light jumped, this time further,*
1:41	κ' η μουσική χάνεται για λίγο k'e i musik'í χánete ja líγo	*and the music was lost for a while,*
1:43	κ' ακούγεται απέναντι. k'e akúɣete apénandi.	*and then it could be heard all across the area.*
1:46	Τότε εθυμέθα κ' λέω: «Ουχ, γλήγορα!» Tóte eθimέθa k'e léo. Uχ ɣlíɣora!	*Then I remembered and said. Oh quickly!*
1:48	Τρέχ', πάει σο καλύβ'. Treʃ, paĭ so kalív.	*He ran and went into the hut.*

1:51	Μα, για. Καλομάνα έτσ' κ' αέτσ'. Ma, ja. Kalomána ets k'-aéts.	*The grandmother listened to this and that.*
1:54	«Εγώ εσέν κ' είπα σε», λέει. <Eγó esén k'-ípa se, leï.	*<What did I tell you?*
1:56	«Κι θα πας από πίσ' α σ' αείκα. K'i θa pas apo pis a s-aíka.	*You will not visit such things.*
1:59	Ατά είναι μάισσες, μάγισσες. Atá íne máises, májises.	*These are witches. Witches.*
2:02	Θα μαεύνε σε. Άλλη φορά κι θα πας.» Θa maévne-se. Áli forá k'i θa pas.>	*They will bewitch you. You will not go there again.>*
2:06	Ατσέ εποίνε σε αέτσ' η μάισσα: Atsé epíne-se aéts i máïsa	*The witch would do this to you:*
2:09	να πας, πας, πας, μετά θα εμάευες. na pas pas pas metá θa emáeves.	*she would chase after you and bewitch you.*
2:12	Δηλαδή θα σ' έπιανε κακό κ' δεν ξέρω τι. Ðilaðí θa s-épçane kakó k'e ðen kséro ti.	*Specifically, a bad person will catch you.*
2:17	Η αλήθεια είναι ότι τα πιστεύανε. I alíθïa íne óti ta pistévane.	*It is true that they believed them.*

Máises – The witches; performer: Ioannis Amarantidis; camera/interview/scientific advisor: Andreea Pascaru; transcription: Thede Kahl, Sotirios Rousiakis; translation: Sotirios Rousiakis; project coordinator: Thede Kahl; editor: Antonio Fichera; retrieved from www.oeaw.ac.at/VLACH, ID-number: pont1253GRV0009a.

We, the Pontic Greeks, love our language

Anatoli Karipidou, who translated the Iliad and the Odyssey into Pontic, on why a language survives only if it is spoken and taught.

Watch: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CoS7_c5pZyw

VLACH has not published a timed transcription of this clip, so it plays without app subtitles.

We, the Pontic Greeks, love our language; performer: Anatoli Karipidou; Vanishing Languages and Cultural Heritage (VLACH), Austrian Academy of Sciences, ID-number: pont1253GRV0011a.

Greek-script lines: the app's rendering of VLACH's phonetic transcription (shown under each line as “VLACH transcription”); English: VLACH's translation. Each transcript row gives the Greek-script line, VLACH's transcription under it, and the English.

Pontic music and memory

Pontic culture in Greece lives in its music: the **κεμεντζές** (lyra), the **νταούλι** drum, songs about exile and the lost homeland, and line dances such as **σέρρα** and **τικ**. Associations (**σύλλογοι**) in Thessaloniki, Drama, Kozani and Athens teach dances and the dialect, and comedians and singers use it on stage. The **Monastery of Panagia Soumela**, rebuilt in Vermio after 1923 and named after the original near Trabzon, is a pilgrimage site every August 15. On 19 May Greece remembers the Pontic Greeks killed in 1916–1923.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

10. In Pontic **νύφε** and **κλέφτες**, what is unusual?
(a) Ancient η is pronounced [e] (b) Final -ς is lost (c) The stress has moved

11. **Είπα τον κύρη** shows which Pontic habit?
(a) Accusative for the indirect object (b) A Turkish loanword (c) The infinitive

12. Where is the old infinitive still used?
(a) In the Romeyka of the Trabzon valleys (b) In all Pontic spoken in Greece (c) Nowhere

13. How do you say 'What is this?' in Pontic?
(a) Ίντα 'ναι τούτο; (b) Ντο εν αούτο; (c) Τι είναι αυτό;

14. Mariupolitan Greek continues the Greek of…
(a) Crimea (b) Cappadocia (c) Cyprus

Glossary

'τον 'τον = ατον (Pontic) — him (acc.) = του

άλαλος άλαλος — mute, speechless

Έγκα έγκα (Pontic) — I brought = έφερα (from ancient ἤνεγκα)

έμορφος έμορφος (Pontic, older Greek) — beautiful = όμορφος

ένι είναι — there is (Pontic)

έτον ήταν — he was (Pontic έτον)

α από — from (Pontic α σο, from the)

αέτσ έτσι — so, like this (Pontic); έτσ' κ' αέτσ', this and that

αβούτος αβούτος (Pontic) — this, he = αυτός

αείκα τέτοια — such things (Pontic)

αούτο αούτο (Pontic) — this = αυτό

αούτος αούτος (Pontic) — this, he = αυτός

απού από — from; απού κάποτε, after a while (Pontic)

Αρχείον αρχείο(ν) — archive

ατά αυτά — these (Pontic)

ατον αυτόν — him, it (Pontic)

βασιλάδες βασιλάδες (Pontic) — kings = βασιλιάδες

βράδ βράδυ — evening, night

γαρής γαρή (Pontic) — wife, woman; τη γαρής = της γυναίκας

Γιάννες Γιάννες (Pontic) — John = Γιάννης

γλέντι γλέντι — party, festivity with music and dance

γλήγορα γρήγορα — quickly

δοσίνι δοσίνι (Romeyka) — to give (infinitive)

εγαπέθα εγαπέθα (Pontic) — I was loved = αγαπήθηκα

εθυμέθα θυμάμαι — I remembered (Pontic)

ειπίνα ειπίνα (Sürmene Romeyka) — (for) me to say: inflected infinitive

εκεκά εκεί — over there (Pontic)

εκοιμέθα εκοιμέθα (Pontic) — I slept = κοιμήθηκα

εμάευες μαγεύω — you would be bewitched (Pontic)

εν είναι — is (Pontic)

εξέβεν εβγαίνω — he went out (Pontic aorist)

επήα πήγα — I went (Pontic)

επαρακάλνα επαρακάλνα (Pontic) — I was begging = παρακαλούσα

Επιτροπή επιτροπή — committee

εποίνε ποιώ — did, would do (Pontic)

επορέσα επορέσα (Romeyka) — I could = μπόρεσα

εσέν εσένα — you (Pontic)

εστάθα εστάθα (Pontic) — I stood = στάθηκα

ζωμίν ζωμίν (Pontic) — broth, juice = ζουμί

κ και — and (Pontic κ' [kʲe])

καλομάνα καλομάνα — grandmother (Pontic)

καλύβ καλύβι — hut (Pontic drops final -ι)

καπινέδες καπινές — privy, toilet (Pontic)

κεμεντζέν κεμεντζές — the Pontic lyra (accusative)

κεμεντζές κεμεντζές — the Pontic lyra

κι κι (Pontic) — not = δεν; elsewhere κι = και 'and'

κλέφτες κλέφτες (Pontic) — thief (sg.) = κλέφτης

κορτσή κορτσή (Pontic) — girl = κορίτσι

κορτσόπον κορτσόπον (Pontic) — little girl = κοριτσάκι

κόρ' κόρ' (Pontic) — daughter = κόρη

κόψινι κόψινι (Romeyka) — to cut (infinitive)

κύρη κύρης (Pontic) — father

κύρης κύρης (Pontic) — father

λέγω λέγω — I say (older form of λέω)

λαγγεύ λαγγεύω — it leaps, jumps (Pontic)

Λαζικά λαζικά — 'Laz': an older local name for Pontic (not the Kartvelian Laz language)

λαλία λαλιά — voice

λύκον λύκον (Pontic) — wolf = λύκος

λύκονος λύκονος (Pontic) — of the wolf = του λύκου

μ' μ' — my (= μου)

μάισσα μάισσα — witch (Pontic, = μάγισσα)

μάισσες μάισσα — witch (Pontic, = μάγισσα)

μαεύνε μαγεύω — they bewitch (Pontic)

με με — me (acc.); Pontic λες με = μου λες

νέικον νέος — young (Pontic)

νου νους — mind; σο νου μ', into my mind

νταούλι νταούλι — large drum

Ντο ντο (Pontic) — what? = τι

ντο ντο — what (Pontic)

νύφε νύφε (Pontic) — bride = νύφη

Οινουντιακά Οινουντιακά — the dialects of Oinoe (Ünye)

οξωκά έξω — outside (Pontic)

ορμίεν forest (VLACH translation)

ορφανέσσα ορφανέσσα (Pontic) — orphan girl = ορφανή

Ουρούμ Ουρούμ — Turkic-speaking Greeks of Crimea and Mariupol

ουχ ουχ — oh! (exclamation)

ούτσ' ούτσ' (Romeyka) — not = δεν

πάπον πάππος — grandfather (Pontic)

πάππον πάππον (Pontic) — grandfather = παππούς

πίσ πίσω — behind; από πίσ' α, after

πα πα — also, too (Pontic)

παιδία παιδία (Pontic) — children = παιδιά

παιδίν παιδίν (Pontic) — child = παιδί

παράν παράν (Romeyka) — money (Turkish para) = λεφτά

παρχάρ παρχάρ — summer mountain pasture (Pontic)

παρχάρι παρχάρι (Pontic) — high summer pasture

παρχάρια παρχάρια (Pontic) — high summer pastures

πατσή πατσή (Pontic) — girl

πεγάδ' πεγάδ' (Pontic) — well = πηγάδι

πιείνι πιείνι (Romeyka) — to drink (infinitive)

πολλά πολλά — (Pontic) very; πολλά έμορφος = very beautiful

Ποντιακά ποντιακά — Pontic Greek

πουλόπον πουλόπον (Pontic) — little bird = πουλάκι

Πόντος Πόντος — Pontus, the south-east Black Sea coast

πόρταν πόρταν (Pontic) — door = πόρτα

Ρουμέικα ρουμέικα — Mariupolitan Greek

Ρωμαίικα ρωμαίικα — 'Roman', i.e. Greek: the speakers' own name for Pontic

σέρρα σέρρα — a Pontic war dance

σε σε — you (acc.); Pontic έγκα σε = σου έφερα

σκοτούμαι σκοτούμαι (Pontic) — I get killed = σκοτώνομαι

σο σε + το — in the, to the (Pontic)

σον σε + τον — in the, to the (Pontic)

σποντύλιν σποντύλιν (Pontic) — vertebra, spindle whorl

στέκ στέκω — stands (Pontic drops final -ει)

στεφανούμαι στεφανούμαι (Pontic) — I get married = στεφανώνομαι

σύλλογοι σύλλογος — association, club

τελϋνω τελϋνω (Pontic) — I finish = τελειώνω

τη τη (Pontic) — genitive article for all genders = του/της

τηρώ τηρώ — I look, I see (Pontic)

τικ τικ — a Pontic dance

Τούρκον Τούρκον (Pontic) — Turk = Τούρκος

Τούρκονος Τούρκονος (Pontic) — of the Turk = του Τούρκου

τρέξινι τρέξινι (Romeyka) — to run (infinitive)

τρέχ τρέχει — he runs

τραγωδί τραγούδι — song (Pontic)

τρανίτερος τρανός — bigger, older (comparative)

τραπέζιν τραπέζιν (Pontic) — table = τραπέζι

Τραπεζουντιακά Τραπεζουντιακά — the Trebizond group of Pontic dialects

Τραπεζούς Τραπεζούς — ancient Trebizond (Trabzon)

φαγίνι φαγίνι (Romeyka) — to eat (infinitive)

φωλέα φωλέα (Pontic) — nest = φωλιά

φωσόπολι φως — a little light (Pontic diminutive)

Χαλδιώτικα Χαλδιώτικα — the dialects of Chaldia (inland)

χωρίν χωρίν (Pontic) — village = χωριό

χωραφί χωράφι — field; Pontic τη χωραφί = του χωραφιού

χώμαν χώμαν (Pontic) — soil = χώμα

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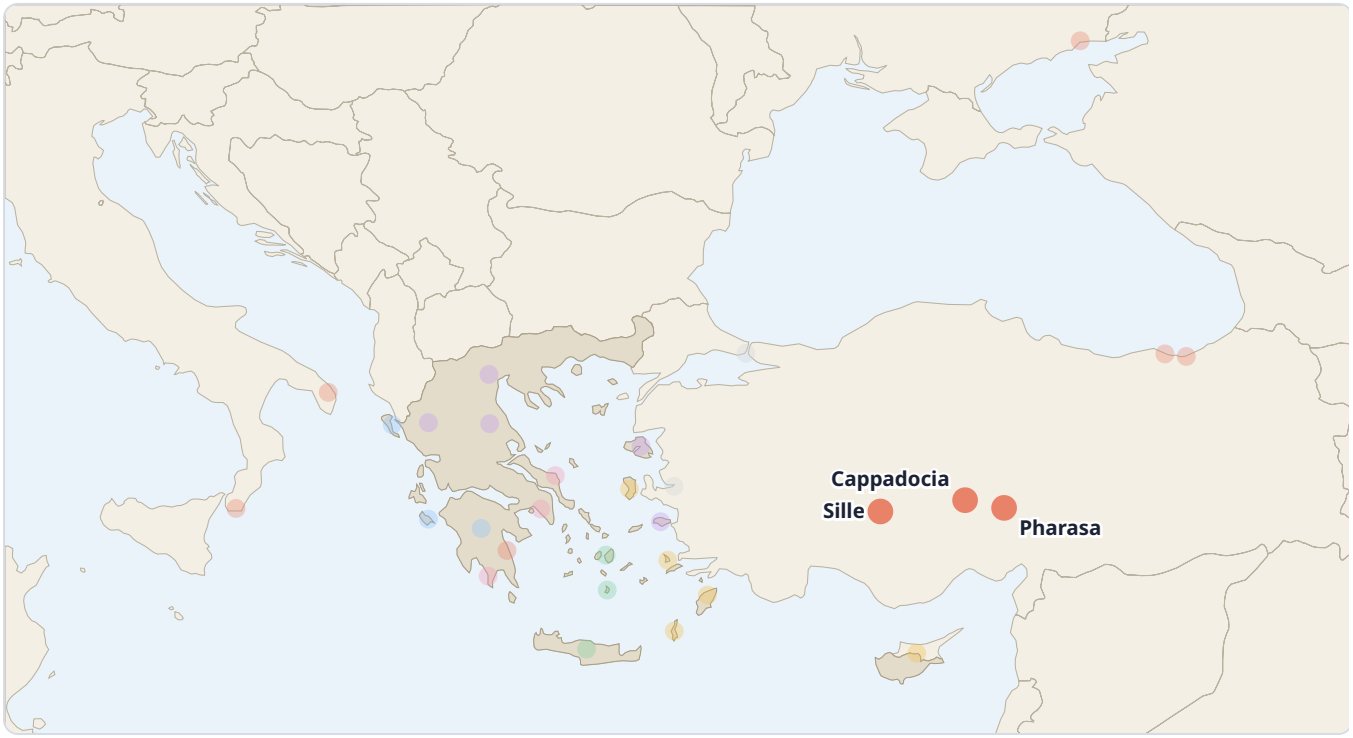
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Καππαδοκικά

Cappadocian Greek, with Pharasa and Sille: Greek under Turkish influence

Until 1923 Greek was spoken in three islands of speech deep inside Anatolia: a group of villages in **Cappadocia** (around Kayseri and Niğde), **Pharasa** and six villages in its valley to the east, and the single village of **Sille** near Konya. After nine centuries of contact with Turkish, these dialects changed more than any other form of Greek: they took Turkish vowels, vowel harmony, endings stacked one after another, and often lost grammatical gender. Nikolaos Kontosopoulos wrote that a reader of Cappadocian 'cannot tell whether it is Turkish in a Greek mouth or Greek in a Turkish mouth'. It was thought extinct by the 1960s, until in 2005 linguists found fluent speakers of the Mistiot variety in Greece.

WHERE	Before 1923: Mistí, Malakopí, Anakú, Axó, Aravaní, Ulağaç, Potamiá, Delmesó, Sinasós and other villages; Pharasa (Çamlıca near Yahyalı); Sille (near Konya, ancient Iconium). After 1923: refugee villages in central and northern Greece.
SPEAKERS	A small number of mostly older and middle-aged speakers of **Μιστιώτικα** (Mistiot), found by Mark Janse and Dimitris Papazachariou in 2005; Pharasiot has been described from speakers in Greece as recently as 2018.
ANCESTOR	Byzantine Greek of central Anatolia, cut off after the Battle of Manzikert (1071) and the Seljuk conquest.
WRITING	Unwritten for most of its history; recorded by scholars from the 19th c. on, often with extra letters (**ŏ, ζ, τŏ**) and Turkish vowels (ı, ö, ü).
NEIGHBOURS	Many Orthodox Christians of the area spoke only Turkish (the **Καραμανλήδες**, who wrote Turkish in Greek letters).



History · Ιστορία

by the 5th c. AD
The old Anatolian languages die out and central Anatolia becomes Greek-speaking. Cappadocia gives Byzantium emperors (Maurice, Heraclius) and Church Fathers (Basil of Caesarea, Gregory of Nazianzus, Gregory of Nyssa).

1071
After the defeat at **Manzikert**, Seljuk Turks take central Anatolia. Cappadocian starts to develop apart from the rest of Greek, and is never touched by the Venetian and French influence of the later Frankokratia.

13th c.
The earliest written traces: a few lines of Greek in the macaronic poems of **Jalal ad-Din Rumi** (1207–1273) in Konya and his son Sultan Walad, written in Arabic script.

Ottoman period
Many Christian communities shift to Turkish. Greek holds on in villages around Kayseri and Niğde, in Pharasa and in Sille, but changes under intense bilingualism.

1909–1911
R. M. Dawkins does fieldwork; his *Modern Greek in Asia Minor* (1916) remains the classic description of Sille, Cappadocia and Pharasa.

1923–1924
The population exchange moves all Orthodox Christians to Greece. Children are encouraged to switch to Standard Greek; the dialect retreats into families.

2005
Janse and Papazachariou find Mistiot speakers in central and northern Greece; revival work, a documentary (*Last Words*) and social-media groups follow.

Sounds · Φωνολογία

Feature	Cappadocian form	Standard
Turkish vowels and consonants	ı, ö, ü; b, d, g, š, ž, tš, dž	–
Unstressed ε, ο raised to ι, ου	**άλουγου** (Malakopí, Mistí); **έρχουμι** (Sille)	άλογο, έρχομαι
Unstressed ι, ου often dropped	**το σπίτ**, **αθρώπ**	το σπίτι, του ανθρώπου
Ancient η as [e] (Cappadocia, Pharasa, as in Pontic)	**ψελό, χελικό**	ψηλό, θηλυκό
ω as [o] where Koine had ου	**κωδώνι, ζωμί**	κουδούνι, ζουμί
κ > τ̆ before ε, ι	**τ̆ερί, τ̆ουφάλι**	κερί, κεφάλι
Vowel harmony in Turkish loan verbs	**ιστεντίζω** 'I want', **ανλαδάζω** 'I understand', **οτουρδούζω** 'I sit', **düšündűζω** 'I think'	θέλω, καταλαβαίνω, κάθομαι, σκέφτομαι

The vowel-harmony verbs show how deep the contact went: the Greek verb ending **-ίζω** takes the vowel of the Turkish stem (Turkish *istemek, anlamak, oturmak, düşünmek*), just as Turkish suffixes do.

Nouns: animacy, endings in a row, and lost gender · Ονοματικό σύστημα

Cappadocian nouns behave in ways no other Greek does. Animate and inanimate nouns decline differently, endings are added one after another as in Turkish, and in most of Cappadocia (much less in Sille) grammatical gender has almost disappeared: a woman can be **το ναίκα**. In south-western varieties

such as Ulağaç, every noun takes the neuter article **do** / **da** and neuter adjectives. A definite direct object is marked by a different form from an indefinite one, again as in Turkish.

	Animate: 'wolf'	Inanimate: 'fear'	Agglutinative: 'woman'
Nom. sg.	**λύκος**	**φόβος**	**ναίκα**
Acc. sg.	**λύκο** (definite) / **λύκος** (indefinite)	**φόβο**	**ναίκα**
Gen. sg.	**λυκι̯ού**	–	**ναίκα-ι̯ου**
Nom. pl.	**λυκ**	**φόβοζι̯α**	**ναίκες**
Gen. pl.	–	–	**ναίκεζ-ι̯ου**

> do kalon do andra · do kalon do neka · do kalon do pei
> **STANDARD:** ο καλός άντρας · η καλή γυναίκα · το καλό παιδί
> the good man · the good woman · the good child: one neuter article for all (Ulağaç)

> itó do néka do ándra-t páasen do do xorjó
> **STANDARD:** εκείνη η γυναίκα πήγε τον άντρα της στο χωριό
> 'that woman took her husband to the village', or 'that woman, her husband took her to the village': without gender and case, the sentence is ambiguous (Ulağaç, after Kesisoglou 1951)

Verbs and word order · Ρήματα και σύνταξη

Feature	Cappadocian	Standard / note
Imperfect with ancient iterative -σκ-	**τρώισκα, αφήνισκα**; Sille **σελίνοσκα**	έτρωγα, άφηνα, ήθελα
Turkish person ending added to a Greek one	**ερχουμεστινιζ**	ερχόμαστε (Turkish 1pl -iz)
Pluperfect on the Turkish model *geldi idi*	**ήρτα τον** (Delmesó), lit. 'I came I was'	είχα έρθει
Comparison without -τερος	**ετά απ' ετό μέγα νε** 'that was bigger than this'	εκείνο ήταν μεγαλύτερο από αυτό
Modifier before the noun (Turkish order)	**κουγιουμτζή εναίκας οντά**	το δωμάτιο της γυναίκας του χρυσοχόου
'And/also' after the noun	**Μαρία κι είπι**	και η Μαρία είπε
Weak pronoun after the verb	**παίρνω σας**	σας παίρνω

Word order is governed by topic and focus, but tends towards Turkish **subject–object–verb**. Turkish idioms were translated word for word: 'he did it himself' is **οπ ὅέριν dου τα ποίκι**, 'he did it with his own hand'.

Old words kept · Αρχαϊσμοί

Cut off before the Crusades, Cappadocian kept Byzantine and ancient words where the standard took Italian or new Greek ones.

Cappadocian	Meaning	Origin / standard
θίρ / tír	door	θύρα; standard πόρτα (from Italian *porta*)
ποίκα, έπκα	I did	Byzantine έποικα; standard έκανα
μό(ν), σό(ν)	my, your	ancient ἐμός, σός; standard μου, σου
φτάλμι	eye	ὀφθάλμιον; standard μάτι
ιμάτι	garment	ἱμάτιον; standard ρούχο
χουωρός	yellow	χλωρός 'pale green'; standard κίτρινος
λιπαρός	fat (person)	λιπαρός 'oily, rich'; standard χοντρός, παχύς
σπουδάζω	I hurry	ancient sense of σπουδάζω; standard βιάζομαι
κάνει	it is enough	ἱκανεῖ; standard φτάνει

Pharasa and Sille · Φαρασιώτικα και Σιλλιώτικα

- **Pharasiot** (Φάρασα and the villages of its valley) had the least Turkish influence of the three, more Armenian loanwords, and kept forms without synizesis (**μαλία, χωρίο** for **μαλλιά, χωριό**). Stressed ι can become [ie] (**λιέγο, διέχνω** for **λίγο, δείχνω**); final -ς drops before **μου** (**ο dada μου** 'my father', but **ο dadas**). Some scholars place it closer to Pontic than to Cappadocian.
- **Silliot** (Σίλλη, near Konya) was the most divergent of all. Its σ is always [ʃ], θ became σ (**σύρα** for **θύρα** 'door'), δ became ρ (**ρώρεκα** for **δώδεκα**), τ became [tʃ] before ι (**ότσι** for **ότι**). It kept gender better than Cappadocia proper.

Why did Cappadocian change so much? · Γιατί άλλαξε τόσο

Three conditions came together: very long separation from other Greek (from the 11th century), a small number of speakers in each village, and **universal bilingualism** with Turkish, the language of the state, the market and often the home. Linguists use Cappadocian as a textbook case of how far 'borrowing' can go: not just words, but sounds, word order and even the shape of endings (Thomason & Kaufman 1988). R. M. Dawkins summed it up in his often-quoted remark that in these dialects 'the body has remained Greek, but the soul has become Turkish'. Recent research (Karatsareas, Janse) shows that much of the change, such as the loss of gender, also follows inner Greek tendencies that Turkish contact accelerated.

Two voices on Cappadocian

Kontosopoulos's description, from his survey of the dialects, and the Turkish-model idiom quoted by Dawkins.

«Όποιος ακούει (ή μάλλον διαβάζει) την καππαδοκική διάλεκτο, δεν ξέρει αν έχει να κάνει με τουρκικά σε ελληνικό στόμα ή με ελληνικά σε στόμα τούρκικο.»
οπ ὅέριν dου τα ποίκι.

'Whoever hears (or rather reads) the Cappadocian dialect cannot tell whether it is Turkish in a Greek mouth or Greek in a Turkish mouth.'
'He did it with his own hand', i.e. he did it himself: a Turkish idiom in Greek words.

Κοντοσόπουλος 1994: 7, quoted on the Portal for the Greek Language; Dawkins 1916: 198–199.

Listen: Pharasa Greek

A recording from the VLACH archive of the Austrian Academy of Sciences, played from its YouTube channel and not stored in the app.

In the app these recordings play inside the page, with subtitles you can tap. Here each one is listed with its link.

The French-style chicken

Varvara Konstantinidou tells, in the Pharasa variety, how a featherless-necked hen she loved was cured with oil and raki instead of going into the pot, and how the same cure later healed her own foot.

Watch: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=33dbRBT0Yow

VLACH has not published a timed transcription of this clip, so it plays without app subtitles.

A rníθi alafránka – The French-style chicken; performer: Varvara Konstantinidou; Vanishing Languages and Cultural Heritage (VLACH), Austrian Academy of Sciences, ID-number: capp1230GRV0006a.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

5. What event cut Cappadocia off from the rest of the Greek world?
   (a) The Battle of Manzikert (1071) (b) The fall of Constantinople (1453) (c) The Fourth Crusade (1204)
6. **το ναίκα** 'the woman' shows…
   (a) loss of grammatical gender (b) a Turkish loanword (c) the ancient dual
7. Why does the verb ending change in **ανλαδάζω** vs **οτουρδούζω**?
   (a) Turkish vowel harmony (b) Stress rules (c) Northern vowel loss
8. Which old Greek word for 'door' survives in Cappadocian?
   (a) θύρα (b) πόρτα (c) κάγκελο
9. In which year were fluent Cappadocian speakers rediscovered in Greece?
   (a) 1923 (b) 1964 (c) 2005

Glossary

dada dada(s) (Pharasa) — father

düšündűžω düšündűžω (Cappadocian, Turkish düşünmek) — I think

dou dou (Cappadocian) — his = του

álougou álougou (Cappadocian) — horse = άλογο

épka épka (Cappadocian) — I did

érchoumi érchoumi (Sille) — I come = έρχομαι

írta írta (dialect) — I came = ήρθα

aθrópi aθrópi (Cappadocian) — of the person = του ανθρώπου

anladáža anladáža (Cappadocian, Turkish anlamak) — I understand

afínska afínska (Cappadocian) — I was leaving = άφηνα

diéchno diéchno (Pharasa) — I show = δείχνω

eípi eípi (Cappadocian) — said = είπε

enaíkas naíka — woman; kougioumtží enaíkas ontá = the goldsmith's wife's room

erchoumestiniž erchoumestiniž (Cappadocian) — we come = ερχόμαστε, with Turkish -iz

etá etá (Cappadocian) — that = εκείνο

etó etó (Cappadocian) — this = αυτό

zomí zomí (Cappadocian) — juice, broth = ζουμί

θír θír (Cappadocian) — door, from θύρα

i̯ou -iou (Cappadocian) — genitive suffix added to the noun

imáti imáti (Cappadocian) — garment, from ἱμάτιον

istentízω istentízω (Cappadocian, Turkish istemek) — I want = θέλω

kánei kánei — he does; Cappadocian 'it is enough' (ikanεῖ)

Kappadokiká kappadokiká — Cappadocian Greek

Karamanlídes Karamanlídes — Turkish-speaking Orthodox Christians of central Anatolia

kougioumtží kougioumtžís — goldsmith (Turkish kuyumcu) = χρυσοχόος

kodóni kodóni (Cappadocian) — bell = κουδούνι

liégo liégo (Pharasa) — little = λίγο

λιπαρός λιπαρός — oily; Cappadocian 'fat'

λυκ λυκ (Cappadocian) — wolves = λύκοι

λυκι̯ού λυκιού (Cappadocian) — of the wolf = του λύκου

λύκο λύκο — wolf (acc.); in Cappadocian the definite object form

λύκος λύκος — wolf

μέγα μέγα — big (ancient μέγας)

μαλία μαλία (Pharasa) — hair = μαλλιά

Μαρία Μαρία — Maria

Μιστιώτικα μιστιώτικα — the Greek of Mistí (Konaklı)

μό μό(ν) (Cappadocian) — my, from ancient ἐμός

ναίκα ναίκα (Cappadocian) — woman = γυναίκα

ναίκεζ ναίκεζ-ιου (Cappadocian) — of the women = των γυναικών

ναίκες ναίκες (Cappadocian) — women = γυναίκες

νε νε (Cappadocian) — was, is (copula)

οντά οντά (Turkish oda) — room = δωμάτιο

οπ οπ (Cappadocian) — with, from (= από)

οτουρδούζω οτουρδούζω (Cappadocian, Turkish oturmak) — I sit

παίρνω παίρνω — I take

ποίκα ποίκα (Cappadocian) — I did, from Byzantine έποικα

ποίκι ποίκι (Cappadocian) — he did = έκανε

ρώρεκα ρώρεκα (Sille) — twelve = δώδεκα

σ̆έριν σέριν (Cappadocian) — hand = χέρι

σας σας — you (pl.), your

σελίνοσκα σελίνοσκα (Sille) — I wanted = ήθελα

σπίτ σπίτ (Cappadocian) — house = σπίτι

σπουδάζω σπουδάζω — I study; Cappadocian 'I hurry'

σό σό(ν) (Cappadocian) — your, from ancient σός

σύρα σύρα (Sille) — door = θύρα

τα τα — them, it

τον τον — him (acc.); in Delmesó ήρτα τον 'I had come' (Turkish idi 'was')

τρώισκα τρώισκα (Cappadocian) — I was eating = έτρωγα

τ̆σερί τ̆σερί (Cappadocian) — candle = κερί

τ̆σουφάλι τ̆σουφάλι (Cappadocian) — head = κεφάλι

φτάλμι φτάλμι (Cappadocian) — eye, from ὀφθάλμιον

φόβο φόβο — fear (acc.)

φόβοζι̯α φόβοζια (Cappadocian) — fears: plural by an added suffix

φόβος φόβος — fear

χελικό χελικό (Cappadocian) — female = θηλυκό

χουωρός χουωρός (Cappadocian) — yellow, from χλωρός

χωρίο χωρίο (Pharasa) — village = χωριό

ψελό ψελό (Cappadocian) — high = ψηλό

ότ̆σι ότσι (Sille) — that = ότι

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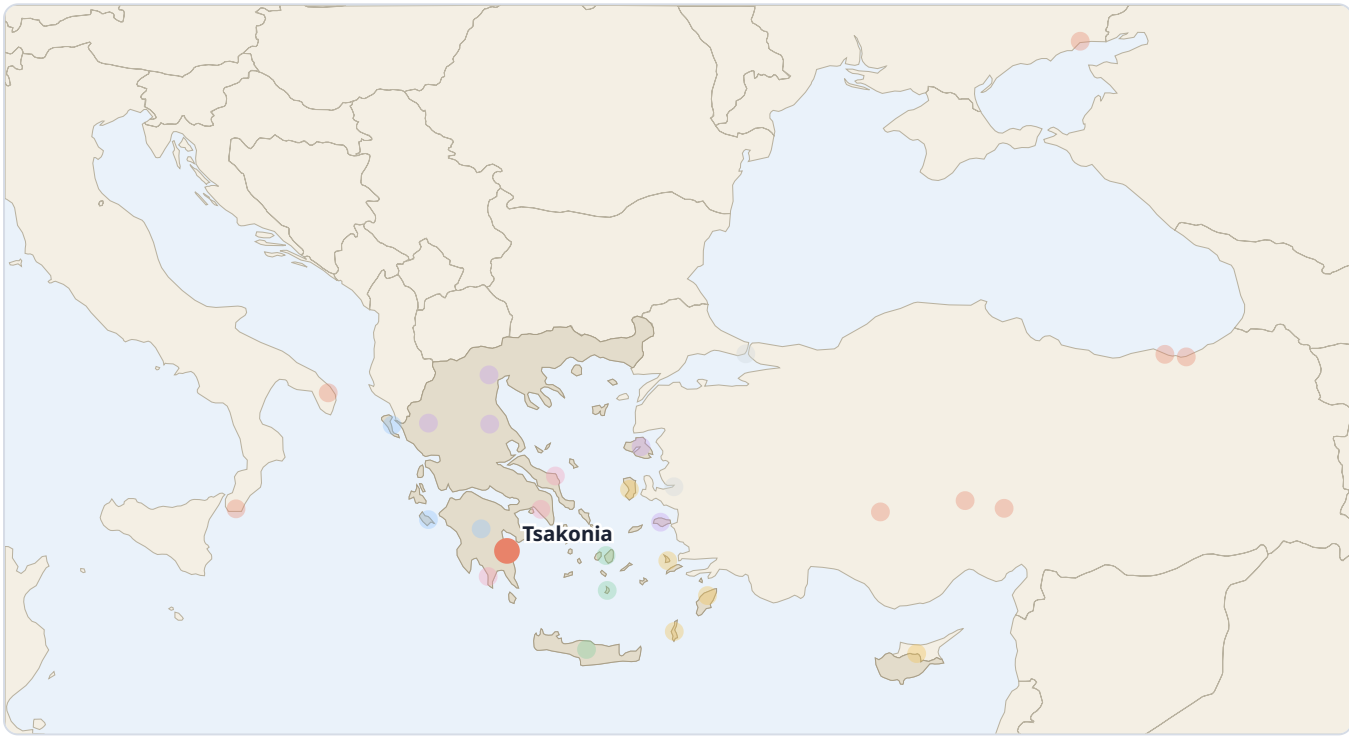
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Τσακώνικα

Tsakonian: the one living descendant of a Doric dialect

In a handful of mountain villages above the Argolic Gulf, on the eastern slopes of Mount Parnon, older people still speak **Τσακώνικα**. It is the only form of Greek alive today that does not come mainly from the Hellenistic Koine: it continues, with heavy Koine influence, the ancient **Laconian Doric** of Sparta. To a speaker of Standard Greek it is largely unintelligible, which is why many linguists treat it as a separate Hellenic language.

WHERE	**Τσακωνιά**, in Kynouria (Arcadia). South: **Λεωνίδιο**, Πραματευτή, Μέλανα, Σαπουνακέικα, Τυρός, Πραστός, Βασκίνα. North: **Καστάνιτσα**, Σίταινα. A third variety was spoken until about 1970 in two villages on the Sea of Marmara (Propontis), whose people moved to Greece in 1924.
SPEAKERS	A few hundred fluent, mostly elderly speakers (estimates of 200–1,000 by 2007) and more semi-speakers; Southern Tsakonian is the best preserved.
NAME	Byzantine writers derive **Τσάκωνες** from **Λάκωνες**, 'Laconians'.
ANCESTOR	Laconian Doric, mixed with Koine; the core vocabulary remains recognisably Doric.
STATUS	No official status; some teaching materials, bilingual signs in Leonidio, liturgy and the Lord's Prayer translated.



Why Tsakonian survived · Ιστορία

Ancient Laconian was one of the Doric dialects that resisted the Koine longest. Byzantine sources speak of the **Τσάκωνες** as a distinct people of the south-eastern Peloponnese, and Tsakonian was once spoken over a wider area, including the Laconian coast; the 17th-century Ottoman traveller Evliya Çelebi recorded

a wider area, including the Laconian coast, the 17th-century Ottoman traveller Evliya Çelebi recorded forms that may belong to a lost western variety. Mountain isolation kept the language intact for centuries. During the War of Independence the centre of Tsakonia moved from Prastos to coastal Leonidio, and from the 19th century schooling, roads, and from the 1950s electricity, radio and television, brought Standard Greek into every house. Fluent speakers fell from many thousands to a few hundred within a century.

Doric sounds you can still hear · Δωρισμοί στη φωνολογία

Feature	Tsakonian	Ancient source / standard
Doric long **α** where Attic and Koine have **η**	**α μάτη** 'the mother', **αμέρα** 'day'	Doric μάτηρ, ἀμέρα; standard μητέρα, μέρα
Ancient υ as [u], or [ju] after some consonants	**γουναίκα**; **λιούκο** 'wolf', **νιούτα** 'night'	γυναίκα, λύκος, νύχτα
Ancient ω narrowed to [u]	**γρούσσα** 'tongue', **ούρα** 'hour'	γλώσσα, ώρα
θ became σ (Laconian)	**α σάτη** 'daughter', **σουζίδα** 'window'	θυγάτηρ, θυρίδα
Final -ς became -ρ (rhotacism, Laconian)	**Π'ούρ έσι;** 'How are you?', **Τσούνερ έσι;** 'Whose are you?'	Πώς είσαι; Τίνος είσαι;
κ before ε, ι > [tʃ]	**τ̆σερέ** 'weather, time', **τ̆σίπο** 'garden'	καιρός, κήπος
γ > ζ	**εζού** 'I', **μούζα** 'fly'	εγώ, μύγα
λ lost between vowels before back vowels (South)	**θέου** 'I want', **αι** 'oil'	θέλω, λάδι
Aspirated stops	**κ', π', τ'** (written κχ, πφ, τθ)	not in the standard

The northern villages (Kastanitsa, Sitaina) keep the intervocalic **λ** that the south lost; that difference is the easiest way to tell the two apart.

Nouns and articles · Μορφολογία

Feature	Tsakonian	Standard
Doric feminine article	**α, ταρ, ταν**: **α γουναίκα** 'the woman'	η, της, την
Feminine -α for -η	**σπούδα**	σπουδή
Masculine -ος > -ε, final -ς dropped	**φούρνε** 'oven', **καπινέ** 'smoke', **ο τσχίφτα** 'grater'	φούρνος, καπνός, ο τρίφτης
1sg -ω > -ου	**πάου να χορέψου**	πάω να χορέψω
Relative particle	**πφη**	που
Very little case inflection	case mostly shown by the article	full case system

Verbs: 'I am bringing' with a participle · Περιφραστικός ενεστώτας

Tsakonian forms its present and imperfect not with endings but with the verb 'to be' plus a **participle** that agrees with the subject in gender, much like English *I am bringing*. A man says **ένει φερήκχου**, a woman **ένει φερήκχα** 'I bring'. In the old texts the copula is also written **έμι** (ancient εἰμί). The aorist, by contrast, is the one tense formed with endings as in ancient Greek.

	'to be'	'I bring' (man / woman)	aorist 'I brought'
1 sg.	**ένει**	**ένει φερήκχου / φερήκχα**	**ενέγκα**
2 sg.	**έσει**	**έσει φερήκχου / φερήκχα**	**ενέντζερε**
3 sg.	**έννι**	**έννι φερήκχου / φερήκχα**	**ενέντζε**
1 pl.	**έμε**	**έμε φερήκχουντε**	**ενέγκαμε**
2 pl.	**έτθε**	**έτθε φερήκχουντε**	**ενέγκατε**
3 pl.	**είνι**	**είνι φερήκχουντε**	**ενέγκαϊ**

Past of 'to be': **έμα, έσα, έκη, έμαϊ, έτθαϊ, ήγκιαϊ**. The aorist **ενέγκα** continues ancient **ἤνεγκα** 'I brought', the same root as Pontic **έγκα**. Propontis Tsakonian put the copula after the participle and kept ancient perfect participles in -κώς.

Ancient words · Λεξιλόγιο

Tsakonian	Meaning	Ancient word
ύο	water	ὕδωρ (standard νερό)
ο εψιλέ	eye	Doric ὀπτίλος
α σάτη	daughter	θυγάτηρ
ορού	I see	ὁράω
ενέντζε	he brought	ἤνεγκε
ο αναύτα	sailor	ναύτης, with a prefixed α-

Useful sentences · Φράσεις

> Π'ούρ έσι;
> **STANDARD:** Πώς είσαι;
> How are you?

> Τσούνερ έσι;
> **STANDARD:** Τίνος είσαι;
> Whose (family) are you?

> Κιά έννι το περιγιάλλι;
> **STANDARD:** Πού είναι η παραλία;
> Where is the beach?

> Κιά έννι το όντα σι;
> **STANDARD:** Πού είναι το δωμάτιό του;
> Where is his room?

> Μη μ' αντζίζερε όρπα!
> **STANDARD:** Μη μ' αγγίζεις εκεί!
> Don't touch me there!

Tsakonia today

Leonidio, the largest Tsakonian town, holds its **Πάσχα** with hundreds of paper lanterns released over the town, and its sweet aubergine, the **μελιτζάνα Τσακώνικη**, has protected designation of origin. Local associations publish Tsakonian dictionaries and grammars (above all Thanasis Kostakis's), run summer classes, and there is a small Tsakonian Wikipedia in development. A street sign in Leonidio tells visitors, in Tsakonian and Greek: 'Our language is Tsakonian. Ask and they'll tell you.'

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

20. Tsakonian is unique because it descends mainly from…
(a) Laconian Doric (b) the Koine of Constantinople (c) Medieval Venetian Greek

21. **α μάτη** 'the mother' keeps which Doric feature?
(a) Long α where Attic has η (b) Final -ν (c) Double consonants

22. How does a woman say 'I bring' in Tsakonian?
(a) ένει φερήκχα (b) ένει φερήκχου (c) φέρνω

23. In **Π'ούρ έσι;** the -ρ continues…
(a) ancient final -ς (b) ancient -ν (c) the Latin -r

Glossary

έκη έκη (Tsakonian) — he/she was

έμα έμα (Tsakonian) — I was

έμαϊ έμαϊ (Tsakonian) — we were

έμε έμε (Tsakonian) — we are

έμι έμι (Tsakonian) — I am (εἰμί)

ένει ένει (Tsakonian) — I am = είμαι

έννι έννι (Tsakonian) — he/she/it is

έσα έσα (Tsakonian) — you were

έσει έσει (Tsakonian) — you are

έσι έσι (Tsakonian) — you are = είσαι

έτθαϊ έτθαϊ (Tsakonian) — you (pl.) were

έτθε έτθε (Tsakonian) — you (pl.) are

ήγκιαϊ ήγκιαϊ (Tsakonian) — they were

α α (Tsakonian) — the (fem.) = η

αι αι (Tsakonian) — oil = λάδι

αμέρα αμέρα (Tsakonian) — day = μέρα (Doric ἀμέρα)

αναύτα αναύτα (Tsakonian) — sailor = ναύτης

αντζίζερε αντζίζερε (Tsakonian) — you touch = αγγίζεις

γουναίκα γουναίκα (Tsakonian) — woman = γυναίκα

γρούσσα γρούσσα (Tsakonian) — tongue, language = γλώσσα

είνι είνι (Tsakonian) — they are

εζού εζού (Tsakonian) — I = εγώ

ενέγκα ενέγκα (Tsakonian) — I brought (ἤνεγκα)

ενέγκαμε ενέγκαμε (Tsakonian) — we brought

ενέγκατε ενέγκατε (Tsakonian) — you (pl.) brought

ενέγκαϊ ενέγκαϊ (Tsakonian) — they brought

ενέντζε ενέντζε (Tsakonian) — he/she brought

ενέντζερε ενέντζερε (Tsakonian) — you brought

εψιλέ εψιλέ (Tsakonian) — eye (Doric ὀπτίλος)

θέου θέου (Tsakonian) — I want = θέλω

καπινέ καπινέ (Tsakonian) — smoke = καπνός

Κιά κιά (Tsakonian) — where? = πού

Λάκωνες Λάκωνες — Laconians (ancient Spartans' region)

Λεωνίδιο Λεωνίδιο — Leonidio, main Tsakonian town

λιούκο λιούκο (Tsakonian) — wolf = λύκος

μ' μ' = με — me

μάτη μάτη (Tsakonian) — mother (Doric μάτηρ)

μελιτζάνα μελιτζάνα — aubergine

Μη μη — don't

μούζα μούζα (Tsakonian) — fly = μύγα

νιούτα νιούτα (Tsakonian) — night = νύχτα

ορού ορού (Tsakonian) — I see (ὁράω)

ούρα ούρα (Tsakonian) — hour = ώρα

Π'ούρ π'ούρ (Tsakonian) — how? = πώς

πάου πάου (Tsakonian) — I go = πάω

Πάσχα Πάσχα — Easter

περιγιάλλι περιγιάλι — seashore, beach

πφη πφη (Tsakonian) — that, which = που

σάτη σάτη (Tsakonian) — daughter (θυγάτηρ)

σι σι (Tsakonian) — his/her = του/της

σουζίδα σουζίδα (Tsakonian) — window (θυρίδα)

σπούδα σπούδα (Tsakonian) — haste, study = σπουδή

ταν ταν (Tsakonian) — the (fem. acc.) = την

ταρ ταρ (Tsakonian) — of the (fem.) = της

τσ̆ίπο τσίπο (Tsakonian) — garden = κήπος

τσ̆ερέ τσερέ (Tsakonian) — weather, time = καιρός

Τσάκωνες Τσάκωνες — Tsakonians

Τσακωνιά Τσακωνιά — the Tsakonian-speaking area in Kynouria

Τσακώνικα τσακώνικα — Tsakonian

Τσούνερ τσούνερ (Tsakonian) — whose? = τίνος

τσχίφτα τσχίφτα (Tsakonian) — grater = τρίφτης

φερήκχα φερήκχα (Tsakonian) — bringing (fem. participle)

φερήκχου φερήκχου (Tsakonian) — bringing (masc. participle)

φερήκχουντε φερήκχουντε (Tsakonian) — bringing (pl. participle)

φούρνε φούρνε (Tsakonian) — oven = φούρνος

χορέψου χορέψου (Tsakonian) — (that) I dance = χορέψω

όντα όντα (Tsakonian) — room = δωμάτιο (Turkish oda)

όρπα όρπα (Tsakonian) — there = εκεί

ύο ύο (Tsakonian) — water (ὕδωρ)

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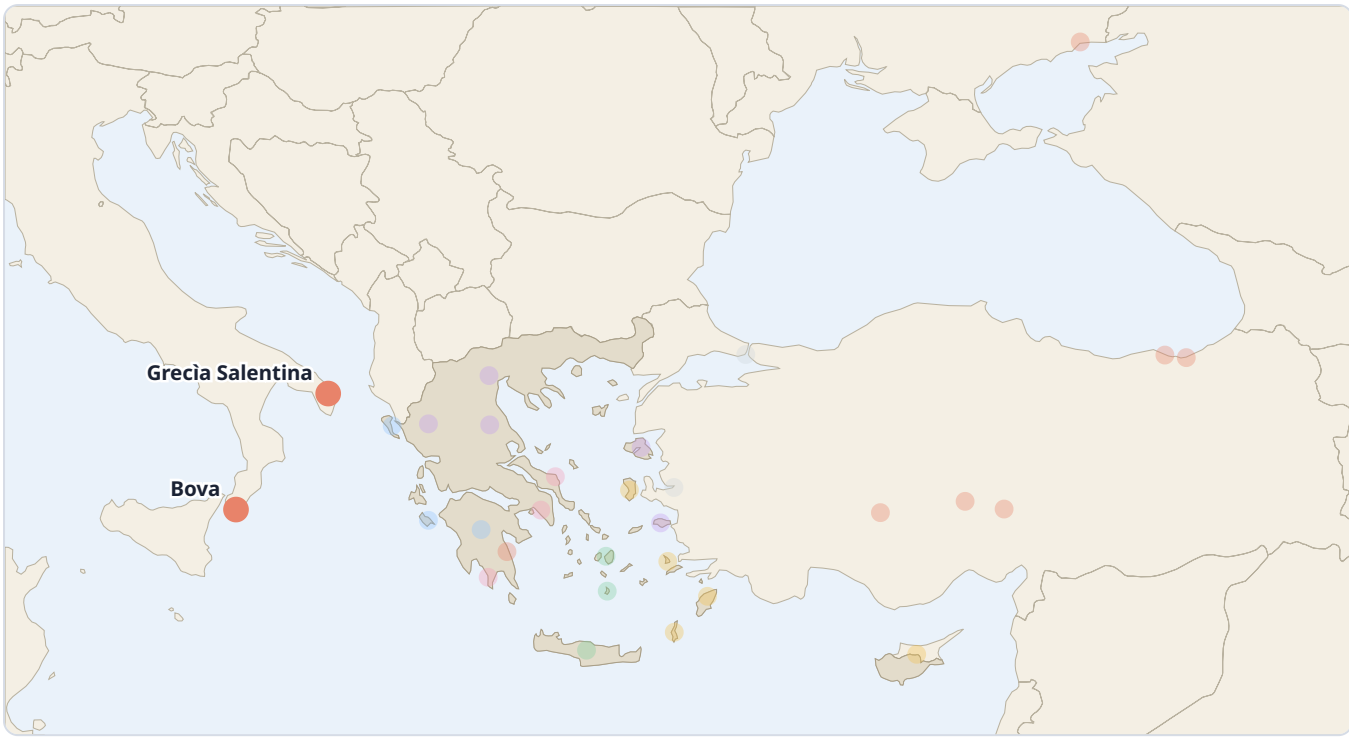
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Κατωιταλικά: Γκρίκο και Γκρεκάνικο

Italiot Greek: Griko of Salento and Greko of Calabria

At the heel and toe of Italy, a few villages still speak Greek. In the Salento, south of Lecce, it is called **γκρίκο** (Griko); in the mountains behind Reggio Calabria, around Bova, it is **γκρέκο** or, in Italian, *grecanico*. Both are written almost always in the Latin alphabet, both are full of Italian and local Romance words, and their speakers are Italian Catholics, not Greeks. Yet a Greek ear catches whole lines: **«Εβώ πάντα σε σένα πενσέω»**, 'I always think of you'. Scholars still argue whether this is the last echo of ancient Magna Graecia or the speech of Byzantine settlers. The answer matters for the whole history of Greek, because it is the one modern dialect, besides Tsakonian, that might not come mainly from the Koine.

WHERE	**Grecìa Salentina** (Apulia): Calimera, Castrignano dei Greci, Corigliano d'Otranto, Martano, Martignano, Sternatia, Zollino; Melpignano and Soleto belong to the union but have lost the language. **Bovesìa** (Calabria): Bova, Roghudi, Chorio di Roghudi, Roccaforte del Greco, Condofuri, Gallicianò, Amendolea.
SPEAKERS	Griko: about 20,000, mostly older, with more who understand it. Calabrian Greek: a few hundred active speakers (the Portal's estimate is about 500), all bilingual in a Romance dialect, which is their first language.
SCRIPT	Latin alphabet in daily use; Greek script in some publications and song books.
STATUS	Recognised as a Greek linguistic minority by Italian Law 482 of 1999; listed by UNESCO as endangered.
ORIGIN	Debated: continuity from the ancient colonies (Rohlfs, Hatzidakis) or Byzantine resettlement (Morosi, and many Italian scholars). Most specialists now see a Koine-based Byzantine Greek layered on older Doric elements.



Three thousand years of Greek in Italy · Ιστορία

8th–6th c. BC
Greek colonies across the south: **Ρήγιον** (Reggio), **Τάρας** (Taranto), Kroton, Sybaris, Lokroi. The region is called **Μεγάλη Ελλάς**, *Magna Graecia*. Many colonists in the far south spoke Doric.

3rd c. BC – 6th c. AD
Roman rule. Latin spreads through the towns, but Greek survives in parts of the countryside and in the Church.

6th–11th c.
Justinian's reconquest brings southern Italy back under Constantinople. Monks fleeing Iconoclasm and Greeks escaping the Arab conquest of Sicily (9th–10th c.) settle in Calabria and the Salento; the **Catepanate of Italy** is governed from Bari until 1071.

1071 onwards
Norman conquest. The Greek rite and Greek monasteries continue for centuries, but the Latin Church gradually replaces them; Bova adopted the Latin rite in 1573.

14th c.
Two Calabrian Greeks bring Greek back to Western scholarship: **Barlaam of Seminara** teaches Petrarch, and **Leonzio Pilato** translates Homer into Latin for Boccaccio.

1821–1924
Karl Witte 'discovers' Calabrian Greek (1821). Giuseppe Morosi (1870) argues for a Byzantine origin; Gerhard Rohlfs (1924) and Georgios Hatzidakis argue for unbroken continuity from antiquity.

20th c.
Emigration, poverty, schooling in Italian and stigma shrink both areas. Earthquakes and floods empty old Roghudi; the people move to the coast.

1999 – today
Law 482 recognises the minority. Grecìa Salentina becomes a centre of revival through music and festivals.

The great debate: Magna Graecia or Byzantium? · Δύο θεωρίες

The **Byzantine theory** says that the Greek of southern Italy arrived with settlers from the Peloponnese, Epirus, Central Greece, Euboea and even the Pontus during Byzantine rule. Its strongest argument is that the grammar is plainly medieval Greek, built on the Koine like every other dialect.

The **continuity theory** says that the Greek spoken here never died out after antiquity and was only strengthened by Byzantine monks and refugees. Its strongest argument is a set of **Doric words** found especially in Calabria, some of which are not even attested in the Doric dialects of Greece itself.

Today most scholars, following Horrocks and Fanciullo, combine the two: a medieval Greek whose structure is Koine-based, with older local survivals in the vocabulary.

> λανό
> **STANDARD:** πατητήρι (αρχ. ληνός, δωρ. λανός)
> wine-press: Doric **α** where Attic has **η**

> νασίδα
> **STANDARD:** νησίδα
> islet: the same Doric **α**

How it sounds · Φωνολογία

Feature	Italiot	Standard
κ before **ε, ι** becomes [tʃ] (strong tsitakismos)	**τσαι** [tʃe], written *ce*: 'and'	και [ce]
γ before **α, ο, ου** becomes [g]	**εγώ τρώγω** [ego trogo]	εγώ τρώγω [eɣo troɣo]
Words avoid ending in **-ς** or **-ν**	**ο άντρα** [o ádra], **λέγου** [léɣu]	ο άντρας, λένε (λέγουν)
…or add a final vowel	**τρίσε** [tríse], **πόσε** [póse], **δεν είχενε** [ðen íçene]	τρεις, πώς, δεν είχε
Double consonants kept	long or doubled, sometimes with a puff of breath	simplified
Retroflex **[ɖ]** (Griko, from λλ, as in local Romance)	**άɖɖo** 'other'	άλλο
φ for χ before consonants, **β** for γ	**καληνύφτα**, **εβώ** (Griko)	καληνύχτα, εγώ

The Griko song «Καληνύφτα» shows two of these at once: **νύφτα** for νύχτα and **εβώ** for εγώ. The second is a Griko habit; in Calabria the same word is **εγώ** [e'go].

Grammar: Greek with an Italian frame · Μορφολογία και σύνταξη

The noun has almost lost its case endings. The difference between subject and object is shown mainly by the article, and the genitive is being replaced by prepositional phrases, much as Italian uses *di*. Verbs tend towards one conjugation for all. The aspect difference between imperfect and aorist survives in the past, but in other tenses periphrases do the work, built on the Italian model.

Meaning	Italiot periphrasis	Model	Standard
Progressive 'I am talking'	**στέκω πλατέγοντα** (*stéko platéyonda*)	Italian *sto parlando*	μιλάω (τώρα)
Pluperfect 'I had talked'	**ίμμο πλατέσσοντα** (*ímmo platéssonda*)	be + gerund	είχα μιλήσει
'I can…'	**σόζω** (Griko) / **σώννω** (Calabria) + infinitive	ancient σώζω, 'save, manage'	μπορώ να…

That last row is remarkable. Like Pontic Romeyka, Italiot Greek still has a **verb infinitive** where every other dialect uses **να**. It survives mainly after the verb 'can', a relic of medieval Greek kept alive by the Romance infinitive all around it.

Words · Λεξιλόγιο

Italiot	Meaning	Standard / source
κανονίζω	look, see	κοιτάζω (ancient κανονίζω 'measure with a rule')
ότοιμη	pregnant	έγκυος (from έτοιμος 'ready')
γαμπρή [gambrí]	bride	νύφη (feminine of γαμπρός)
κουράζω	beat with a stick	ραβδίζω
πολεμώ	work	δουλεύω (ancient πολεμώ 'make war, toil')
πενσέω	think	σκέφτομαι (Italian *pensare*, conjugated like a Greek verb)
στέω	stand, stay	στέκω
σύρνω	go, drag oneself	σέρνω

Loans from Italian and the local Romance dialects reach even the closed parts of grammar, such as prepositions, and speakers do not feel them as foreign.

«Καληνύφτα», a Griko love song

A traditional serenade from Grecìa Salentina, sung today by groups such as Ghetonia.

Εβώ πάντα σε σένα πενσέω,
γιατί σένα φσυχή μου 'γαπώ,
τσαι που πάω, που σύρνω, που στέω
στην καρδία μου πάντα σένα βαστώ.

I always think of you,
because I love you, my soul,
and wherever I go, wherever I wander, wherever I stand,
in my heart I always hold you.

Traditional; text as given in the Wikipedia article «Griko language».

Listen: Griko of Sternatia

A recording from the VLACH archive of the Austrian Academy of Sciences, played from its YouTube channel and not stored in the app.

In the app these recordings play inside the page, with subtitles you can tap. Here each one is listed with its link.

In 1567

Luigia Linciano (1923–2016) of Sternatia tells an old tale of the hail of 1567 that destroyed the crops, and of the young women who asked the Virgin to calm her son's anger.

Watch: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QV17Yr1ZrKs

VLACH has not published a timed transcription of this clip, so it plays without app subtitles.

In 1567; performer: Luigia Linciano; transcription/translation: Francesco Giannachi, Thede Kahl; Vanishing Languages and Cultural Heritage (VLACH), Austrian Academy of Sciences, ID-number: apul1237ITV0001a.

The revival through music

Every August, Melpignano in Grecìa Salentina hosts **La Notte della Taranta**, a huge festival of the *pizzica* tarantella where Griko songs are sung to tens of thousands. Groups such as **Ghetonia** ('neighbourhood', from γειτονιά) and the **Canzoniere Grecanico Salentino** have made Griko songs known abroad, and Calabria has its own festival, **Palearìza** ('old root'). Even the name of the largest Griko town, Calimera, is Greek: **καλημέρα**.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

24. In which alphabet is Italiot Greek usually written?
(a) Latin (b) Greek (c) Cyrillic

25. Which word is the classic evidence for Doric survival in Calabria?
(a) λανό 'wine-press' (b) πενσέω 'think' (c) καλημέρα

26. What does «στέκω πλατέγοντα» mean?
(a) I am talking (b) I stood up (c) I will speak

27. What is unusual about «σόζω» + verb in Griko?
(a) It uses an infinitive (b) It has no subject (c) It is borrowed from Turkish

Glossary

'γαπώ αγαπώ — 'I love'
άντρα ο άντρα — ο άντρας (Italiot drops final -ς)
άḍḍo άḍḍo — άλλο, 'other'
ίμμο ίμμο — ήμουν, 'I was'
βαστώ βαστώ — κρατώ, 'hold'
γαμπρή γαμπρή — νύφη, 'bride'
γκρέκο γκρέκο — Greko, the Greek of Calabria
γκρίκο γκρίκο — Griko, the Greek of Salento
είχενε είχενε — είχε, 'had'
Εβώ εβώ — εγώ (Griko), 'I'
εβώ εβώ — εγώ (Griko), 'I'
Καληνύφτα καληνύφτα — καληνύχτα, 'good night'
καληνύφτα καληνύφτα — καληνύχτα, 'good night'
κανονίζω κανονίζω — κοιτάζω, 'look'
καρδία καρδία — καρδιά, 'heart'
κουράζω κουράζω — ραβδίζω, 'beat with a stick' (Italiot)
λέγου λέγου — λένε, 'they say'
λανό λανό — πατητήρι, 'wine-press' (ancient ληνός, Doric λανός)
νασίδα νασίδα — νησίδα, 'islet'
νύφτα νύφτα — νύχτα, 'night'
πενσέω πενσέω — σκέφτομαι, 'I think' (Italian pensare)
πλατέγοντα πλατέγοντα — μιλώντας, 'talking' (πλατεύω)
πλατέσσοντα πλατέσσοντα — aorist gerund, 'having talked'
πολεμώ πολεμώ — δουλεύω, 'work' (Italiot)
πόσε πόσε — πώς, 'how'
στέκω στέκω — 'stand'; in Italiot also 'be (doing)'
στέω στέω — στέκω, 'stand, stay'
σόζω σόζω — μπορώ, 'I can' (ancient σώζω)
σύρνω σύρνω — σέρνω, 'drag, wander'
σώννω σώννω — μπορώ, 'I can' (Calabrian)
τρίσε τρίσε — τρεις, 'three'

τσαι τσαι — και (Italiot), 'and'

φσυχή φσυχή — ψυχή, 'soul'

ότοιμη ότοιμη — έγκυος, 'pregnant'

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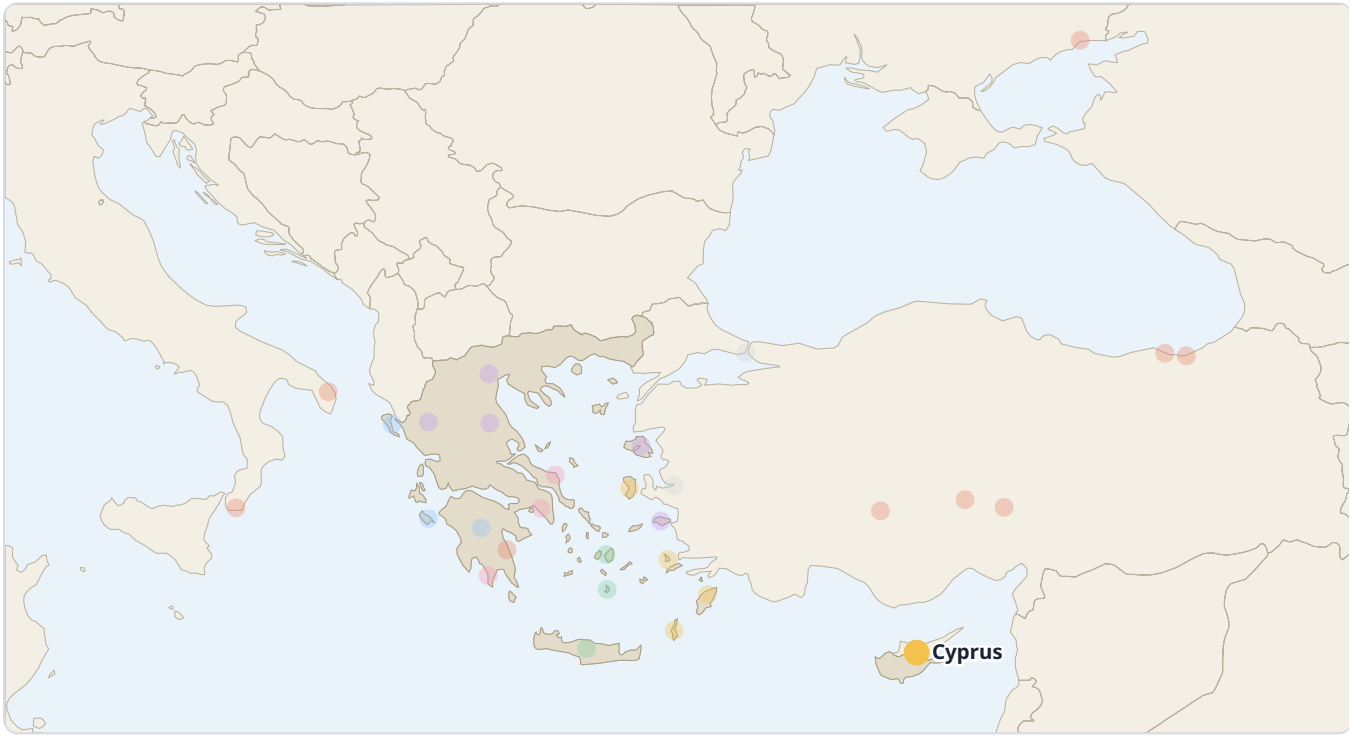
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Κυπριακά

Cypriot Greek: the most widely spoken dialect

If you land in Larnaca speaking textbook Greek, you will be understood perfectly and answered in something you only half follow: **«Ίντα που θέλεις;»**, **«εν ξέρω»**, **«τζαι»** for **και**. Cypriot is the one Greek dialect that is a living everyday language for a whole country, around 700,000 people. It is not a descendant of the ancient Arcadocypriot dialect of the island: like almost every modern dialect it grew out of the Koine. But centuries of separation, first under Arab raids and then under Frankish, Venetian, Ottoman and British rule, let it keep old features the mainland lost and build new ones of its own.

WHERE	Cyprus, with large communities in London, Australia and elsewhere; regional varieties differ (Paphos, Larnaca, Famagusta, the mountains).
SPEAKERS	About 700,000 Greek Cypriots. In 1960, 38% of Turkish Cypriots could also speak Greek.
GROUP	South-eastern, with the Dodecanese, Chios and parts of the Cyclades.
WRITTEN	From the 14th century: the Assizes, the chronicles of Leontios Machairas (15th c.) and Georgios Boustronios (16th c.), and a 16th-century collection of love poems.
TODAY	Standard Greek is the official language of school, law and news; Cypriot is the language of home, street, radio talk shows, comedy and rap.



Why Cypriot is different · Ιστορία

Antiquity

Cyprus spoke **Arcadocypriot**, written in a syllabary. It died out in the Hellenistic period, replaced by

the Koine, the true ancestor of Cypriot.

647–965
Arab raids from 647 lead to a **condominium**: the island pays taxes to both Byzantium and the Caliphate. Three centuries of relative isolation, when Cypriot speech probably began to diverge from the Greek of the centre.

965–1191
Cyprus is fully Byzantine again.

1192–1489
The French **Lusignan** kingdom. Greek remains the language of the people, French of the court. The **Assizes**, the law code, are translated into Cypriot Greek, and Machairas writes his chronicle in it, full of French and Italian words.

1489–1571
Venetian rule. More Italian loans.

1571–1878
Ottoman rule. Turkish loans enter everyday speech, and many Turkish Cypriots grow up bilingual.

1878–1960
British administration and then colony. English becomes the language of government; English loans follow.

1960 – today
Independence, then the 1974 division. Standard Greek is used for education and official life, and a common **urban Cypriot koine**, based on the speech of Nicosia and the Mesaoria plain, levels the village differences.

How it sounds · Φωνολογία

Feature	Cypriot	Standard
κ before **ε, ι** becomes [tʃ], written **τζ**	**τζαι**, **τζιείνος**, **τζεφαλή**	και, εκείνος, κεφάλι
χ before **ε, ι** becomes [ʃ], written **σι** or **ŏ**	**σιέριν** [ʃérin], **σιέπει** [ʃépi]	χέρι, σκεπάζει
Double consonants are really long	**ούλλοι**, **σκοτώννω**, **γαίμαν**	όλοι, σκοτώνω, αίμα
Double κκ, ππ, ττ aspirated	**κόκκαλον** [kókʰalon], **ποττέ** [potʰé]	κόκαλο, ποτέ
Final **-ν** kept, and even added	**βουνόν**, **στόμαν**, **πρόγραμμαν**	βουνό, στόμα, πρόγραμμα
γ often lost between vowels	**έφια**, **επία**, **Παναία**	έφυγα, πήγα, Παναγία
Glide hardening: [j] becomes [c] or [k]	**πκιον**, **καρκιά**, **χαρκιά**	πια, καρδιά, χαρτιά
No northern vowel loss	**σκλερό**	σκληρό

Glide hardening is the feature that most puzzles mainland ears. Where standard Greek has a short **ι** before another vowel (καρδ**ιά**), Cypriot turns it into a consonant: [kaɾ'ca], spelled **καρκιά**.

Grammar: old endings, new particles · Μορφολογία

Feature	Cypriot	Standard
Negation	**εν** (indicative), **μεν** (subjunctive)	δεν, μην
'is'	**εν**, **έναι**, **ένι**	είναι
Future	**έννα πάω** (often written **εν να**)	θα πάω
3rd plural endings	**λαλούσιν**, **εκάμασιν**, **είδασιν**	λένε, έκαναν, είδαν
Old aspect pairs kept	**έκαμεν** 'he did' / **έκαμνεν** 'he was doing'; **κάμνουσιν**	έκανε / έκανε; κάνουν
Feminine plural article	**τες** γυναίκες	τις γυναίκες
Verbs in **-ίσκω**	**φανίσκω** 'weave', **μιαλινίσκω** 'grow up', **αρέσκει**	υφαίνω, μεγαλώνω, αρέσει
Plural of γιος	**γιούδες**	γιοι

Syntax: the pronoun after the verb · Σύνταξη

Cypriot places the weak pronoun **after** the verb in ordinary statements, as medieval Greek did. It also builds questions with **ίντα** 'what' as a cleft: literally 'what is it that…'.

> Λαλεί του.
> **STANDARD:** Του λέει.
> He tells him.

> Γράφει το.
> **STANDARD:** Το γράφει.
> She writes it.

> Είδες το;
> **STANDARD:** Το είδες;
> Did you see it?

> Ίντα που είδες;
> **STANDARD:** Τι είδες;
> What did you see? (lit. what is it that you saw?)

> Εν την Ξένια που είδες.
> **STANDARD:** Την Ξένια είδες.
> It's Xenia that you saw.

> Στείλ' μου το.
> **STANDARD:** Στείλ' το μου.
> Send it to me: indirect object first.

> Τα λαλείς εν σωστά.
> **STANDARD:** Αυτά που λες είναι σωστά.
> What you say is right: **τα** as a relative 'what'.

Words · Λεξιλόγιο

Cypriot	Meaning	Standard / source
ίντα, είντα	what	τι
λαλώ	say	λέω (ancient λαλῶ 'chatter')
θωρώ	see, look	βλέπω (ancient θεωρῶ)
συντυχάννω	talk	μιλώ (ancient συντυγχάνω 'meet')
όντες	when	όταν
αμμά	but	αλλά
αγκρίζω	get angry	θυμώνω (ancient ἀγρίζω, from ἄγριος 'wild')
πόθεν	from where	από πού
δεφτέριν	register, ledger	κατάστιχο (Turkish *defter*)
χαζίριν	ready	έτοιμο (Turkish *hazır*)
μάδδαλλα	wonderful! (said to ward off the evil eye)	Arabic *mā shāʾ Allāh*

Cypriot also has local loans from Old French, Italian and English that the mainland never took. London Cypriots have added English words that the island itself does not use.

Two Greeks in one country · Διγλωσσία

Greek Cypriots grow up with two varieties. **Standard Modern Greek** is the language of the state, the school and the news; **Cypriot** is learned at home and stands for intimacy, humour and Cypriot identity. Linguists such as Spiros Moschonas (1996) describe this as **diglossia**. In practice speakers move along a continuum: at one end the Standard as spoken in Cyprus, at the other the village dialect, and in the middle the urban Cypriot koine, which keeps only the most basic Cypriot features. For a learner from Greece, the koine is the variety you will meet.

«Η 9η Ιουλίου 1821», by Vasilis Michaelides

The national poem of Cyprus, written in the dialect around 1884–1895. It tells of the execution of Archbishop Kyprianos by the Ottoman authorities in 1821. Stanza 18 and the close of stanza 19.

Η Ρωμιοσύνη εν φυλή συνότζαιρη του κόσμου,
κανένας δεν εβρέθηκεν για να την ι-ξηλείψη,
κανένας, γιατί σιέπει την που τα 'ψη ο Θεός μου.
Η Ρωμιοσύνη εν να χαθή, όντες ο κόσμος λείψει!
Σφάξε μας ούλους τζι ας γενεί το γαίμαν μας αυλάτζιν,
αμμά ξέρε πως ύλαντρον όντες κοπεί καβάτζιν
τριγύρου του πετάσσουνται τρακόσια παραπούλια.

Greekness is a race as old as the world,
no one has ever been found to wipe it out,
no one, because my God shields it from on high.
Greekness will vanish only when the world ends!
Slaughter us all and let our blood become a stream,
but know that when a tree is cut down at the stump,
three hundred new shoots burst out around it.

Vasilis Michaelides (1849–1917), public domain; text and translation after the Wikipedia article «Cypriot Greek».

Tsiattista: duelling in rhyme

At weddings and festivals, Cypriot **ποιητάρηδες** improvise **τσιαττιστά**: rhyming couplets thrown back and forth as challenges, compliments and insults, each singer answering the last line of the other. UNESCO added tsiattista to its list of Intangible Cultural Heritage in 2011. The poet Dimitris Lipertis wrote much-loved lyric poems in the dialect, and today Cypriot is heard in comedy shows, local TV series and rap.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

28. Which ancient dialect is modern Cypriot descended from?
(a) The Koine (b) Arcadocypriot (c) Doric

29. How do you say «Δεν ξέρω» in Cypriot?
(a) Εν ξέρω (b) Μεν ξέρω (c) Δεν ξέρου

30. «Έννα πάω» means…
(a) I will go (b) I went (c) I must not go

31. What does «καρκιά» correspond to in the standard?
(a) καρδιά (b) καρέκλα (c) κάρβουνα

32. «Γράφει το» puts the pronoun after the verb. In the standard you would say…
(a) Το γράφει (b) Γράφει το (c) Γράφει αυτό το

Glossary

'ψη ύψη — 'heights', που τα 'ψη = from on high
έκαμεν έκαμεν — έκανε, 'did' (aorist)
έκαμνεν έκαμνεν — έκανε, 'was doing' (imperfect)
έναι έναι — είναι, 'is'
ένι ένι — είναι, 'is'
έννα έννα — θα (future)
έφια έφια — έφυγα, 'I left'
Ίντα ίντα — τι, 'what'
ίντα ίντα — τι, 'what'
αγκρίζω αγκρίζω — θυμώνω, 'get angry'
αμμά αμμά — αλλά, 'but'
αρέσκει αρέσκει — αρέσει, 'pleases'
αυλάτζιν αυλάτζιν — αυλάκι, 'stream, channel'
βουνόν βουνόν — βουνό, 'mountain'
γαίμαν γαίμαν — αίμα, 'blood'
γενεί γίνει — 'become'
γιούδες γιούδες — γιοι, 'sons'
δεφτέριν δεφτέριν — κατάστιχο, 'ledger' (Turkish defter)
είδασιν είδασιν — είδαν, 'they saw'
είντα είντα — τι, 'what'
εβρέθηκεν εβρέθηκεν — βρέθηκε, 'was found'
εκάμασιν εκάμασιν — έκαναν, 'they did'
εν εν — δεν ('not') or είναι ('is'); εν να = θα
Εν εν — δεν ('not') or είναι ('is')
επία επία — πήγα, 'I went'
θωρώ θωρώ — βλέπω, 'see'
ι-ξηλείψη εξαλείψει — 'wipe out'
κάμνουσιν κάμνουσιν — κάνουν, 'they do'
καβάτζιν καβάτζιν — κούτσουρο, 'stump'
καρκιά καρκιά — καρδιά, 'heart'
κοπεί κοπεί — 'is cut'
κόκκαλον κόκκαλον — κόκαλο, 'bone'
Λαλεί λαλεί — λέει, 'says'
λαλείς λαλείς — λες, 'you say'
λαλούσιν λαλούσιν — λένε, 'they say'
λαλώ λαλώ — λέω, 'say'
μεν μεν — μην, 'don't'
μιαλινίσκω μιαλινίσκω — μεγαλώνω, 'grow up'
ούλλοι ούλλοι — όλοι, 'all'
ούλους ούλους — όλους, 'all'
Παναία Παναία — Παναγία, 'the Virgin'
παραπούλια παραπούλια — βλαστάρια, 'shoots'
πετάσσουνται πετάσσουνται — πετάγονται, 'spring up'
πκιον πκιον — πια, 'any more'

ποιητάρηδες ποιητάρηδες — Cypriot folk poets

ποττέ ποττέ — ποτέ, 'never'

πρόγραμμαν πρόγραμμαν — πρόγραμμα

πόθεν πόθεν — από πού, 'from where'

Ρωμιοσύνη Ρωμιοσύνη — the Greek (Romaic) people and identity

σιέπει σιέπει — σκεπάζει, προστατεύει, 'shields'

σιέριν σιέριν — χέρι, 'hand'

σκλερό σκλερό — σκληρό, 'hard'

σκοτώννω σκοτώννω — σκοτώνω, 'kill'

στόμαν στόμαν — στόμα, 'mouth'

συντυχάννω συντυχάννω — μιλώ, 'talk'

συνότζαιρη συνότζαιρη — συνομήλικη, 'of the same age'

τες τες — τις (feminine plural article)

τζαι τζαι — και, 'and'

τζεφαλή τζεφαλή — κεφάλι, 'head'

τζι τζι — και, 'and'

τζιείνος τζιείνος — εκείνος, 'that one'

τσιαττιστά τσιαττιστά — improvised Cypriot rhyming couplets

φανίσκω φανίσκω — υφαίνω, 'weave'

χαζίριν χαζίριν — έτοιμο, 'ready' (Turkish hazır)

χαθή χαθεί — 'be lost, vanish'

χαρκιά χαρκιά — χαρτιά, 'papers'

όντες όντες — όταν, 'when'

ύλαντρον ύλαντρον — δέντρο, 'tree'

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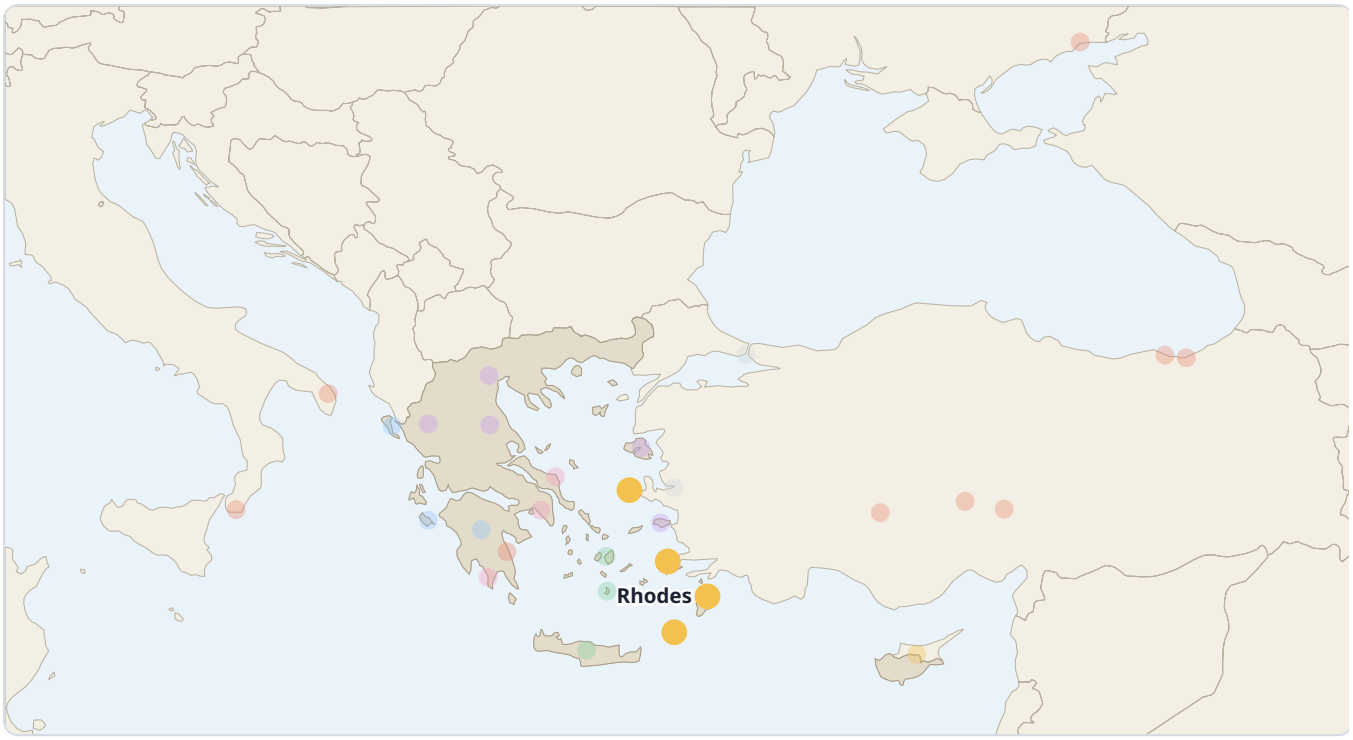
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Δωδεκανησιακά (και Χίος)

The Dodecanese and Chios: island Greek of the south-east

Ask an old Kalymnian if they are leaving before Easter and you may hear **«'εφ φεύγω μπρι τηλ λαμπρή»**: 'I'm not leaving before Easter'. Every consonant bends towards the next one, final **-ν** survives, and **π** before **ρ** turns into **μπ**. The Dodecanese lie far from Athens and close to Asia Minor, and for centuries they were a no man's land between Byzantium and the Arabs, then the possession of the Knights of St John, the Ottomans and Italy. They joined Greece only in 1948. Their speech is a close relative of Cypriot, and it changes from island to island and sometimes from village to village.

WHERE	Rhodes, Kastellorizo, Karpathos, Kasos, Chalki, Tilos, Nisyros, Symi, Kalymnos, Astypalaia, Kos, Leros; Patmos is closer to Cretan.
GROUPS	Trudgill: **south-eastern** (Rhodes, Karpathos, Kos, Kasos, Kastellorizo, Leros, with Cyprus) and **eastern** (Symi, Tilos, Nisyros, Kalymnos, Astypalaia, with Ikaria, Chios and the nearby Asia Minor coast).
WRITTEN	Rhodian poems from the 14th and 15th centuries, such as Emmanuel Georgillas's «Θανατικόν της Ρόδου», on the plague of 1498.
JOINED GREECE	1947–48, after Italian rule (1912–1943) and a brief German and British occupation.
STATUS	Receding under Standard Greek and emigration; still strong among older speakers and in remote villages such as Olympos on Karpathos.



A frontier history · Ιστορία

7th–10th c.
Arab fleets raid the Aegean. The historian Robert Browning notes that the Dodecanese were long 'a kind of neutral ground between Byzantium and the Arabs', and that their main dialect features were probably fixed then.

1309–1522
The **Knights of St John** rule Rhodes and Kos. The medieval town of Rhodes is theirs; Greek remains the language of the islanders, and Rhodian poets write in their own dialect.

1522–1912
Ottoman rule, with wide local self-government in many islands. Sponge-diving and shipping (Kalymnos, Symi, Kastellorizo) take islanders across the Mediterranean.

1912–1943
Italy takes the islands in the Italo-Turkish war. In the 1930s it imposes Italian in schools and public life. Italian loans and many Italian-built buildings remain.

1947–48
Union with Greece. Schooling, radio and later television bring Standard Greek to every island, and the dialects begin to retreat.

20th c.
Mass emigration. So many people from Kastellorizo moved to Perth and Sydney that far more people of Kastellorizian descent now live in Australia than on the island.

How it sounds · Φωνολογία

Feature	Dodecanese	Standard
β, γ, δ lost between vowels	**πιάδι** [piáði], **σίερο**, **πρόατο**	πηγάδι, σίδερο, πρόβατο
ρθ, ργ, βγ harden to **ρτ, ρκ, βκ**	**ήρτα**, **πύρκος**, **αυκά**	ήρθα, πύργος, αβγά
Final **-ν** kept	**ξύλον**, **χαρτίν**	ξύλο, χαρτί
…and assimilated to the next word	**μιαβ βολάν** 'once', **τολ λαόν**	μια φορά, τον λαό
Double consonants really double	and spreading to new words	simplified
κκ, ππ, ττ pronounced [kx, pf, tθ]	**λάκχος**, **πάπφου**	λάκκος, πάππος
[tʃ] for κ before ε, ι (some places)	**τσαι** [tʃe]	και
[j] after a consonant becomes [s, ʃ] or [ʒ]	**πσάνω** (πιάνω), **σέρζα** (χέρια)	πιάνω, χέρια

Put the features together and you get the Kalymnian sentence from the introduction: **δεν** loses its δ ('εν), its final ν assimilates to φ ('εφ φεύγω), **πριν** becomes **μπρι**, and **την** assimilates to λ (τηλ λαμπρή).

Grammar · Μορφολογία

Feature	Dodecanese	Standard
3rd plural **-ουσι(ν)**, **-ασι(ν)**	**ράβγουσι**, **κλέψασι**, **πουλήσασι**	ράβουν, έκλεψαν, πούλησαν
Verbs in **-εύκω**, **-εύγκω**	**δουλέβκω**, **δουλέβγκω**	δουλεύω
Augment kept even unstressed, often as **η-**	**ήπηρα**, **ήκουσα**, **ηφέρνανε**, **ηποφασίσανε**	πήρα, άκουσα, έφερναν, αποφάσισαν
'what'	**είντα**	τι

All four features are shared with Cypriot, and the **-ουσι(ν)** endings go back to the Koine (λύουσι). The **η-** augment is a medieval innovation, found also in Crete and the Cyclades.

Chios and the eastern Aegean · Χίος, Ικαρία, Μικρασιατικά παράλια

Chios, Ikaria and the Asia Minor coast opposite them (Smyrna, Çeşme, Ayvalık before 1922) belong with Symi, Kalymnos and Astypalaia in Trudgill's **eastern** group: they share the southern vowel system and many south-eastern traits, but not every Cypriot one. The Greek of the Asia Minor coast moved to Greece with the refugees of 1922–23 and mixed into the new urban speech of Athens, Piraeus and Thessaloniki, while Chios kept its own village varieties. Chiot is famous for its distinctive local vocabulary and for the medieval mastic villages, but it has been studied far less than Cypriot or Cretan, and modern descriptions are few.

Island by island · Ποικιλία

- **Rhodes**: the largest island, with clear differences between the town and the villages of the south.
- **Karpathos**: the north, above all **Όλυμπος**, is one of the most conservative places in the Greek world, with women's traditional dress still worn daily and improvised **μαντινάδες** sung to lyra and lute.
- **Kalymnos**: strong assimilation across word boundaries, as in the introduction.
- **Symi**: a careful study by Zachariou-Mamalinga (1994) shows how quickly the dialect gave way to Standard Greek after union in 1948.
- **Patmos**: closer to Cretan than to its neighbours.

> **Sponge divers and mantinades**
>
> Kalymnos was the capital of Mediterranean sponge-diving, and its divers carried Kalymnian speech to Tarpon Springs in Florida, where a Greek community still lives from sponges. On Karpathos, improvised rhyming couplets, **μαντινάδες**, are sung at every feast, much as in Crete. Rhodes and Kos keep the Italian period in their architecture and in a layer of Italian words.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

33. What does «ήρτα» correspond to in the standard?
(a) ήρθα (b) άρτα (c) έρθω

34. «Πρόατο» shows which feature?
(a) loss of β between vowels (b) final -ν (c) tsitakismos

35. When did the Dodecanese join Greece?
(a) 1947–48 (b) 1830 (c) 1913

36. Which dialect is closest to the Dodecanesian varieties?
(a) Cypriot (b) Pontic (c) Northern Greek

Glossary

'εφ 'εφ — δεν (before φ)

ήπηρα ήπηρα — πήρα, 'I took'

ήρτα ήρτα — ήρθα, 'I came'

αυκά αυκά — αβγά, 'eggs'

βολάν βολάν — φορά, 'time'

δουλέβγκω δουλέβγκω — δουλεύω, 'work'

δουλέβκω δουλέβκω — δουλεύω, 'work'

είντα είντα — τι, 'what'

ηποφασίσανε ηποφασίσανε — αποφάσισαν, 'they decided'

ηφέρνανε ηφέρνανε — έφερναν, 'they were bringing'

Θανατικόν θανατικόν — επιδημία, 'plague'

κλέψασι κλέψασι — έκλεψαν, 'they stole'

λάκχος λάκχος — λάκκος, 'pit'

λαμπρή λαμπρή — Πάσχα, 'Easter'

λαόν λαόν — λαό, 'people'

μαντινάδες μαντινάδες — improvised rhyming couplets

μιαβ μιαβ βολάν — μια φορά, 'once'

μπρι μπρι — πριν, 'before'

ξύλον ξύλον — ξύλο, 'wood'

πάπφου πάπφου — πάππος, 'grandfather'

πιάδι πιάδι — πηγάδι, 'well'

πουλήσασι πουλήσασι — πούλησαν, 'they sold'

πρόατο πρόατο — πρόβατο, 'sheep'

πδάνω πδάνω — πιάνω, 'catch'

πύρκος πύρκος — πύργος, 'tower'

ράβγουσι ράβγουσι — ράβουν, 'they sew'

σέρζα σέρζα — χέρια, 'hands'

σίερο σίερο — σίδερο, 'iron'

τηλ τηλ — την (before λ)

τολ τολ — τον (before λ)

χαρτίν χαρτίν — χαρτί, 'paper'

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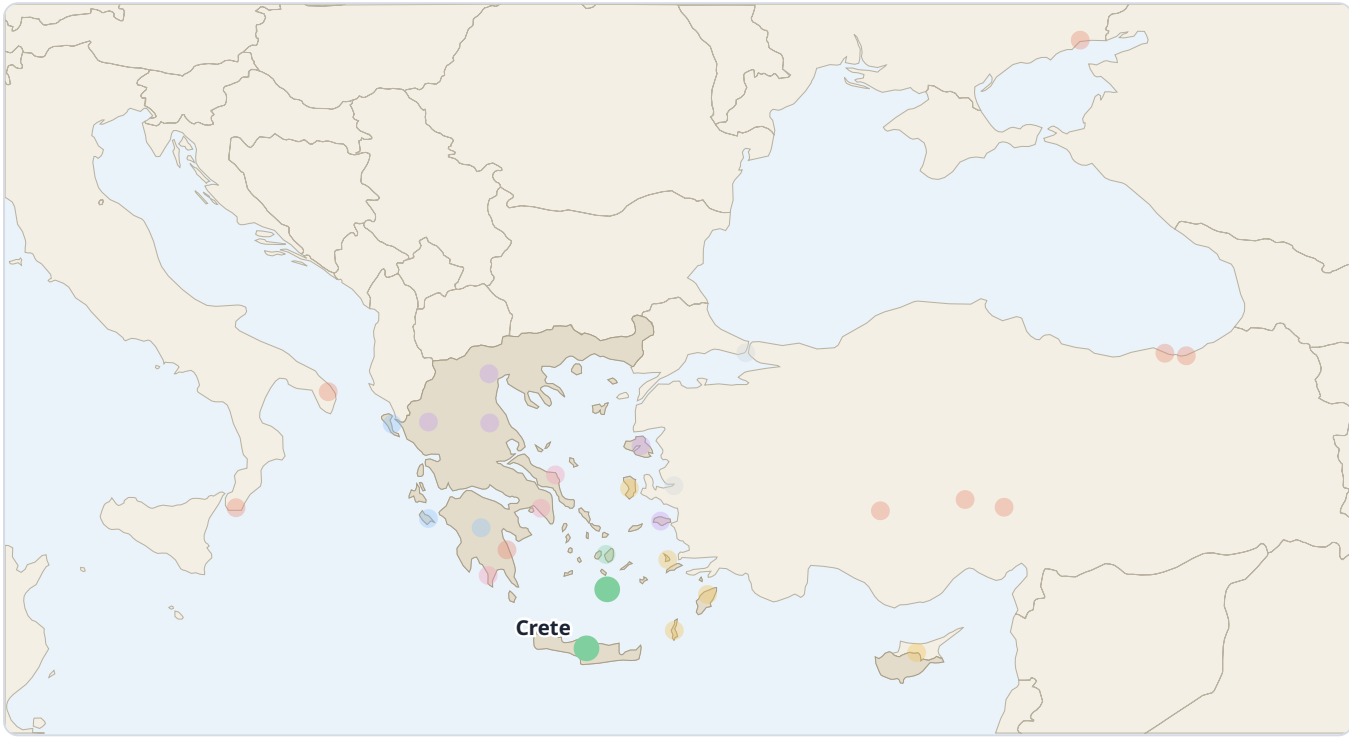
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Κρητικά (και Κύθηρα, Σαντορίνη, Μήλος)

Cretan: the dialect of the Erotokritos

Cretan is the dialect you are most likely to hear on a Greek island today, and the one with the richest literature. A Cretan child is a **κοπέλι**, 'now' is **εδά**, and 'what' is **ίντα**; the **κ** of **και** sounds almost like English *ch*. Crete was cut off by Arab rule in the 9th and 10th centuries and then ruled for more than four centuries by Venice, which gave it a Renaissance of its own. Its masterpiece, Kornaros's **Ερωτόκριτος**, is still sung by heart in villages, and its music, the lyra and the improvised **μαντινάδα**, carries the dialect into the present.

WHERE	Crete, with real differences between east and west (Kontosopoulos's dialect atlas, 1988, maps them). The same southern group includes **Kythera**, Antikythera, **Santorini**, Anafi and **Milos**.
SPEAKERS	Most of the island's 620,000 people use Cretan features to some degree; the full dialect lives in villages and among older speakers.
ANCESTOR	The Hellenistic Koine; not the ancient Doric dialect of Crete.
WRITTEN	From the 14th century, flourishing 16th–17th c. (the Cretan Renaissance); silent from 1669 until 19th-century collections of folk songs.
ABROAD	About 7,000 Greek-speaking Muslims of Cretan descent in al-Hamidiyah (Syria) and near Tripoli (Lebanon); Cretan Muslims resettled in 1923 at Ayvalık, Cunda and Smyrna.



Crete's history in its speech · Ιστορία

Antiquity

Crete spoke a **Doric** dialect, known from the Gortyn law code. The Koine replaced it in the Hellenistic

Crete spoke a **Doric** dialect, known from the Gortyn law code. The Koine replaced it in the Hellenistic period; Cretan descends from that Koine.

c. 824–961
Arabs from al-Andalus, after a stay in Egypt, conquer Crete and found an emirate at Chandax (Heraklion). Nikephoros Phokas retakes it in 961. Browning argues that this century and a half of isolation fixed many of Cretan's peculiar features.

1211–1669
Venetian Crete. Greek and Venetian live side by side; Venetian loans pour in; Cretan becomes a written literary language: Chortatzis's «Ερωφίλη», the «Θυσία του Αβραάμ», Kornaros's «Ερωτόκριτος» (c. 1600).

1669
Candia falls to the Ottomans after a 21-year siege. Many Cretan writers and scholars flee to the Ionian Islands and Venice, carrying their literature with them.

1669–1898
Ottoman Crete. Many Cretans convert to Islam but keep speaking Cretan Greek. Revolts in 1821, 1866 and 1897 drive Cretan Muslims to emigrate to Syria, Lebanon and Asia Minor.

1898–1913
The autonomous Cretan State; union with Greece in 1913. Cretan Muslims leave in the 1923 exchange.

20th c. – today
Standard Greek spreads through school and media; Cretan remains a strong marker of identity, above all in song.

How it sounds · Φωνολογία

Feature	Cretan	Standard
κ, γ, χ before **ε, ι** become soft [tɕ, ʑ, ɕ], close to English *ch, j, sh*	**τ̆σαι** 'and', **τ̆σερί** 'candle'	και, κερί
τ, δ before **ι** + vowel become **θ, δ**	**μάθια** [máθça], **αρχοδιά** [arxoðjá]	μάτια, αρχοντιά
μπ, ντ, γκ without the nasal	**των gοπελιώ**, **των dουρκώ**	των κοπελιών, των Τούρκων
Genitive plural drops **-ν**	**τω Γερμανώ**, **τω σπιθιώ**	των Γερμανών, των σπιτιών
Clusters simplified	**άθρωπος**, **φταμένος**, **αθός**	άνθρωπος, φτασμένος, ανθός

The soft **κ** is the first thing a mainlander imitates in a Cretan accent.

Grammar · Μορφολογία και σύνταξη

Feature	Cretan	Standard
Article and pronoun **τση**, **τσι**	**τση μάνας**, **τσι γυναίκες**	της μάνας, τις γυναίκες
Prefix **α-** or **ο-** on many words	**αζώντανος**, **αμοναχός**, **οφέτος**, **οπέρσι**, **ογλήγορα**	ζωντανός, μοναχός, φέτος, πέρσι, γρήγορα
1st plural **-ομε**	**κάνομε**, **έχομε**	κάνουμε, έχουμε
Verbs in **-εύγω**	**χορεύγω**, **δουλεύγω**	χορεύω, δουλεύω
Future with **θέλω** after the verb	**να πάω θέλω**, **να φάμε θέλει**	θα πάω, θα φάμε
Aorist in **-ξ-**	**τραγούδηξα**, **θα τραγουδήξω**	τραγούδησα, θα τραγουδήσω
Augment **η-**	**ήβανε**	έβαλε

> Ρωτώ σε.
> **STANDARD:** Σε ρωτάω.
> I ask you: the weak pronoun follows the verb.

> Ένα γαφέ μου κάμε.
> **STANDARD:** Κάνε μου έναν καφέ.
> Make me a coffee: with the object first, the pronoun comes before the imperative.

The future **να πάω θέλω** is a living fossil: medieval Greek formed the future with **θέλω να**, which in the standard shrank to **θα**. Crete kept both words and turned them round.

Words · Λεξιλόγιο

Cretan	Meaning	Standard
κοπέλι	child, boy	παιδί, αγόρι
κουζουλός	crazy	τρελός
κουράδι	flock	κοπάδι
κουτσούνα	doll	κούκλα
εδά	now	τώρα
επαέ	here	εδώ
ίντα, **γιάντα**	what, why	τι, γιατί
μπλιο	any more	πια
θωρώ	see	βλέπω
γροικώ	hear, understand	ακούω, καταλαβαίνω
κατέχω	know	ξέρω
πράμα	nothing	τίποτα
θέτω	lie down, sleep	πλαγιάζω, κοιμάμαι
χτήμα	donkey	γάιδαρος
πυροβόλος	cigarette lighter	αναπτήρας

Several of these mean something else in the standard: **πράμα** is 'thing' in Athens and 'nothing' in Crete, as in **«Δεν κατέχω πράμα»** 'I know nothing'; **χτήμα** is 'estate' in Athens and 'donkey' in Crete; **κατέχω** is 'possess' in the standard.

The other southern islands · Κύθηρα, Σαντορίνη, Ανάφη, Μήλος

Kythera, Antikythera, Santorini, Anafi and Milos share the southern vowel system and many Cretan traits, and the Portal for the Greek Language groups them with Cretan. Kythera, Venetian until 1797 and then part of the Ionian state, also keeps old pronunciations without synizesis.

«Ερωτόκριτος», the opening

Vitsentzos Kornaros, c. 1600: 10,012 rhyming fifteen-syllable lines in Cretan. These are lines 1–4 and 41–42, from Stylianos Alexiou's edition; the poem's text is centuries out of copyright.

Του Κύκλου τα γυρίσματα, που ανεβοκατεβαίνουν,
και του Τροχού, που ώρες ψηλά κι ώρες στα βάθη πηαίνουν·
και του Καιρού τα πράματα, που αναπαημό δεν έχουν,
μα στο Καλό κ' εις το Κακό περιπατούν και τρέχουν·
γιατ' ήσαν χρόνους ανταμώς, και τέκνα δεν εκάμα',
σ' έγνοια μεγάλη και βαρά τσ' ήβανε τέτοιο πράμα.

The turnings of the Cycle of time, which rise and fall,
and of the Wheel, which now go high and now sink to the depths;
and the things of Time, which know no rest,
but walk and run towards Good and towards Evil.
For they had been together for years and had no children,
and this had put them into great and heavy worry.

Βιτσέντζος Κορνάρος, Ερωτόκριτος, Α΄ 1–4, 41–42, ed. Στ. Αλεξίου (1980).

Lyra and mantinades

In Crete, feelings are still put into **μαντινάδες**: rhyming couplets of fifteen-syllable lines, improvised at weddings and feasts to the **λύρα** and **λαούτο**, or texted to a sweetheart. The great performers, such as Nikos Xylouris and Psarantonis, made Cretan known all over Greece, and every Cretan knows a few lines of «Ερωτόκριτος» set to music.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

37. In Cretan, «να πάω θέλω» means…
(a) I will go (b) I want to go (c) I had to go

38. «Δεν κατέχω πράμα» means…
(a) I don't know anything (b) I don't own the thing (c) I don't hold anything

39. What made Cretan a written literary language?
(a) Venetian rule and the Cretan Renaissance (b) The Ottoman administration (c) The Arab emirate

40. «Μάθια» is the Cretan form of…
(a) μάτια (b) μαθήματα (c) μάθε

41. Where is Cretan still spoken outside Greece?
(a) al-Hamidiyah in Syria (b) Mariupol in Ukraine (c) Cargèse in Corsica

Glossary

dουρκώ dουρκώ — Τούρκων

gαφέ gαφέ — καφέ, 'coffee'

gοπελιώ gοπελιώ — κοπελιών, of the children

άθρωπος άθρωπος — άνθρωπος

έγνοια έγνοια — φροντίδα, ανησυχία, 'worry'

έχομε έχομε — έχουμε

ήβανε ήβανε — έβαλε, 'put'

ίντα ίντα — τι, 'what'

αζώντανος αζώντανος — ζωντανός

αθός αθός — ανθός, 'blossom'

αμοναχός αμοναχός — μοναχός, 'alone'

αναπαημό αναπαημός — ανάπαυση, 'rest'

ανεβοκατεβαίνουν ανεβοκατεβαίνουν — ανεβαίνουν και κατεβαίνουν

ανταμώς ανταμώς — μαζί, 'together'

αρχοδιά αρχοδιά — αρχοντιά, 'nobility, grace'

βαρά βαρά — βαριά, 'heavy'

Γερμανώ Γερμανώ — Γερμανών

γιάντα γιάντα — γιατί, 'why'

γροικώ γροικώ — ακούω, καταλαβαίνω

γυρίσματα γυρίσματα — περιστροφές, 'turnings'

δουλεύγω δουλεύγω — δουλεύω

εδά εδά — τώρα, 'now'

εκάμα' εκάμαν — έκαναν, 'they made'

επαέ επαέ — εδώ, 'here'

θέτω θέτω — πλαγιάζω, κοιμάμαι (Cretan)

θωρώ θωρώ — βλέπω, 'see'

κάμε κάμε — κάνε, 'make'

κάνομε κάνομε — κάνουμε

Καιρού Καιρός — Time

κατέχω κατέχω — ξέρω, 'know' (Cretan)

κοπέλι κοπέλι — παιδί, αγόρι, 'child, boy'

κοπελιώ κοπελιώ — κοπελιών, of the children

κουζουλός κουζουλός — τρελός, 'crazy'

κουράδι κουράδι — κοπάδι, 'flock'

κουτσούνα κουτσούνα — κούκλα, 'doll'

Κύκλου Κύκλος — the cycle (of time, fortune)

λαούτο λαούτο — lute

λύρα λύρα — the Cretan bowed lyre

μάθια μάθια — μάτια, 'eyes'

μαντινάδα μαντινάδα — Cretan rhyming couplet

μαντινάδες μαντινάδες — Cretan rhyming couplets

μπλιο μπλιο — πια, 'any more'

ογλήγορα ογλήγορα — γρήγορα, 'quickly'

οπέρσι οπέρσι — πέρσι, 'last year'

οφέτος οφέτος — φέτος, 'this year'

περιπατούν περιπατούν — περπατούν, 'walk'

πηαίνουν πηαίνουν — πηγαίνουν, 'go'

πράμα πράμα — τίποτα, 'nothing' (Cretan); πράγμα

πράματα πράματα — πράγματα, 'things'

πυροβόλος πυροβόλος — αναπτήρας, 'lighter' (Cretan)

Ρωτώ ρωτώ — ρωτάω, 'ask'

σπιθιώ σπιθιώ — σπιτιών

τραγουδήξω τραγουδήξω — τραγουδήσω

τραγούδηξα τραγούδηξα — τραγούδησα

Τροχού Τροχός — the wheel (of fortune)

τσ' τσ' — τους, 'them'

τ̆δαι τ̆δαι — και, 'and'

τ̆δερί τ̆δερί — κερί, 'candle'

τση τση — της

τσι τσι — τις, τους

τω τω — των (genitive plural article)

φταμένος φταμένος — φτασμένος, 'arrived'

χορεύγω χορεύγω — χορεύω

χτήμα χτήμα — γάιδαρος, 'donkey' (Cretan)

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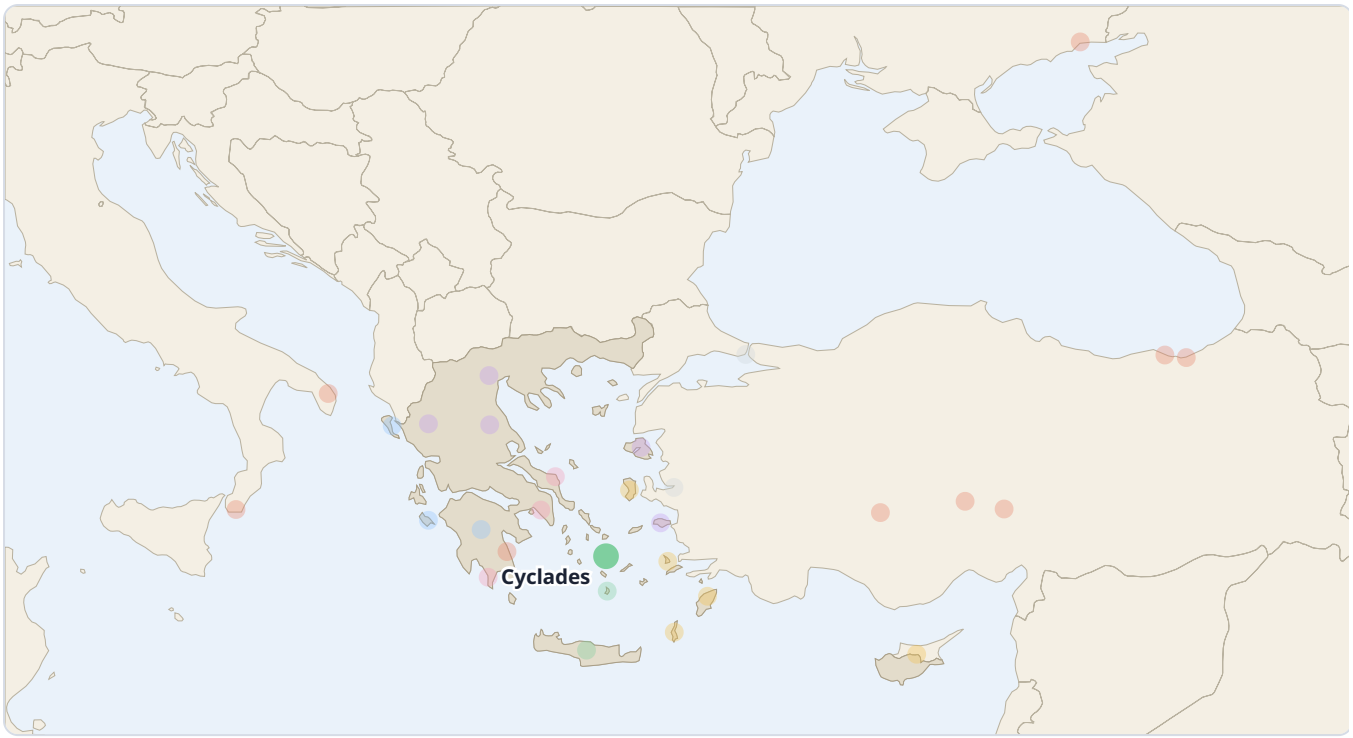
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Κυκλαδίτικα

The Cyclades: a dialect patchwork shaped by the Venetian dukes

The Cyclades look alike on a postcard, but their speech does not. On one island the **γ** vanishes (**ο έρος** for **ο γέρος**), on another **κ** becomes **τσ** (**τσέρατο** for **κέρατο**), and on Andros and Tinos you will even hear northern vowels. The islands were held for three and a half centuries by Venetian and other Latin lords of the **Duchy of the Archipelago**, who left Italian words, Catholic villages and castles behind. Since the 19th century, islanders have moved to Athens and Piraeus, and the dialects have been fading for a long time; they are still among the least studied in Greece.

WHERE	Kea, Kythnos, Serifos, Sifnos, Kimolos, Milos, Paros, Naxos, Syros, Antiparos, Sikinos, Folegandros, Ios, Santorini, Anafi, Andros, Tinos, Mykonos, Amorgos and the Small Cyclades.
GROUPS (KONTOSOPOULOS)	1) southern vowels, close to Cretan (most islands); 2) close to the Dodecanese (Amorgos, Donousa, Irakleia, Schinoussa, Koufonisia); 3) northern vowels (parts of Andros and Tinos); 4) semi-northern (Mykonos). Sifnos sits between 1 and 2.
GROUPS (TRUDGILL)	Santorini, Milos, perhaps Anafi: southern, with Crete. Central Cyclades (Amorgos, Irakleia…), western (Sifnos, Kimolos, Serifos), Mykonos on its own, and a northern Cyclades group (Andros, Tinos, Kea, Kythnos, Syros, Naxos, Paros, Ios, Folegandros).
HISTORY	Duchy of the Archipelago (1207–1579), Ottoman rule to 1821, part of Greece from 1830.
STATUS	Receding already in studies of the 1920s–30s; few modern descriptions.



Islands of the Franks · Ιστορία

7th–10th c.
Arab raids empty many smaller islands; settlement shrinks to fortified hilltop villages.

1207
After the Fourth Crusade, the Venetian Marco Sanudo founds the **Duchy of the Archipelago** with its capital at Naxos. Latin lords rule most of the Cyclades; Tinos and Mykonos stay Venetian, Tinos until 1715.

13th–17th c.
The **Frankokratia**. A Catholic Latin aristocracy rules a Greek Orthodox peasantry. Italian words enter everyday speech, and Catholic communities form on Syros, Tinos and Naxos that still exist.

1537–1579
The Ottomans take the islands; the Duchy ends in 1579. Islands keep a good deal of local self-government.

1820s
Refugees from Chios and Psara found **Ερμούπολη** on Syros, for a time the largest port of free Greece.

19th–20th c.
Emigration to Athens, Piraeus and the mines of Lavrion. Later, tourism and Standard Greek complete the change.

How it sounds · Φωνολογία

Feature	Cyclades	Standard
Tsitakismos: **κ** before **ε, ι** becomes [ts]	**αυλάτσι**, **τσέρατο**, **τσιλιά**, **τσίρης**	αυλάκι, κέρατο, κοιλιά, κύρης
γ lost at the start of words and between vowels	**έρος**, **άμος**, **θυατέρα**, **ανοίω**, **τραούδι**, **μεάλος**	γέρος, γάμος, θυγατέρα, ανοίγω, τραγούδι, μεγάλος
τσ, τζ simplified to **σ, ζ**	**έκασε**, **πεσί**, **ζίζικας**, **μούζα**, **ζάμι**, **ζάκι**	έκατσε, πετσί, τζίτζικας, μούτζα, τζάμι, τζάκι
μπ, ντ, γκ without the nasal	**είντα** [ída], **γιάντα** [jáda], **αφέντης** [afédis]	τι, γιατί, αφέντης [aféndis]
Stress on the fourth syllable from the end, with a second stress	**ήκαμενέ**, **ήβγαλενε**, **αρχίνησενε**	έκανε, έβγαλε, άρχισε

Standard Greek does not allow stress further back than the third syllable from the end. Cycladic **ήκαμενε** breaks that rule, and many speakers 'repair' it with a second stress: **ήκαμενέ**.

Grammar · Μορφολογία και σύνταξη

Feature	Cyclades	Standard
Verbs in **-εύγω**	**γυρεύγω**, **χορεύγω**, **δουλεύγω**	γυρεύω, χορεύω, δουλεύω
Article **τση**, **τσι**	**τση χαράς**, **τσι γερόντους**, **τσι γυναίκες**	της χαράς, τους γέροντες, τις γυναίκες
Nominative and accusative plural of **-ος** nouns share one form	**τσι γιατρούς**, **τσι βλάχους**	different forms: οι γιατροί / τους γιατρούς
Augment **ε-** or **η-**, even unstressed	**εστεναχωρεθήκαμε**, **ήχυσα**, **ηχύσαμε**	στενοχωρηθήκαμε, έχυσα, χύσαμε

> Ευχαριστώ σας.
> **STANDARD:** Σας ευχαριστώ.
> Thank you: the weak pronoun follows the verb.

> Βλέπω σε.
> **STANDARD:** Σε βλέπω.
> I see you.

> Είπα σας.
> **STANDARD:** Σας είπα.
> I told you.

> Σου πιστεύγω.
> **STANDARD:** Σε πιστεύω.
> I believe you: genitive instead of accusative.

> Γροικά του.
> **STANDARD:** Τον ακούει.
> He hears him (or: he obeys him).

> Να μου συχωρέσετε.
> **STANDARD:** Να με συγχωρέσετε.
> Please forgive me.

Words: Venetian loans and island inventions · Λεξιλόγιο

Cyclades	Meaning	Source / standard
φουντάνα	fountain, spring	Italian *fontana*; κρήνη, πηγή
μπονόρα	early	Italian *di buon'ora*; νωρίς
βάνω αμέντε	keep in mind	Italian *a mente*; βάζω στο νου μου
κόρνο	horn	Italian *corno*; κέρατο
γαμιώτης	wedding guest	καλεσμένος σε γάμο
δερφακίδα	young pig	γουρουνάκι
ανεμοσουσουρίδα	whirlwind	ανεμοστρόβιλος
άφνιδα	suddenly	ξαφνικά
ζάρω	get used to	συνηθίζω
πράσσω	keep company with	συναναστρέφομαι
σύνεργο	plough	αλέτρι
παίζω	shoot (a gun)	πυροβολώ
περισύρνω	sweep	σκουπίζω
σπάος	string	σπάγκος

Mykonos, Andros and Tinos: the northern islands of the south · Ημιβόρεια και βόρεια ιδιώματα

Mykonos is the one Cycladic island with **semi-northern** vowels: unstressed **ου** and **ι** may drop, while **ε** and **ο** stay. Parts of Andros and Tinos go further, with fully **northern** vowel loss of the kind heard in Thessaly or Macedonia. One suggested reason is settlement: northern Andros received Albanian-speaking (Arvanite) settlers in the late Middle Ages, and the northern Cyclades had close links with Euboea and the mainland. The result is a reminder that a dialect map follows the movements of people, not the shape of the sea.

> **Catholic villages and island feasts**
>
> Syros and Tinos still have large Catholic communities, a legacy of the Duchy: Ano Syros, above Ermoupoli, has a Catholic cathedral, and many Tinian villages have both an Orthodox and a Catholic church. Across the islands the summer **πανηγύρι**, with violin and **τσαμπούνα** bagpipe, is where you are most likely to hear old dialect songs and **κοτσάκια**, the rhyming couplets of Naxos.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

12. «Ο έρος» is the Cycladic form of…
    (a) ο γέρος (b) ο έρωτας (c) ο ήρωας
13. Why are there Italian words such as «φουντάνα» in the Cyclades?
    (a) Latin rule under the Duchy of the Archipelago (b) Italian rule 1912–1943 (c) Modern tourism
14. Which Cycladic island has semi-northern vowels?
    (a) Mykonos (b) Santorini (c) Milos
15. «Ήκαμενε» is unusual because…
    (a) it is stressed on the fourth syllable from the end (b) it has no augment (c) it is a Turkish loan

Glossary

άμος άμος — γάμος, 'wedding'

άφνιδα άφνιδα — ξαφνικά, 'suddenly'

έκασε έκασε — έκατσε, 'sat'

έρος έρος — γέρος, 'old man'

ήβγαλενε ήβγαλενε — έβγαλε, 'took out'

ήκαμενέ ήκαμενέ — έκανε, 'did'

ήκαμενε ήκαμενε — έκανε, 'did'

ήχυσα ήχυσα — έχυσα, 'I spilled'

αμέντε βάνω αμέντε — βάζω στο νου μου, 'keep in mind'

ανεμοσουσουρίδα ανεμοσουσουρίδα — ανεμοστρόβιλος, 'whirlwind'

ανοίω ανοίω — ανοίγω, 'open'

αρχίνησενε αρχίνησενε — άρχισε, 'began'

αυλάτσι αυλάτσι — αυλάκι, 'ditch'

γαμιώτης γαμιώτης — καλεσμένος σε γάμο, 'wedding guest'

γερόντους γερόντους — γέροντες, 'old men'

γιάντα γιάντα — γιατί, 'why'

Γροικά γροικά — ακούει, 'hears'

γυρεύγω γυρεύγω — γυρεύω, 'look for'

δερφακίδα δερφακίδα — γουρουνάκι, 'young pig'

δουλεύγω δουλεύγω — δουλεύω, 'work'

είντα είντα — τι, 'what'

εστεναχωρεθήκαμε εστεναχωρεθήκαμε — στενοχωρηθήκαμε, 'we were upset'

ζάκι ζάκι — τζάκι, 'fireplace'

ζάμι ζάμι — τζάμι, 'window pane'

ζάρω ζάρω — συνηθίζω, 'get used to'

ζίζικας ζίζικας — τζίτζικας, 'cicada'

ηχύσαμε ηχύσαμε — χύσαμε, 'we spilled'

θυατέρα θυατέρα — θυγατέρα, 'daughter'

κοτσάκια κοτσάκια — Naxian rhyming couplets

κόρνο κόρνο — κέρατο, 'horn'

μεάλος μεάλος — μεγάλος, 'big'

μούζα μούζα — μούτζα, rude hand gesture

μπονόρα μπονόρα — νωρίς, 'early'

πανηγύρι πανηγύρι — village feast

περισύρνω περισύρνω — σκουπίζω, 'sweep'

πεσί πεσί — πετσί, 'skin'

πιστεύγω πιστεύγω — πιστεύω, 'believe'

πράσσω πράσσω — συναναστρέφομαι, 'keep company'

σπάος σπάος — σπάγκος, 'string'

συχωρέσετε συχωρέσετε — συγχωρέσετε, 'forgive'

σύνεργο σύνεργο — αλέτρι, 'plough'

τραούδι τραούδι — τραγούδι, 'song'

τσέρατο τσέρατο — κέρατο, 'horn'

τσίρης τσίρης — κύρης, 'father, master'

τσαμπούνα τσαμπούνα — island bagpipe

τση τση — της

τσι τσι — τους, τις

τσιλιά τσιλιά — κοιλιά, 'belly'

φουντάνα φουντάνα — κρήνη, πηγή (Italian fontana)

χορεύγω χορεύγω — χορεύω, 'dance'

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Πελοποννησιακά και Επτανησιακά

The Peloponnese and the Ionian Islands: the dialects closest to the standard

For more than a century, Greeks were taught that their national language was 'based on Peloponnesian'. It is easy to see why: Peloponnesian and Ionian speech sound closer to Standard Modern Greek than any other dialect, the Peloponnese was the heart of the 1821 revolution, and the Ionian poets created modern Greek literature. But recent research has turned the story around. The Peloponnese has plenty of its own features (**πάω το χωριό**, **ήγλεπα**, **ομορφύτερος**), and much of its similarity to the standard may be the result of its speakers converging on Athenian usage, not the other way round. The Ionian Islands, never ruled by the Ottomans, have a Venetian accent of their own.

WHERE	Peloponnese (except Tsakonia and Mani); the Ionian Islands Corfu, Paxoi, Kefalonia, Ithaca and Zakynthos; western Epirus. **Lefkada** has northern vowels and belongs with Central Greece.
GROUP	Trudgill's **central** group: Peloponnese, Ionian Islands and western Epirus.
WRITTEN	The 14th-century «Χρονικό του Μορέως», in vernacular Greek; the Ionian School of poetry, 19th century.
HISTORY	Peloponnese: Frankish, Byzantine, Ottoman (1460), Venetian (1685–1715), Ottoman again until 1821. Ionian Islands: Venetian for up to four centuries, then French, Russian–Ottoman, British (1815–1864); union with Greece 1864.
STATUS	Strongly influenced by the standard; features survive in villages and in local accents, for example in Patras.



The Peloponnese: from the Morea to the new state · Ιστορία της Πελοποννήσου

6th–9th c.
Slavic tribes settle much of the Peloponnese. Byzantium re-Hellenises the region; Slavic place names remain (Αράχωβα, Βελιγοστή).

1205–1432
The Frankish **Principality of Achaea**. The «Χρονικό του Μορέως» tells its story in everyday Greek, full of French words.

1349–1460
The Byzantine **Despotate of the Morea** at Mystras, a last centre of Byzantine learning.

14th–15th c.
Albanian-speaking (Arvanite) settlers arrive in large numbers in Argolis, Corinthia and elsewhere.

1460–1821
Ottoman rule, interrupted by Venice (1685–1715).

1821–1834
The Revolution starts in the Peloponnese. Nafplio is the first capital of Greece (1829–1834); Peloponnesians move to the new capital Athens in large numbers.

Did Peloponnesian really become Standard Greek? · Η βάση της κοινής;

The traditional view, found in Mackridge, Browning and Kontosopoulos, is that the standard grew out of Peloponnesian and Ionian speech. Nikolaos Pantelidis and others now argue that this view rested more on history than on linguistic data: the Peloponnese led the Revolution, and Peloponnesians flooded into Athens. When the dialect material is studied closely, it shows many differences from the standard. The striking similarities may come from **convergence**: Peloponnesians were the first rural Greeks to adopt the new common language of Athens, and they did so early and thoroughly. Whether there was ever a single 'Peloponnesian koine' is unknown. See the **History** page for how the standard actually formed, from a mix of urban Athenian speech, Peloponnesian and Ionian input, and the refugee speech of the 19th and 20th centuries.

Peloponnesian: sounds · Φωνολογία

Feature	Peloponnese	Standard
Some unstressed **ι, ου, ε** lost, less than in the north	**σκώνεται**, **ίμνα**, **κοτόπλο**	σηκώνεται, ήμουνα, κοτόπουλο
[j] inserted between vowels	**δίγιο**, **τρίγια**, **η γιαδερφή μ'**	δύο, τρία, η αδερφή μου
ι inserted before a nasal	**καπινός**	καπνός
Sibilants not palatalised	**κλοτσά**, **κορίτσα**	κλοτσιά, κορίτσια
Some tsitakismos	**τσεφάλι**, **καλοτσαίρι**	κεφάλι, καλοκαίρι
γμ simplified	**σφαμένος**, **βουτημένος**, **στιμή**	σφαγμένος, βουτηγμένος, στιγμή

Even in a big city close to Athens the dialect is not gone: in Patras, Dimitris Papazachariou found several non-standard pronunciations of **λ**, used differently according to speakers' origin, gender and education.

Peloponnesian: grammar and words · Μορφολογία, σύνταξη, λεξιλόγιο

Feature	Peloponnese	Standard

Feature	Peloponnese	Standard
Adjectives in **-ύς** become **-ιος**	**βαριός**, **παχιός**	βαρύς, παχύς
Comparatives in **-ύτερος**	**τρανύτερος**, **ομορφύτερος**, **μπροστύτερα**	μεγαλύτερος, ομορφότερος, μπροστά
Plural of masculines in **-ας**: **-οι**	**μήνοι**, **χειμώνοι**, **γειτόνοι**, **αρχόντοι**	μήνες, χειμώνες, γείτονες, άρχοντες
Plural of **-άρης**: **-αραίοι**	**καρβουνιαραίοι**, **διακονιαραίοι**	καρβουνιάρηδες, ζητιάνοι
Augment **η-**, even unstressed	**ήφερνα**, **ήγλεπα**, **ήπρεπε**	έφερνα, έβλεπα, έπρεπε
3rd plural passive imperfect **-σαντε**	**ήσαντε**, **καθόσαντε**, **λεγόσαντε**	ήταν, κάθονταν, λέγονταν
Place without a preposition	**πάω το χωριό**	πάω στο χωριό
Pronouns and adverbs	**αυτούνος**, **τίποτις**, **απάνου**, **χάμου**, **σαπέρα**, **σακείθε**	αυτός, τίποτα, επάνω, κάτω, εκεί πέρα, προς τα εκεί
Prepositions and conjunctions	**οχ** / **αχ** 'from', **όντας** / **αφόντις** 'when', **μούδε** 'nor', **ήτε** 'neither'	από, όταν, μήτε, ούτε

Several of these, such as **τρανύτερος**, **λέγανε** and **όντας**, are also heard in Athens, because Peloponnesians were so many of its 19th-century settlers.

The Ionian Islands: Greek under Venice · Ιστορία των Επτανήσων

> **1386–1797**
> Corfu under Venice; Zakynthos from 1485, Kefalonia and Ithaca from 1500, Lefkada from 1684. Italian is the language of the nobility and administration; the islands are the only part of Greece the Ottomans never held for long.
>
> **1669**
> After the fall of Candia, Cretan refugees bring the literature of the Cretan Renaissance to the islands.
>
> **1797–1815**
> French rule, then the **Septinsular Republic** (1800–1807), the first autonomous Greek state of modern times.
>
> **1815–1864**
> British protectorate. The **Ionian Academy** in Corfu (1824) is the first Greek university.
>
> **1820s–1860s**
> The **Ionian School** of poets (Solomos, Kalvos, later Valaoritis and Mavilis) proves that spoken Greek can carry great poetry.
>
> **1864**
> Union with Greece.

Ionian: sounds and grammar · Επτανησιακά

The most recognisable Ionian feature is not a vowel or a consonant but the **intonation**, the sing-song melody of Corfu and Zakynthos. The vowels are southern and close to the standard.

Feature	Ionian	Standard

μπ, ντ without the nasal	**αμπέλι** [abéli], **άντρας** [ádras]	[ambéli], [ándras]
γ lost between vowels	**καλόερος**	καλόγερος
Article **τσου, τση, τσι**	**τσου χωριάτες**, **τσι μέρες**, **τση κοπελός**, **τσ' αρχόντους**	τους χωριάτες, τις μέρες, της κοπέλας, τους άρχοντες
Genitive of feminines in **-ός**	**νυχτός**, **μερός**, **βδομαδός**, **ομπρελλός**	νύχτας, μέρας, βδομάδας, ομπρέλας
Final **-ε** added	**των ανθρωπώνε**, **ποιόνε**, **γράφουνε**	των ανθρώπων, ποιον, γράφουν
Augment kept, even unstressed	**εκάμαμε**, **επήγαμε**, **εβαρέθηκα**	κάναμε, πήγαμε, βαρέθηκα
Passives in **-ιόμαι**	**τραβιόμαι**, **κρατιόμαι**, **θυμιόμαι**	τραβιέμαι, κρατιέμαι, θυμάμαι
Diminutives **-έλι**, **-πούλα**, **-ίτσι**	**ποτηρέλι**, **πορτοπούλα**, **ποδαρίτσι**	ποτηράκι, πορτούλα, ποδαράκι

Ionian words · Λεξιλόγιο

Ionian	Meaning	Standard / source
παλαιούθε	from long ago	από παλιά
μου 'κάζεται	I suppose	νομίζω
κάμε κόντο	probably	πιθανώς (Italian *conto*)
νεράντζι	orange	πορτοκάλι (in the standard: bitter orange)
λάχανα	wild greens	χόρτα
γλυκά	sugared almonds	κουφέτα
προβατώ	walk	περπατώ
πρόσφωρο	match	σπίρτο
άμπιτα	clothes	ρούχα (Italian *abito*)
ντακάπο	from the start	από την αρχή (Italian *da capo*)
πάγα	wages	μισθός (Italian *paga*)
σκάτουλα	box	κουτί (Italian *scatola*)
μόντε	pawnshop	ενεχυροδανειστήριο (Italian *monte di pietà*)
ντέμπολος	thin, weak	αδύνατος (Italian *debole*)

«Ύμνος εις την Ελευθερίαν», by Dionysios Solomos

Written on Zakynthos in 1823; its first stanzas became the Greek national anthem. Solomos, raised speaking Italian, chose the spoken Greek of his island for his poetry. Public domain.

Σε γνωρίζω από την κόψη
του σπαθιού την τρομερή,
σε γνωρίζω από την όψη
που με βιά μετράει τη γη.
Απ' τα κόκαλα βγαλμένη

των Ελλήνων τα ιερά,
και σαν πρώτα ανδρειωμένη,
χαίρε, ω χαίρε, Ελευθεριά!

I know you by the terrible edge
of your sword,
I know you by the look
with which you swiftly measure the earth.
Risen from the sacred bones
of the Greeks,
and brave as you were before,
hail, o hail, Liberty!

Διονύσιος Σολωμός, «Ύμνος εις την Ελευθερίαν» (1823), stanzas 1–2.

Kantades and the Philharmonic bands

The Venetian legacy is still audible in the Ionian **καντάδες**, serenades sung in harmony to guitar and mandolin, and in the philharmonic brass bands of Corfu, which play at every Easter procession. On Corfu, people still use dozens of Italian words in daily life. In the Peloponnese, Kalamata's **καλαματιανός** is the dance that every Greek wedding plays.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

46. What do many linguists now think about Peloponnesian as the 'basis' of Standard Greek?
(a) The similarity may come from Peloponnesian converging on Athenian usage (b) It is certain (c) The standard comes from Cretan

47. «Πάω το χωριό» means…
(a) I'm going to the village (b) I'm leaving the village (c) I'm visiting the village square

48. In the Ionian Islands, «νυχτός» is…
(a) the genitive of νύχτα (b) a kind of bird (c) an adjective 'nightly'

49. Why are there so many Italian words on Corfu?
(a) Four centuries of Venetian rule (b) Italian rule in 1941–43 only (c) Tourism

50. Which Ionian island has northern vowels?
(a) Lefkada (b) Zakynthos (c) Corfu

Glossary

'κάζεται μου 'κάζεται — νομίζω, 'I suppose'
άμπιτα άμπιτα — ρούχα, 'clothes'
ήγλεπα ήγλεπα — έβλεπα, 'I was seeing'
ήπρεπε ήπρεπε — έπρεπε, 'it was necessary'
ήσαντε ήσαντε — ήταν, 'they were'
ήτε ήτε — ούτε, 'neither'
ήφερνα ήφερνα — έφερνα, 'I was bringing'
ίμνα ίμνα — ήμουνα, 'I was'
ανδρειωμένη ανδρειωμένη — γενναία, 'brave'
ανθρωπώνε ανθρωπώνε — ανθρώπων
απάνου απάνου — επάνω, 'up'
αρχόντοι αρχόντοι — άρχοντες, 'lords'
αυτούνος αυτούνος — αυτός, 'this one'
αφόντις αφόντις — όταν, αφότου
αχ αχ — από, 'from' (Peloponnese)
βαριός βαριός — βαρύς, 'heavy'
βδομαδός βδομαδός — βδομάδας (genitive)
βιά βιά — βία, ορμή; με βιά = swiftly, forcefully
γειτόνοι γειτόνοι — γείτονες, 'neighbours'
γιαδερφή η γιαδερφή — η αδερφή, 'the sister'
γράφουνε γράφουνε — γράφουν
δίγιο δίγιο — δύο, 'two'
διακονιαραίοι διακονιαραίοι — ζητιάνοι, 'beggars'
εβαρέθηκα εβαρέθηκα — βαρέθηκα, 'I got bored'

εκάμαμε εκάμαμε — κάναμε, 'we did'

Ελευθεριά Ελευθεριά — ελευθερία, 'liberty'

επήγαμε επήγαμε — πήγαμε, 'we went'

θυμιόμαι θυμιόμαι — θυμάμαι, 'I remember'

καθόσαντε καθόσαντε — κάθονταν, 'they were sitting'

καλαματιανός καλαματιανός — dance from Kalamata

καλοτσαίρι καλοτσαίρι — καλοκαίρι, 'summer'

καλόερος καλόερος — καλόγερος, 'monk'

καντάδες καντάδες — Ionian serenades

καπινός καπινός — καπνός, 'smoke'

καρβουνιαραίοι καρβουνιαραίοι — καρβουνιάρηδες, 'charcoal men'

κλοτσά κλοτσά — κλοτσιά, 'kick'

κοπελός κοπελός — κοπέλας (genitive)

κορίτσα κορίτσα — κορίτσια, 'girls'

κοτόπλο κοτόπλο — κοτόπουλο, 'chicken'

κρατιόμαι κρατιόμαι — κρατιέμαι

κόντο κάμε κόντο — πιθανώς, 'probably'

λεγόσαντε λεγόσαντε — λέγονταν, 'they were called'

μήνοι μήνοι — μήνες, 'months'

μερός μερός — μέρας (genitive)

μούδε μούδε — μήτε, 'nor'

μπροστύτερα μπροστύτερα — πιο μπροστά, 'further ahead'

μόντε μόντε — ενεχυροδανειστήριο, 'pawnshop'

νεράντζι νεράντζι — πορτοκάλι (Ionian), 'orange'

ντέμπολος ντέμπολος — αδύνατος, 'weak'

ντακάπο ντακάπο — από την αρχή

νυχτός νυχτός — νύχτας (genitive)

ομορφύτερος ομορφύτερος — ομορφότερος, 'more beautiful'

ομπρελλός ομπρελλός — ομπρέλας (genitive)

οχ οχ — από, 'from' (Peloponnese)

πάγα πάγα — μισθός, 'wages'

παλαιούθε παλαιούθε — από παλιά, 'from long ago'

παχιός παχιός — παχύς, 'fat'

ποδαρίτσι ποδαρίτσι — ποδαράκι, 'little foot'

ποιόνε ποιόνε — ποιον, 'whom'

πορτοπούλα πορτοπούλα — πορτούλα, 'little door'

ποτηρέλι ποτηρέλι — ποτηράκι, 'little glass'

προβατώ προβατώ — περπατώ, 'walk'

πρόσφωρο πρόσφωρο — σπίρτο (Ionian), 'match'

σακείθε σακείθε — προς τα εκεί, 'that way'

σαπέρα σαπέρα — εκεί πέρα, 'over there'

σκάτουλα σκάτουλα — κουτί, 'box'

σκώνεται σκώνεται — σηκώνεται, 'gets up'

στιμή στιμή — στιγμή, 'moment'

σφαμένος σφαμένος — σφαγμένος, 'slaughtered'

τίποτις τίποτις — τίποτα, 'nothing'

τρίγια τρίγια — τρία, 'three'

τραβιόμαι τραβιόμαι — τραβιέμαι

τρανύτερος τρανύτερος — μεγαλύτερος, 'bigger'

τσεφάλι τσεφάλι — κεφάλι, 'head'

τση τση — της

τσι τσι — τις, τους

τσου τσου — τους

χάμου χάμου — κάτω, 'down, on the ground'

χειμώνοι χειμώνοι — χειμώνες, 'winters'

όντας όντας — όταν, 'when'

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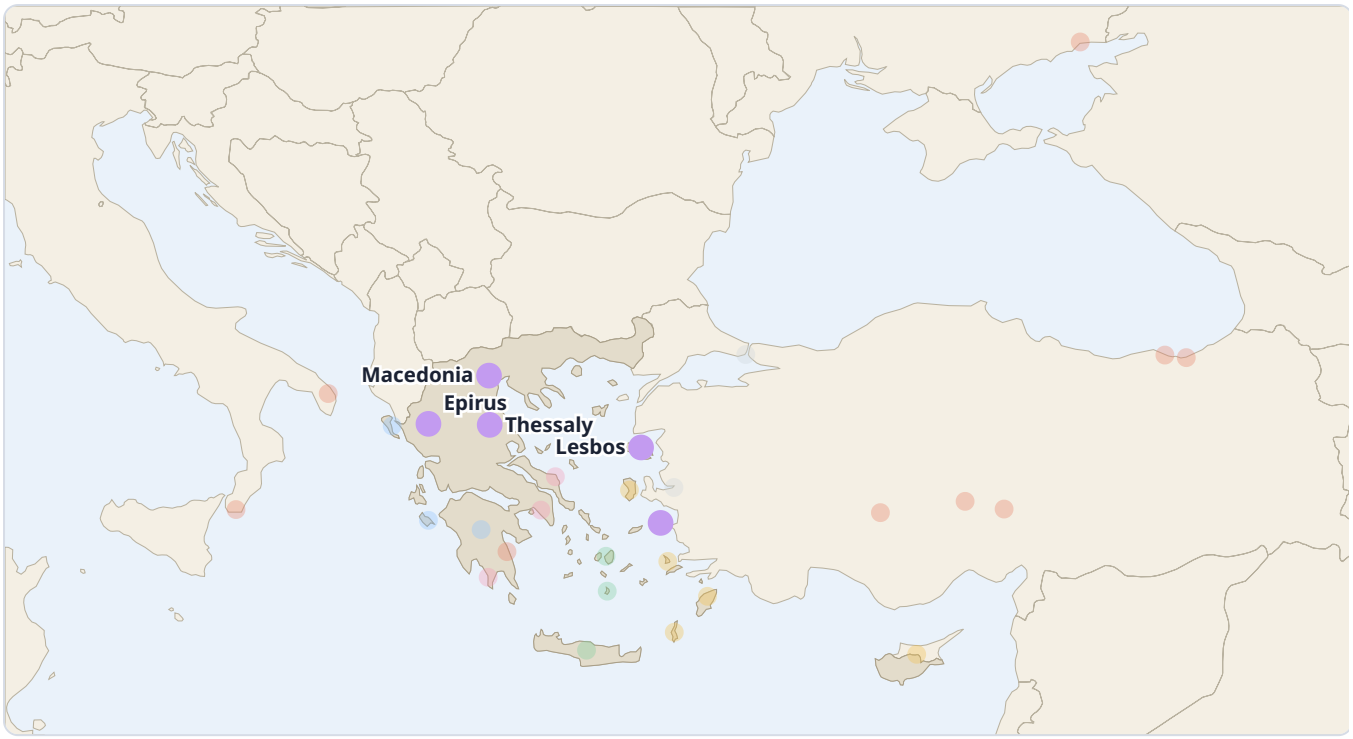
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Βόρεια ιδιώματα

Northern Greek: the dialects that swallow their vowels

Listen to an old shepherd from Roumeli or Thessaly and you may hear **«ου Νίκους πήγι στου χουράφ'»** for **«ο Νίκος πήγε στο χωράφι»**. That is the northern vowel system: unstressed **ι** and **ου** disappear, and unstressed **ε** and **ο** rise to **ι** and **ου**. It covers almost all of mainland Greece north of the Gulf of Corinth, plus Euboea, Lesbos, Samos, the northern Sporades and, until 1922, much of the Asia Minor and East Thracian coast. Since the 19th century the north has been the Greek mainland's great meeting place: Vlachs, Arvanites, Slavic speakers, Sephardic Jews, Turks and, after 1922, hundreds of thousands of refugees from Asia Minor and the Pontus. Northern features are still the most recognisable regional accent in Greece, from the dark **λ** of Thessaloniki to the famous **«σε λέω»**.

WHERE	From the north shore of the Gulf of Corinth to the northern border: Central Greece (Roumeli), Epirus (except Thesprotia), Thessaly, Macedonia, Thrace, Euboea, Lesbos, Lemnos, Samos, Imbros, Samothrace, the northern Sporades; parts of Andros and Tinos; before 1922 north-west Asia Minor, East Thrace and the Propontis.
DISCOVERED BY	Georgios Hatzidakis, who first divided Greek dialects into northern and southern by their vowels.
SEMI-NORTHERN	Skyros, Mykonos, Kastoria, Lefkada, Naousa, Lefkes on Paros, Vourbiani in Epirus, eastern East Thrace, Artaki, Livisi.
JOINED GREECE	Thessaly and Arta 1881; Macedonia, Epirus and the north-eastern Aegean 1912–13; Western Thrace 1920.
STATUS	Full dialects survive among older villagers; features such as **σε λέω** and the dark **λ** are widespread in everyday speech.



Where the northern vowels come from · Ιστορία

Nobody knows exactly when northern vowel reduction began. It is not ancient and is not clearly attested in Byzantine texts; it is usually placed in the late medieval or Ottoman period. Hatzidakis explained it by a strong **stress accent**: the stressed syllable was pronounced so forcefully that the unstressed ones shrank or vanished. Later scholars such as Symeonidis and Synodinou refined the idea, but the basic explanation is still accepted.

The north's history explains the rest. Ottoman Rumelia was a land of mixed villages. Greek lived beside Aromanian (Vlach), Albanian, Slavic, Turkish and, in Thessaloniki, the Judaeo-Spanish of the Sephardic Jews who arrived after 1492. When the north joined Greece between 1881 and 1920, and then received the refugees of 1922–23, the old dialects met Pontic, Cappadocian and Asia Minor Greek. In Macedonia and Thrace, refugee speech and local speech blended under the growing influence of Standard Greek.

> **Byzantine era**
> No clear sign yet of northern vowel loss in the written record.
>
> **15th–19th c.**
> Ottoman Rumelia: Greek in contact with Aromanian, Albanian, Slavic, Turkish and Judaeo-Spanish. Northern vocalism spreads across the mainland and to the Asia Minor coast.
>
> **1881–1920**
> Thessaly, then Macedonia, Epirus and Thrace join Greece.
>
> **1922–23**
> The population exchange: more than a million refugees, many of them settled in Macedonia and Thrace.
>
> **Today**
> Thessaloniki's urban speech keeps a few northern traits, which Greeks immediately recognise.

The northern vowel system · Βόρειος φωνηεντισμός

Change	Northern	Standard
Unstressed **ι** and **ου** dropped	**χέρ'**, **πηγάδ'**, **σκλι**, **πλάου**, **δλεβ'**	χέρι, πηγάδι, σκυλί, πουλάω, δουλεύει

…even inside phrases	**τ' Χάρ'**, **στ' Λάμπ' τ'ς μύλ'**	του Χάρου, στου Λάμπου τους μύλους
Unstressed **ε** raised to **ι**	**φιγγάρ'**	φεγγάρι
Unstressed **ο** raised to **ου**	**χουράφ'**, **ου Νίκους**	χωράφι, ο Νίκος

Strict northern dialects do both things: drop **ι, ου** and raise **ε, ο**. **Semi-northern** dialects usually only drop final **ι** (and often unstressed **ι, ου** inside words) without raising; in Naousa it is the reverse. In Amfissa the raised vowels stop half-way, between [e] and [i].

What happens to the consonants · Σύμφωνα

Feature	Northern	Standard
New clusters change shape	**δκός** / **θκός**, **χαμλός** / **χαμπλός**	δικός, χαμηλός
Several words collapse into one	**φτο** can mean βουτώ, φυτό, φτύνω or βοηθώ	
A **τ** appears where **ι** was lost	**μέλτσα**, **θέλτς**	μέλισσα, θέλεις
σ, ζ, τσ, τζ palatalised before **ι**	**σ̆ήμιρα**, **σ̆τάρ'**, **τσ̆ίχλα**, **πικρούτσ̆κος**	σήμερα, σιτάρι, τσίχλα, πικρούτσικος
Dark **λ** before **α, ο, ου** (as in English *well*)	Epirus, Macedonia and elsewhere	clear λ
λ as a short [u] in some places	**καουά**	καλά
λ, ν palatalised before **ε**	**αλι̯εύρι**, **Ιλι̯έν'**	αλεύρι, Ελένη
Samothrace drops **λ** and **ρ**	**γάμματα**	γράμματα
-ς + **μου** gives **-ζ-ουμ**	**ου πατέραζ-ουμ**, **ου θ'κόζ-ιμ**	ο πατέρας μου, ο δικός μου

Other sound changes · Άλλα φαινόμενα

Feature	Northern	Standard
Incomplete synizesis: [j] before stressed **α** sounds like open **ε**	**αχλαδέ̯α**, **παλαμαρέ̯α**	αχλαδιά, παλαμαριά
γ inserted (Thrace, Lesbos, Imbros)	**τρίγια**, **Τουρκίγια**, **γιένας**	τρία, Τουρκία, ένας
Prothetic **α-** (Imbros)	**αγλήγουρα**, **αχιλώνα**, **αραβδί**	γρήγορα, χελώνα, ραβδί
ι inserted in hard clusters	**Λαμπιργιά** (Lemnos)	Λαμπρή
Stress on the fourth syllable from the end	**έφαγαμι**, **έπιζαμι** (Aetolia, Thrace, Langadas)	φάγαμε, παίζαμε

Grammar · Μορφολογία

Feature	Northern	Standard
Masculine article **ου** (Central Greece, Euboea, Epirus, western Macedonia) or **η** (central and eastern Macedonia, Lesbos, Thessaly)	**ου Νίκους**, **η Νίκους**, **η παππούς**	ο Νίκος, ο παππούς
Diminutives **-ούδ'**, **-έλ'**, **-ούλ'**	**πιδούδ'** (Thrace), **κουρ'τσέλ'** (Lesbos), **κουρ'τσούλ'** (W. Macedonia)	παιδάκι, κοριτσάκι
Genitive replaced by **από** + accusative	**απ' τ'ς λαγοί**	των λαγών
Lesbos genitive plural **-ιούν**	**ντουν ανθρωπιούν**	των ανθρώπων
Aorist in **-κα** (Epirus, Thrace, Kastoria)	**εχτύπηκα**	χτύπησα
1st and 2nd plural **-μαν**, **-ταν**	**τρώγαμαν**, **καήκαταν**	τρώγαμε, καήκατε
Contracted verbs (Macedonia)	**τραγ'δώ**	τραγουδάω

«Σε λέω»: the accusative indirect object · Σύνταξη

The best-known northern feature is syntactic. Where the standard uses a **genitive** for the person you say or give something to (**σου λέω**, **του το είπα**), northern speakers use the **accusative**, as do the Asia Minor dialects. It is so recognisable that it shapes how other Greeks judge northern speakers, and Thessalonians use it proudly.

> Σε λέω.
> **STANDARD:** Σου λέω.
> I'm telling you.

> Σε κάνω ένα δώρο.
> **STANDARD:** Σου κάνω ένα δώρο.
> I'm giving you a present.

> Θα τον πω.
> **STANDARD:** Θα του (το) πω.
> I'll tell him.

> Σε είπα να μην πας.
> **STANDARD:** Σου είπα να μην πας.
> I told you not to go.

Semi-northern islands and towns · Ημιβόρεια ιδιώματα

- **Skyros**: nouns in **-ος** end in **-ες** (**ο άντζελες**, 'the angel'), **τσαι** for **και**, and **είντα** for 'what'.
- **Mykonos**: **κ** as [tʃ] and **γκ** as [dʒ], aorists in **-ξα** (**να σε ρωτήξω κάτι;**), and pronouns after the verb (**δεν έχομέ τις** 'we don't have them').
- **East Thrace**: **γ** before initial vowels (**γηύρε** 'he found'), **τις** for masculine 'them' (**τις στόχ'σα** 'I forgot them'), **εκάνανα** for **έκαναν**.
- **Artaki** (Propontis): masculine article **e**, diminutives in **-έρ**.
- **Livisi** (Lycia): raising without vowel loss, **η αγιασμέ** 'holy water', **έκουσα** 'I heard', **αφεντάδοι** 'masters'. Its people moved to Greece in 1923; the abandoned town (Kayaköy) inspired Louis de Bernières's novel «Birds Without Wings».

Listen: the Vallahades of Grevena

The **Vallahades** were Greek-speaking Muslims of the Grevena area in western Macedonia. In 1923 the exchange of populations sent them to Turkey; the village of **Mursallı** has been home since then to families from Gublar (today Μυρσίνη). Their Greek kept the northern vowel system: unstressed **ε → ι**, **ο → ου**, and unstressed **ι, ου** dropped (πουλιά → πλια, κοιμήσου → κμήσ'). Recordings from the VLACH archive of the Austrian Academy of Sciences, played from its YouTube channel and not stored in the app.

In the app these recordings play inside the page, with subtitles you can tap. Here each one is listed with its link.

Σιλιμάν, τα πουλιά κι μυλουνάς · Suleiman, the chickens and the miller

Konuk Serap, Mursallı, tells a story her grandfather from Gublar used to tell.

Watch: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=m_dJ-spfq-8

Listen for: ιγώ, ιδώ, απόψι (ε → ι); στου μύλου, πάνου (ο → ου); έδιρι, βγήκι (final ε → ι); κμήσ', σπίτ' (lost vowels); Turkish loans σαχίν, εμ.

0:13	Μι μουλουγούσι δέδες στου Γκουμπλάρ: Mi muluɣúɛi dédes stu Gublár:	*My grandfather from Gublar (Myrsini) told me:*
0:18	Ήταν τσουτσανός. Ítan ʦuʦanós.	*Once there was a boy.*
0:19	Λέει η μάνα τ': «Σιλιμάν», λε, «ιγώ θα πάνου σ' κουμπσίσα», λε. ʎeĭ i mána-t: <Syʎimán,> ʎe, <iɣó θa pánu s kumpɛíɛa,> ʎe.	*His mother said: <Suleiman, I will go to the neighbour.*
0:23	«Τήρα κουσάρια μι τα πλια», λε, <Téra kusária mi ta pʎa,> ʎe,	*Keep an eye on the hen with the chickens,*
0:25	«να μη τα παρ' κανά γιράκ'», λε, «κι να μη τα φάει», λε. <na mi ta par kaná ɟirák,> ʎe, <k'i na mi ta faĭ,> ʎe.	*so that the hawk will not take and eat them.>*
0:30	Πάει αυτήν σ' γιτουνιά. Αυτός χάλιβι να παίξ'. Paĭ aftín ʒ-ɟitunǽ. Aftós χáʎivi na pékɛ.	*She went to the neighbourhood. He wanted to play.*
0:34	Εμ, τώρα να τ' αφήκ', α φύγουν. Em, tóra na t-afík', a fíɣun.	*But if he leaves them alone, they'll run away.*
0:38	Του πήρι... τα πήρι τα πλια, πουδάρ' πουδάρ' πουδάρ' τ' άδισι. Tu píri -- ta píri ta pʎa, puðár puðár puðár t-áðiɛi.	*So he took the chickens and tied them by their feet.*
0:42	Τ' άδισι κι ν' κουσάρα, πάει να παίξ'. T-áðiɛi k'i ŋ-gusárà, paĭ na pekɛ.	*He also tied the hen and went to play.*
0:46	Ήρσι του σαχίν, του γιράκ', τα πήρι όλα, έφυι. Írɛi tu ɛaçíɲ, tu ɟerák', ta píri óla, éfii.	*The hawk came, took them all and left.*
0:49	Ήρθι η μάνα τ': «Πού είνι, Σιλιμάν, τα πλια μι ν' κότα;» λε. Írθi i mána-t: <Pu íɲi, Syʎimán, ta pʎa m-iɲ- góta?> ʎe.	*His mother came: <Where are the chickens with the hen?>*
0:53	«Τα πήρι, μάνα», λε. Τουν έδιρι μάνα τ'. <Ta píri, mána,> ʎe. Tun éðiri mána-t.	*<It took them, mother.> His mother hit him.*
0:56	Αυτός κλαίουντας κλαίουντας πάει στου μύλου. Aftós kléundas-kʎéundas paĭ stu mílu.	*Weeping he ran to the mill.*

1:00	Λέει αυτός ι μύλους, μυλουνάς: «Τι κλαις ρα, Σιλιμάν;» λε. ʎeĭ aftós i míʎus, milunás: <Ti kʎes ra, Syʎimánʔ> ʎe.	*The miller asked: <Why are you crying, Suleiman?>*
1:07	«Για», λέει, «πάει η μάνα μ' γιτνιά, έτσας κι έτσας έκαμα <Ĭa,> ʎeĭ, <paĭ i mána-m jityɲá étɕas k'-étɕas ékama	*<My mother went to the neighbour. This and that happened*
1:10	κι μ' έδιρι», λε. k'i m-édiri,> ʎe.	*and she hit me.>*
1:12	«Κάτσι ιδώ απόψι», λέει, «κμήσ'. Ιγώ θα φύγου», λε. <Kátɕi iðó apópɕi,> ʎeĭ, <k'imís. Iɣó θa fíɣu,> ʎe.	*<Stay and sleep here tonight. I will go,> he said.*
1:16	Πάει στου μύλου, κμήθκι, ξύπνισι τ' νύχτα, βγήκι όξου. Paĭ stu mílu, k'imíθk'i, ɕípɲiɕi t-ɲíχta, vík'i óksu.	*He went to the mill to sleep. In the night he woke up and went out.*
1:20	Άφκι μ' πόρτα ανοιχτή, πάει του γουρούν', ε, τ' όφαϊ τ' αλεύρ'. Áfk'i ɱ-bórta aɲixtí, paĭ tu ɣurún, é, t-ófai t- aʎévr'.	*He left the door open. Then the pig came and ate the flour.*
1:24	Ήρθι τ' χαραΐ μυλουνάς: «Σιλιμάν», λέει, «πού είνι τ' αλεύρ';» λε. Írθi t-χaraí milunás: <Syʎimánʔ> ʎeĭ, <pu íɲi t-aʎévr'?> ʎe.	*At dawn, the miller came back: <Suleiman, where is the flour?>*
1:30	«Τ' όφαϊ του γουρούν'», λε. Τουν έδιρι κι αυτός. <T-ófaĭ tu ɣurún,> ʎe. Tun édiri k'-aftós.	*<The pig ate it>. And so, he hit him too.*
1:35	Βγήκι όξου. Βρήκι έναν... Ρουμνιός. Vík'i óksu. Vrík'i énàn -- Rumɲós.	*He went out and found a (Christian) Greek.*
1:39	«Τι κρες ρα, Σιλιμάν;» λε. <Ti kres ra, Syʎemánʔ> ʎe.	*<Why do you cry, Suleiman?> he said.*
1:40	«Έτσ' άιας κι έτσ' άιας», λε, «μ' έδιρι η μάνα μ'», λέει. <Etɕ áĭas k'-etɕ áĭas,> ʎe, <m-éðiri i mána-m,> ʎeĭ.	*<This and that happened. My mother hit me,> he said.*
1:44	«Πήγα στου μύλου. <Píɣa stu mílu.	*<I went to the mill.*
1:45	Έφαϊ του γουρούν' τ' αλεύρ'», λέει. «Μ' έδιρι κι αυτός», λε. Éfai tu ɣurún t-aʎévr',> ʎeĭ. <M-édiri k'-aftós,> ʎe.	*The pork ate the flour. And that man hit me too.>*
1:49	«Έλα, να σι πάρου ιγώ να γέντσ' θκο μ' πιδί», λε. <Éla, na ɕi páru iɣó na ĭénʦ θkó-m piðí,> ʎe.	*<Come, I will take you to become my child.>*
1:52	Γιατί ήταν Ρουμνός. Κλαίουντας πάει πάλι στου σπίτ'. Jatí itan Rumnós. Kʎéundas paĭ páʎi stu ɕpit'.	*Because he was a Greek. And so he ran back home crying.*
1:56	Δεν πάισι... Ðen-báĭsi ---.	*Do not go to ---.*
1:58	Αυτό μι μουλουγούσι. Aftó mi muluɣúɕi.	*That is what he told me.*

Syʌimán, ta puʌá k'i milunás – Suleiman, the chickens and the miller; performer: Konuk Serap; camera/interview: Thede Kahl, Andreea Pascaru; transcription/translation: Thede Kahl, Sotirios Rousiakis; editor: Helmut Sandeck; retrieved from www.oeaw.ac.at/VLACH, ID number: mace1251TRV0002a.

Η χαρά · The wedding

Azem Altay, Mursallı, on the wedding days and the food served.

Watch: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0ytf7T7j6kY

Listen for: χαρά for 'wedding'; the weekdays Πέφτ' and Σάβατου; Turkish words for things of daily life (μπαϊράκ', νταβετλής, τσουρβάν, έβετ).

0:13	Ν' Κυριακή έβαναμι του μπαϊράκ'. Χιρνούσι η χαρά. Ɲ-g'ir'ák'í évanami tu baĭrák'. Çirnúɛi i χará.	*On Sunday we put the wedding flag. The marriage started.*
0:20	Μ' Πέφτ' μέρα πήαμ, πάιναμι ταχνά μι του ζγουρ'. Ɱ-beft' méra píam, páĭnami taçná mi tu ʒyur.	*On Thursday morning we went and brought the lamb.*
0:25	Του ζγουρ', τσ' νύφς τα κιαφέτια, Tu ʒgur, ʦ ɲifs ta kɯafétĭa,	*The lamb and the bride's clothes,*
0:31	ταχνά τα πάιναμι. taçná ta páĭnami.	*we brought them in the morning.*
0:37	Μας έδουναν ψουμί ικεί, εκάθουμασταν, έτρουγαμι ψουμί. Mas éðunan psumí ik'i, ekáθumastan, étruɣami psumí.	*There they gave us bread [food] and we had a meal.*
0:42	Χουσαβέρ γυρνούσαμι, έρουμασταν πάλι ιδώ. Husavér jirnúsami, érumastan páʌi iðó.	*Then we returned.*
0:46	Του Σάβατου μι ν' Κυριακή έβαναμι τα βιουλιά. Tu Savátu mi ɲ-g'ir'ak'í évanámi ta vjuʌá.	*On Saturday and Sunday the violins [musicians] played.*
0:50	Λαλούσαν, χόριβναν, ίπιναν. Lalúsan, χórivnan, ípçinan.	*They played, they danced, they drank.*
0:54	Ν' Κυριακή τ' μέρα ύστιρα μι του κουμβόι πάιναμι να πάρουμι τ' νύφ'. Ɲ-g'ir'ak'í t-méra íɕtirà mi tu kumvóĭ páĭnami na párumi t-ɲif'.	*Later on Sunday, we went in a group to take the bride.*
1:02	Ούλου του χουριό, όπιους ήνταν νταβετλής. Úlu tu χurjó, ópçus índan dávetʌís.	*All those invited from the village,*
1:07	Του ν' έκραϊγάν, πάιναν, έπιρναν τ' νύφ'. Έρουμασταν. Tuɲ-ékraĭɣán, páinan, épirnan t-ɲif'. Érumastan.	*The guests went to take the bride. We came back.*
1:15	Οι χαρές μας έτσ' γένουνταν. I χarés mas ĭeʦ jénundan.	*That was how our marriages were.*
1:16	— Τα φαγιά; Τι φαγιά έφκιαναν; — Α, φαγιά: - Ta faĭá? Tí faĭá éfk'anan? - Á, faĭá:	*- What kind of food did they make? - Ah, food:*
1:21	Μπακλαβάν έφκιαναμι, φασούλια, μουσακάν, τσουρβάν, ριζ, κιμπάπ. Ɱbaklaván éfk'anami, fasúʌa, musakán, ʦurván, riʒ, k'ibáp.	*We made baklava, beans, moussaka, soup, rise, kebab.*
1:33	— Πίτις; — Πίτις έφκιαναμι, μπιρέκια. - Pítis? - Pítis éfk'anami, birék'a.	*- Pies? - We made pies, bourek.*

1:36	— Ύστιρα κι μουσακά. — Ναι, είπεν για μουσακά. Άμα... - Ístira ki musaká. - Ne, ípen ja musaká. Áma --	*- Finally, moussaka. - Yes, he mentioned moussaka. But --*
1:42	— Μι πράσα μουσακά. - Mi prása musaká.	*- Moussaka with leek.*
1:44	— Νύφις παλιά πέρναν κι από άλλα χουριά; - Nífis paʎá pérnan k'-apo ála χurjá?	*- But did you marry brides from other villages?*
1:46	— Έρουνταν, έπερναν. — Έπερναν κι από χριστιανό; - Érundan, épernan. - Épernan k'i apó χristĭanó?	*- Yes, we did. - Also from Christians?*
1:54	— Όχι, όχι. — Δεν έπερναν. Τώρα πέρουν. Τώρα... - Óçi, óçi. - Ðen épernan. Tóra pérun. Tóra ---	*- No, no. - They didn't. But now they do.*
1:59	— Αρβανίτ', μι τσ' αρβανίτ', πρώτα δεν είχαμε τέτοιο. - Arvanít, mi ts-arvanít, próta ðen éxame tétço.	*- Before, we didn't even mix with the Albanians.*
2:02	Τώρα, τώρα το ίρχισαν. Tóra, tóra to írçisan.	*Now they've started to.*
2:06	— Εδώ στου χουριό, στου Μουρσαλί; — Έβετ, έβετ. - Eðó stu χurjó, stu Mursaluɯ? - Évet, évet.	*- Here in the village, in Mursallı? - Yes, yes.*

I xará – Marriage; performer: Azem Altay; camera/interview: Thede Kahl, Andreea Pascaru; transcription/translation: Thede Kahl, Sotirios Rousiakis; editor: Helmut Sandeck; retrieved from www.oeaw.ac.at/VLACH, ID number: mace1251TRV0003a.

Giannis and Marulio (Thracian song)

Tasoula Papavasiliou, Proskynites (Rodopi), sings a tragic love song brought from Mikro Bogialiki in North Thrace, today Malko Sharkovo in Bulgaria.

Watch: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5pwa_m3d0lE

VLACH has not published a timed transcription of this clip, so it plays without app subtitles.

Giannis and Marulio; performer: Tasoula Papavasiliou; Vanishing Languages and Cultural Heritage (VLACH), Austrian Academy of Sciences, ID-number: thra1248GRV0020a.

Five pilgrims journeying to the Holy Land (Thracian song)

Tasoula Papavasiliou sings a dance song from Mikro Bogialiki.

Watch: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XGqZR9vc5c8

VLACH has not published a timed transcription of this clip, so it plays without app subtitles.

Five pilgrims journeying to the Holy Land; performer: Tasoula Papavasiliou; Vanishing Languages and Cultural Heritage (VLACH), Austrian Academy of Sciences, ID-number: thra1248GRV0017a.

Greek-script lines: the app's rendering of VLACH's phonetic transcription (shown under each line as "VLACH transcription"); English: VLACH's translation. Each transcript row gives the Greek-script line, VLACH's transcription under it, and the English.

The northern accent today

In Thessaloniki, the dark **λ** and **σε λέω** are part of local identity, celebrated in comedy and songs. In Epirus, the polyphonic songs of Pogoni and Zagori, and in Thessaly and Roumeli the **κλέφτικα** songs of the mountain fighters, keep old northern pronunciations alive. Many northern families also remember Pontic, Cappadocian or Asia Minor grandparents, so a single village may hold several dialects at once.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

1. «Ου Νίκους» is the northern form of…
   (a) ο Νίκος (b) οι Νίκοι (c) του Νίκου
2. Who first divided Greek dialects into northern and southern?
   (a) Georgios Hatzidakis (b) Dionysios Solomos (c) Peter Trudgill
3. «Σε λέω» in the standard is…
   (a) Σου λέω (b) Σε λένε (c) Σας λέω
4. Which of these is semi-northern?
   (a) Skyros (b) Crete (c) Cyprus
5. «Εχτύπηκα» in Epirus means…
   (a) χτύπησα (b) χτυπήθηκα (c) θα χτυπήσω

Glossary

άδισι δένω — he tied (northern έδεσε)
άντζελες ο άντζελες — ο άγγελος (Skyros)
άφκι αφήνω — he left (northern άφησε)
έβαναμι βάζω — we put up (northern)
έβετ yes (Turkish evet)
έδιρι δέρνω — hit, beat (northern έδειρε)
έδουναν δίνω — they gave
έκουσα έκουσα — άκουσα, 'I heard'
έπερναν παίρνω — they took
έπιζαμι έπιζαμι — παίζαμε, 'we were playing'
έπιρναν παίρνω — they took
έρουμασταν έρχομαι — we came back (northern)
έτρουγαμι τρώω — we ate (northern τρώγαμε)
έτσας έτσι — so; έτσας κι έτσας, this and that
έφαγαμι έφαγαμι — φάγαμε, 'we ate'
έφαϊ τρώω — ate (northern έφαγε)
έφκιαναμι φτιάχνω — we made (northern φκιάνω)
έφκιαναν φτιάχνω — they made (northern φκιάνω)
έφυι φεύγω — left (northern έφυγε)
έχομέ δεν έχομέ τις — δεν τις έχουμε
ήνταν ήταν — they were
ήρθι έρχομαι — came (northern ήρθε)
ήρσι έρχομαι — came (northern ήρθε)
ίπιναν πίνω — they drank
ίρχισαν αρχίζω — they started
α θα — will (northern)
αγιασμέ η αγιασμέ — ο αγιασμός, 'holy water'
αγλήγουρα αγλήγουρα — γρήγορα, 'quickly'
αλεύρ αλεύρι — flour
αλιεύρι αλιεύρι — αλεύρι, 'flour'
ανθρωπιούν ανθρωπιούν — ανθρώπων (Lesbos)
απόψι απόψε — tonight
αραβδί αραβδί — ραβδί, 'stick'
αρβανίτ Αρβανίτης — Albanian
αφήκ αφήνω — (if) he leaves (northern)
αφεντάδοι αφεντάδοι — αφέντες, 'masters'
αχιλώνα αχιλώνα — χελώνα, 'tortoise'
αχλαδέα αχλαδέα — αχλαδιά, 'pear tree'
βγήκι βγαίνω — went out (northern βγήκε)
βιουλιά βιολιά — violins; the musicians
βρήκι βρίσκω — found (northern βρήκε)
γάμματα γάμματα — γράμματα, 'letters'
γένουνταν γίνομαι — happened, were done
γέντσ γίνομαι — you become (northern)
γηύρε γηύρε — βρήκε, 'found'
γιένας γιένας — ένας, 'one'
γιράκ γεράκι — hawk
γιτνιά γειτονιά — to the neighbour's
γιτουνιά γειτονιά — neighbourhood

γκουμπλάρ Γκουμπλάρ — Gublar, Greek Μυρσίνη, a village near Grevena

γουρούν γουρούνι — pig

γυρνούσαμι γυρνώ — we returned

δέδες δέδες — grandfather (from Turkish dede)

δκός δκός — δικός, 'own'

δλεβ' δλεβ' — δουλεύει, 'works'

είνι είναι — is, are

είντα είντα — τι, 'what'

εκάθουμασταν κάθομαι — we sat (northern)

εκάνανα εκάνανα — έκαναν, 'they did'

εμ εμ — but, well (from Turkish)

εχτύπηκα εχτύπηκα — χτύπησα, 'I hit'

ζγουρ lamb (VLACH translation)

θ'κόζ-ιμ ου θ'κόζ-ιμ — ο δικός μου

θέλτς θέλτς — θέλεις, 'you want'

θκο δικό — own; θκο μ', my own

θκός θκός — δικός, 'own'

ιγώ εγώ — I (northern: unstressed ε → ι)

ιδώ εδώ — here

ικεί εκεί — there

Ιλιέν' Ιλιέν' — Ελένη

κάτσι κάθομαι — stay (northern κάτσε)

καήκαταν καήκαταν — καήκατε, 'you got burned'

καουά καουά — καλά, 'well'

κιαφέτια clothes (VLACH translation)

κιμπάπ κεμπάπ — kebab

κλέφτικα κλέφτικα — songs of the klephts (mountain fighters)

κμήθκι κοιμάμαι — he slept (northern κοιμήθηκε)

κμήσ κοιμάμαι — sleep! (northern κοιμήσου)

κουμβόι group, procession (VLACH translation)

κουμπσίσα κουμπσίσα — neighbour, a woman next door (from Turkish komşu)

κουρ'τσέλ' κουρ'τσέλ' — κοριτσάκι, 'little girl'

κουρ'τσούλ' κουρ'τσούλ' — κοριτσάκι, 'little girl'

κουσάρα κουσάρα — hen with chicks

κουσάρια κουσάρα — hen with chicks

κρες κλαίω — you cry (as transcribed)

Λάμπ' στ' Λάμπ' — στου Λάμπου

λαγοί απ' τ'ς λαγοί — των λαγών, 'of the hares'

λαλούσαν λαλώ — they played (music)

Λαμπιργιά Λαμπιργιά — Λαμπρή, 'Easter'

λε λέει — he/she says

μέλτσα μέλτσα — μέλισσα, 'bee'

μι με — with; me (northern: ε → ι)

μουλουγούσι μολογώ — he used to tell (northern: ο → ου, final ε → ι)

μουρσαλί Μουρσαλί — Mursallı, the village in Turkey

μουσακάν μουσακάς — moussaka

μπακλαβάν μπακλαβάς — baklava

μπαϊράκ μπαϊράκι — flag; here the wedding flag (from Turkish bayrak)

μπιρέκια μπουρέκι — börek, filled pastry

μυλουνάς μυλωνάς — miller

μύλ' τ'ς μύλ' — τους μύλους, 'the mills'

μύλου μύλος — mill (northern ο → ου)

μύλους μύλος — miller, the man at the mill

ν την — the (northern ν' before a noun)

Νίκους Νίκους — Νίκος

νταβετλής guest, invited (from Turkish davetli)

ντουν ντουν — των (Lesbos)

νύφ νύφη — bride

νύφις νύφη — brides

νύφς νύφη — bride

ξύπνισι ξυπνώ — he woke up (northern ξύπνησε)

ου ου — ο (northern article); or του

Ου ου — ο (northern article)

ούλου όλος — all

πάιναμι πηγαίνω — we went, we took (northern)

πάιναν πηγαίνω — they went (northern)

πάνου πάω — I go (northern)

πάρου παίρνω — I take (northern πάρω)

πάρουμι παίρνω — we take

πέρναν παίρνω — they took

πέρουν παίρνω — they take

πέφτ Πέμπτη — Thursday

πήαμ πηγαίνω — we went

πήγι πήγι — πήγε, 'went'

πίτις πίτα — pies

παίξ παίζω — to play

παλαμαρέ̱α παλαμαρέ̱α — παλαμαριά, 'hawser'

παππούς παππούς — grandfather

παρ παίρνω — (may) take

πατέραζ-ουμ ου πατέραζ-ουμ — ο πατέρας μου

πηγάδ' πηγάδ' — πηγάδι, 'well'

πιδί παιδί — child

πιδούδ' πιδούδ' — παιδάκι, 'little child'

πικρούτ̆κος πικρούτ̆κος — πικρούτσικος, 'a bit bitter'

πλάου πλάου — πουλάω, 'sell'

πλια πουλιά — chicks (northern drops unstressed ου)

πουδάρ ποδάρι — leg, foot

πράσα πράσο — leeks

ρα ρε — hey (form of address)

ριζ ρύζι — rice

ρουμνιός Ρωμιός — a (Christian) Greek

ρουμνός Ρωμιός — a (Christian) Greek
ρωτήξω ρωτήξω — ρωτήσω, 'ask'
ὅήμιρα ὅήμιρα — σήμερα, 'today'
ὅτάρ' ὅτάρ' — σιτάρι, 'wheat'
σάβατου Σάββατο — Saturday
σαχίν σαχίν — falcon, hawk (from Turkish şahin)
σι σε — you (northern)
σκλι σκλι — σκυλί, 'dog'
σπίτ σπίτι — house, home
στου στου — στο
στόχ'σα στόχ'σα — ξέχασα, 'I forgot'
τήρα τηράω — look after, watch
ταχνά ταχιά — in the morning
τουν τον — him
Τουρκίγια Τουρκίγια — Τουρκία
τρίγια τρίγια — τρία, 'three'
τραγ'δώ τραγ'δώ — τραγουδάω, 'sing'
τρώγαμαν τρώγαμαν — τρώγαμε, 'we were eating'
τσ της, τους — her, their (northern)
τὅίχλα τὅίχλα — τσίχλα, 'thrush; chewing gum'
τσαι τσαι — και, 'and'
τσουρβάν soup (from Turkish çorba)
τσουτσανός τσουτσανός — boy (VLACH translation)
φαγιά φαγητό — dishes, food
φιγγάρ' φιγγάρ' — φεγγάρι, 'moon'
φτο φτο — βουτώ, φυτό, φτύνω or βοηθώ
φύγου φεύγω — I leave (northern φύγω)
χάλιβι χαλεύω — he wanted (northern)
Χάρ' τ' Χάρ' — του Χάρου, 'of Charon (death)'
χέρ' χέρ' — χέρι, 'hand'
χαμλός χαμλός — χαμηλός, 'low'
χαμπλός χαμπλός — χαμηλός, 'low'
χαρά χαρά — joy; here the wedding
χαραΐ χαραυγή — dawn
χιρνούσι began (VLACH translation)
χουράφ' χουράφ' — χωράφι, 'field'
χουριά χωριό — villages
χουριό χωριό — village
χουσαβέρ then (VLACH translation)
χόριβναν χορεύω — they danced (northern)
ψουμί ψωμί — bread; a meal
όξου έξω — out
όπιους όποιος — whoever
όφαϊ τρώω — ate (northern έφαγε)
ύστιρα ύστερα — later, then

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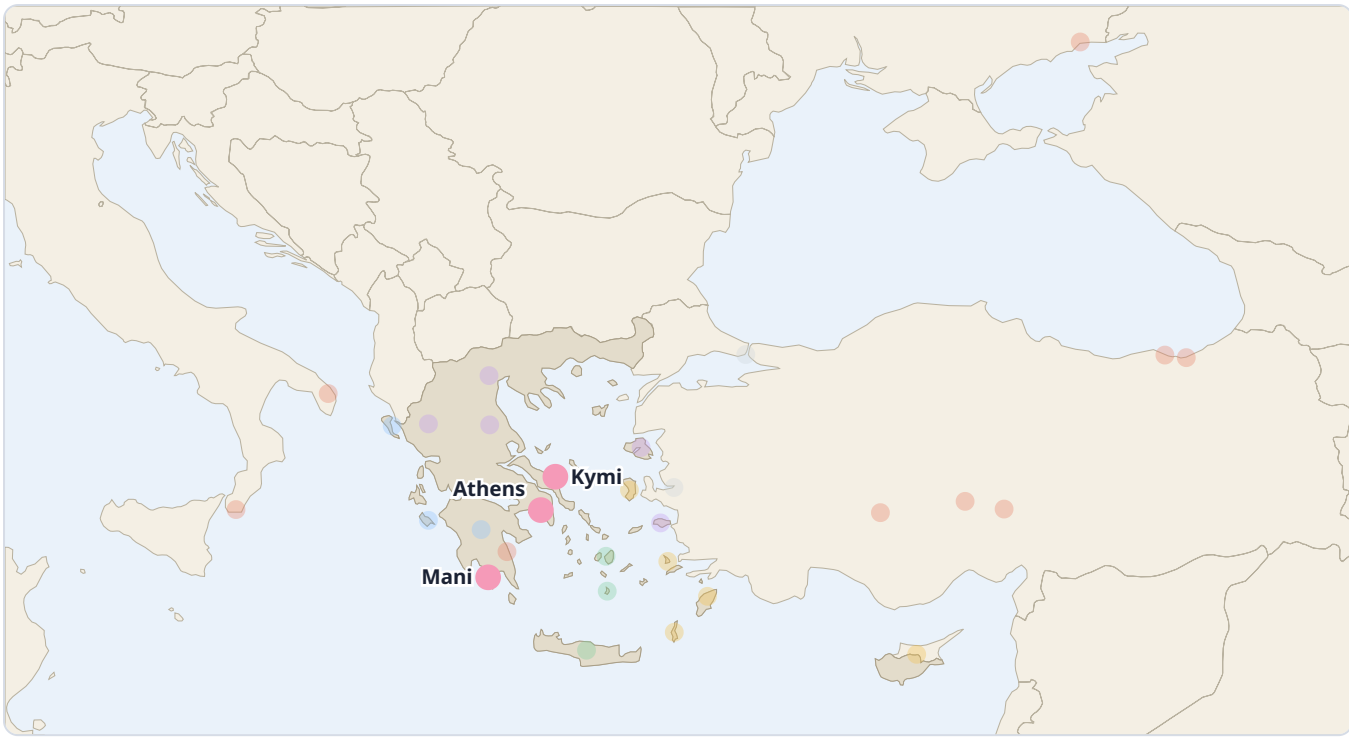
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Παλαιά αθηναϊκά, Κύμη, Μέγαρα, Αίγινα και Μάνη

Old Athenian and Mani: the «ου» dialects that were cut apart

Before 1834, when Athens became the capital, Athenians did not say **ξύλο** but **ξούλο**, and they called a woman **γιουναίκα**. The same [u] for ancient **υ** was heard in Aegina, Megara, Kymi in Euboea, in the Mani peninsula and in Tsakonian. These scattered places are the survivors of a once-continuous Greek dialect area of the south-eastern mainland. In the late Middle Ages, Albanian-speaking Arvanites settled most of Attica, Boeotia, southern Euboea and the Argolid, and the old Greek speech survived only in islands of Greek within an Arvanite countryside. Then the new capital drew Greeks from everywhere, and Old Athenian vanished within a few generations, the most dramatic case of dialect death in modern Greek history.

WHERE	**Old Athens**, **Aegina** and **Megara** (one group in Trudgill's classification), **Kymi** in central Euboea (a group of its own), and the **Mani** peninsula in the southern Peloponnese.
SHARED FEATURE	Ancient **υ** and **οι** pronounced [u], not [i]: **σούκα** for σύκα, **σου** for συ. Tsakonian shares it.
WHY SCATTERED	Greek-speaking enclaves left after Arvanite (Albanian-speaking) settlement in the 14th–15th centuries.
END	Old Athenian and the Aegina dialect died out in the 19th century, after Athens became the capital (1834). Kymi, Megara and Mani declined in the 20th.
AEGINA	Its dialect is partly due to Athenians who settled there after the Venetian siege of Athens in 1688.



How one dialect became five fragments · Ιστορία

Byzantine era
A Greek dialect area with **υ** = [u] probably stretches from Attica and Euboea to the Peloponnese. Ancient **υ** was still pronounced [y] into the 10th century, so this is a conservative pronunciation, not a later change.

1204–1456
Frankish and Catalan dukes rule Athens, Florentines after them; the city is small.

14th–15th c.
Albanian-speaking **Arvanites** settle in large numbers in Attica, Boeotia, Megaris, southern Euboea and the Argolid. Greek survives in Athens, Kymi, Aegina, Megara and the isolated Mani.

1456–1833
Ottoman Athens is a small town. In 1687 the Venetians besiege it and a shell blows up the Parthenon; when they withdraw in 1688, many Athenians flee to Aegina and Salamis.

1834
Athens becomes the capital of Greece. Officials, merchants and refugees from the Peloponnese, the islands, Epirus and Constantinople pour in. Within a generation or two, Old Athenian is replaced by a new mixed urban speech.

20th c.
Kymi, Megara and Mani lose most of their speakers to emigration and schooling.

Old Athens, Aegina, Megara and Kymi: sounds · Φωνολογία

Feature	Old Athenian group	Standard
υ and **οι** as [u]	**Κούμη** [kúmi], **σούκα**, **σου**, **βούτουρο**, **γιουναίκα**, **άχουρα**	Κύμη, σύκα, συ, βούτυρο, γυναίκα, άχυρα
κ before **ε, ι** as [tʃ]	**τ̆σουλιά**, **στ̆σούλος**, **βάρτ̆σες**	κοιλιά, σκύλος, βάρκες
Sibilants not palatalised	**δροσά**, **εκκλησά**, **νησά**, **πλούσος**, **κερασά**	δροσιά, εκκλησιά, νησιά, πλούσιος, κερασιά
No synizesis: **ι, ε** + vowel kept as two syllables	**γραία**, **παιδία**, **φωτία**, **γροθία**, **σταλέα**	γριά, παιδιά, φωτιά, γροθιά, σταλιά
μπ, ντ, γκ without the nasal	[b, d, g]	[mb, nd, ŋg]

Look at **γροθία** and **φωτία**. These are the older pronunciations; the standard **γροθιά**, **φωτιά** come from merging the two vowels into one syllable (synizesis). Trudgill notes that Kymi has softened, palatal **κ** rather than full [tʃ], one reason he puts it in a group of its own.

Grammar · Μορφολογία

Feature	Old Athenian group	Standard
Active aorist in **-κα**	**έλυκα**, **καβάληκα**, **άκουκα**, **έβρακα**, **αγόρακα**	έλυσα, καβάλησα, άκουσα, βρήκα, αγόρασα
Passive aorist in **-να**, always with augment	**εστάθηνα**, **ελύθηνα**, **ελούστηνα**, **εγδύθηνα**	στάθηκα, λύθηκα, λούστηκα, γδύθηκα
'what', 'why'	**ντα**, **γιάντα**	τι, γιατί

These features link the Old Athenian group to the dialects of the southern Aegean, not to the Peloponnese next door. Browning admits that we cannot yet explain where they came from.

Words · Λεξιλόγιο

Word	Where	Meaning (standard)
γλέφαρο	Athens	forehead (κούτελο)
δράμη	Athens	running (τρέξιμο)
μερμιρία	Athens	fear (φόβος)
συγκούρταλος	Athens	with all one's family and baggage
αλόχτερας	Aegina	rooster (κόκορας)
νυχτορεύω	Aegina	work through the night
παλεθύρι	Aegina	window (παράθυρο)
αχτίμωτο	Aegina	priceless (πολύτιμο)
αμπωνέ	Aegina	if perhaps (αν ίσως)
λαλούσα	Kymi	voice (φωνή)
δρέμω	Kymi	run (τρέχω)
βάσσω	Kymi	bark (γαβγίζω)
πλέος	Megara	any more (πια)
γλέπω	Megara	see (βλέπω)
έξυμνος	Megara	clever (έξυπνος)
λειδινό	Megara	late afternoon (δειλινό)
σκορπαίος	Megara	scorpion (σκορπιός)
μανάφης	Megara	greengrocer (μανάβης)

Δρέμω and **δράμη** keep the root of ancient **δραμεῖν** 'to run', which survives in the standard only in learned words such as **δρόμος** and **δρομέας**.

Mani: the tower dialect · Μανιάτικα

The Mani, the middle finger of the southern Peloponnese, was never fully controlled by Franks or Ottomans. Its clans lived in stone towers, fought vendettas, and in 1821 were among the first to rise. The Maniot dialect shares the [u] for ancient **υ** with Old Athenian and Tsakonian (**ξούλο** 'wood'), and, like Cretan, it softens **κ, γ, χ** before **ε, ι** to [tɕ, dʑ, ɕ]. Like Kythera, it avoids synizesis. Even family names tell the region: they typically end in **-έας** in Outer Mani and in **-άκος** or, more rarely, **-όγγονας** in Inner (Mesa) Mani.

- In 1675–76 about 700 people from Vitylo in Mani left for Corsica, settling first at Paomia and later at **Cargèse**, where Greek was spoken into the 20th century.
- Maniot dialect material is scarce: there is no chapter on Mani in the Portal for the Greek Language, and most descriptions are old. Treat details with care.

Moirologia: songs for the dead

Mani is famous for its **μοιρολόγια**, improvised laments sung by women over the dead, in fifteen-syllable verse and old dialect forms. They were collected in the 19th and 20th centuries and are among the most powerful Greek folk poetry. Patrick Leigh Fermor's travel book «Mani» (1958) introduced the peninsula, its towers and its laments to readers abroad.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

56. How did Old Athenians pronounce «ξύλο»?
(a) ξούλο (b) ξίλο (c) ξέλο

57. Why are the Old Athenian, Kymi, Megara and Mani varieties scattered?
(a) Arvanite settlement divided a once-continuous area (b) They were founded by different ancient colonists (c) Each was brought by Byzantine monks

58. When did Old Athenian disappear?
(a) In the 19th century, after Athens became the capital (b) In the Byzantine period (c) After the 1923 population exchange

59. «Εστάθηνα» corresponds to…
(a) στάθηκα (b) σταθήκαμε (c) θα σταθώ

Glossary

άκουκα άκουκα — άκουσα, 'I heard'
άχουρα άχουρα — άχυρα, 'straw'
έβρακα έβρακα — βρήκα, 'I found'
έλυκα έλυκα — έλυσα, 'I untied'
έξυμνος έξυμνος — έξυπνος, 'clever'
αγόρακα αγόρακα — αγόρασα, 'I bought'
αλόχτερας αλόχτερας — κόκορας, 'rooster'
αμπωνέ αμπωνέ — αν ίσως, 'if perhaps'
αχτίμωτο αχτίμωτο — πολύτιμο, 'priceless'
βάρτσες βάρτσες — βάρκες, 'boats'
βάσσω βάσσω — γαβγίζω, 'bark'
βούτουρο βούτουρο — βούτυρο, 'butter'
γιάντα γιάντα — γιατί, 'why'
γιουναίκα γιουναίκα — γυναίκα, 'woman'
γλέπω γλέπω — βλέπω, 'see'
γλέφαρο γλέφαρο — κούτελο, 'forehead' (Old Athenian)
γραία γραία — γριά, 'old woman'
γροθία γροθία — γροθιά, 'fist'
δράμη δράμη — τρέξιμο, 'running'
δρέμω δρέμω — τρέχω, 'run'
δροσά δροσά — δροσιά, 'coolness'
εγδύθηνα εγδύθηνα — γδύθηκα, 'I undressed'
εκκλησά εκκλησά — εκκλησιά, 'church'
ελούστηνα ελούστηνα — λούστηκα, 'I washed my hair'
ελύθηνα ελύθηνα — λύθηκα, 'I was untied'
εστάθηνα εστάθηνα — στάθηκα, 'I stood'
καβάληκα καβάληκα — καβάλησα, 'I mounted'
κερασά κερασά — κερασιά, 'cherry tree'
Κούμη Κούμη — Κύμη (Euboea)
λαλούσα λαλούσα — φωνή, 'voice'
λειδινό λειδινό — δειλινό, 'late afternoon'
Μάνη Μάνη — the Mani peninsula
μανάφης μανάφης — μανάβης, 'greengrocer'
μερμιρία μερμιρία — φόβος, 'fear'
μοιρολόγια μοιρολόγια — laments for the dead
νησά νησά — νησιά, 'islands'
ντα ντα — τι, 'what'
νυχτορεύω νυχτορεύω — work at night
ξούλο ξούλο — ξύλο, 'wood'
παιδία παιδία — παιδιά, 'children'
παλεθύρι παλεθύρι — παράθυρο, 'window'
πλέος πλέος — πια, 'any more'
πλούσος πλούσος — πλούσιος, 'rich'
σκορπαίος σκορπαίος — σκορπιός, 'scorpion'
σου σου — συ, 'you' (Old Athenian); otherwise 'your, to you'
σούκα σούκα — σύκα, 'figs'
σταλέα σταλέα — σταλιά, 'drop'
στσούλος στσούλος — σκύλος, 'dog'
συγκούρταλος συγκούρταλος — with all one's family and baggage
τσουλιά τσουλιά — κοιλιά, 'belly'
φωτία φωτία — φωτιά, 'fire'

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Answer key

Λύσεις

Από την Κοινή στις διαλέκτους

1. (b) the Hellenistic Koine · Ancient dialects were almost all replaced by the Koine; modern dialects formed from it again in Byzantine times. Tsakonian (and possibly Italiot) are the exceptions.

2. (b) Tsakonian · Tsakonian keeps Doric traits such as α for Attic η (α μάτη) and the Laconian change of θ to σ.

3. (a) They were ruled by Latin powers, outside Byzantine learned culture · Under the Lusignans (Cyprus) and Venice (Crete), Greek had no imperial learned standard to follow, so legal texts, chronicles and poetry were written in local speech.

4. (b) Religion · Orthodox Christians went to Greece and Muslims to Turkey, whatever language they spoke.

5. (c) 1976 · Law 309/1976, after the fall of the junta; the monotonic system followed in 1982.

Ο χάρτης των διαλέκτων

6. (b) Macedonia or Thessaly · Raising unstressed ε, ο to ι, ου and dropping final ι are northern vocalism.

7. (b) υ pronounced [u] · ξούλο for ξύλο: a relic feature of areas cut apart by later Arvanite settlement.

8. (a) tsitakismos · κ before ε, ι > τσ: typical of the Cyclades.

9. (a) South-eastern (Cyprus, Rhodes, Karpathos…) · Trudgill's area 8 has all three.

Ποντιακά

10. (a) Ancient η is pronounced [e] · Everywhere else η became [i] (νύφη, κλέφτης); Pontic kept an older [e] in many words.

11. (a) Accusative for the indirect object · Pontic uses the accusative for all objects; the standard says είπα στον πατέρα / του είπα.

12. (a) In the Romeyka of the Trabzon valleys · Sitaridou's fieldwork documents forms like φαγίνι, κόψινι, used only in non-realised contexts.

13. (b) Ντο εν αούτο; · ντο 'what', εν 'is', αούτο 'this'.

14. (a) Crimea · Crimean Greeks were resettled north of the Sea of Azov after 1778.

Καππαδοκικά

15. (a) The Battle of Manzikert (1071) · The Seljuk conquest of central Anatolia followed it.

16. (a) loss of grammatical gender · A feminine noun takes the neuter article; in Ulağaç every noun does.

17. (a) Turkish vowel harmony · The ending copies the vowel quality of the Turkish stem (anla-, otur-).

18. (a) θύρα · Cappadocian θίρ / tír; the standard πόρτα comes from Italian.

19. (c) 2005 · Mark Janse and Dimitris Papazachariou found Mistiot speakers in central and northern Greece.

Τσακώνικα

20. (a) Laconian Doric · All other living dialects (except perhaps Italiot) come from the Koine.

21. (a) Long α where Attic has η · Doric μάτηρ vs Attic μήτηρ; the article α is also Doric (Attic ἡ).

22. (a) ένει φερήκχα · The present is 'be' + participle, and the participle agrees with the speaker's gender.

23. (a) ancient final -ς · Laconian rhotacism: πῶς > π'ούρ.

Κατωιταλικά: Γκρίκο και Γκρεκάνικο

24. (a) Latin · Its speakers are schooled in Italian; Greek script appears only in some publications.

25. (a) λανό 'wine-press' · It has Doric **α** (λανός) where Attic and the Koine have **η** (ληνός).

26. (a) I am talking · A progressive periphrasis modelled on Italian *sto parlando*.

27. (a) It uses an infinitive · Standard Greek lost the infinitive; Italiot keeps it after 'can'.

Κυπριακά

28. (a) The Koine · Arcadocypriot died out in Hellenistic times; Cypriot, like nearly all modern dialects, grew from the Koine.

29. (a) Εν ξέρω · **εν** negates the indicative, **μεν** the subjunctive.

30. (a) I will go · **έννα** is the Cypriot future particle, standard **θα**.

31. (a) καρδιά · Glide hardening turns the [j] of καρδιά into [c].

32. (a) Το γράφει · The standard puts weak pronouns before a finite verb.

Δωδεκανησιακά (και Χίος)

33. (a) ήρθα · In the Dodecanese **ρθ** hardens to **ρτ**.

34. (a) loss of β between vowels · πρόβατο → πρόατο: β, γ, δ drop between vowels.

35. (a) 1947–48 · After Italian rule from 1912 and wartime occupation.

36. (a) Cypriot · Trudgill puts Rhodes, Karpathos, Kos and Cyprus in one south-eastern group.

Κρητικά (και Κύθηρα, Σαντορίνη, Μήλος)

37. (a) I will go · Cretan forms its future with **θέλω** after the verb, a reversed form of medieval **θέλω να**.

38. (a) I don't know anything · **κατέχω** = 'know', **πράμα** = 'nothing' in Cretan.

39. (a) Venetian rule and the Cretan Renaissance · 16th–17th-century Venetian Crete produced Erotokritos, Erofili and other works.

40. (a) μάτια · τ before ι + vowel becomes θ.

41. (a) al-Hamidiyah in Syria · Descendants of Cretan Muslims who left between 1866 and 1897.

Κυκλαδίτικα

42. (a) ο γέρος · Many Cycladic islands drop **γ** at the start of words and between vowels.

43. (a) Latin rule under the Duchy of the Archipelago · Venetian and other Latin lords ruled the islands from 1207 to 1579, Tinos until 1715.

44. (a) Mykonos · Kontosopoulos and Trudgill both treat Mykonos as a group of its own.

45. (a) it is stressed on the fourth syllable from the end · Standard Greek stress cannot go further back than the antepenult.

Πελοποννησιακά και Επτανησιακά

46. (a) The similarity may come from Peloponnesian converging on Athenian usage · Pantelidis and others argue that the influence may have run from the standard to the dialect.

47. (a) I'm going to the village · Peloponnesian uses a bare accusative for destination.

48. (a) the genitive of νύχτα · Feminines in -α can form the genitive in **-ός**: νυχτός, μερός.

49. (a) Four centuries of Venetian rule · Corfu was Venetian from 1386 to 1797.

50. (a) Lefkada · Kontosopoulos groups Lefkada with Central Greece for this reason.

Βόρεια ιδιώματα

51. (a) ο Νίκος · Unstressed **ο** rises to **ου** in the article and in the ending.

52. (a) Georgios Hatzidakis · He noticed the different vowel systems.

53. (a) Σου λέω · Northern Greek uses the accusative for the indirect object.

54. (a) Skyros · Skyros, Mykonos, Kastoria and Lefkada drop some unstressed vowels but do not raise ε and ο.

55. (a) χτύπησα · Aorists in **-κα** instead of **-σα**.

Παλαιά αθηναϊκά, Κύμη, Μέγαρα, Αίγινα και Μάνη

56. (a) ξούλο · Ancient **υ** became [u] in the Old Athenian group, Mani and Tsakonian.

57. (a) Arvanite settlement divided a once-continuous area · Albanian-speaking settlers of the 14th–15th centuries filled most of the countryside between them.

58. (a) In the 19th century, after Athens became the capital · Newcomers from all over Greece outnumbered the old Athenians within a generation or two.

59. (a) στάθηκα · The Old Athenian group forms passive aorists in **-να**.

Sources and credits

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